

INTRODUCTION

Rosanna is a village girl born to a handsome sailor called Tarma and a beautiful performer called Jirmak. She was born in a village located in a dry land called Hikmid. Hikmid was two miles from the sea. Hikmid had been colonized by a very powerful, rich empire called Boparl, and the people of Hikmid were treated like war slaves, yet they were allowed a strange kind of freedom. Hikmidians were allowed to do whatever they wanted as long as they respected the law.

Boparl consisted of seven states: Kahli, Gorma, Tunera, Farisa, Hjortigar, Hakma, and the capital region. The king's most trusted ministers governed these six states, while the king Shirkisir, his wife Kumata, and his three concubines lived in the capital, Tumar. Tumar was located in the center of the empire. Tumar was a beautiful city where money flowed, businesses thrived, and gold miners searched for gold. Hikmid was within the state of Farisa, to the south of the capital. Rosana's father, Tarma, was a righteous man, the son of a fisherman named Irsha and a housekeeper named Luisa.

Rosana's mother, Jirmak, had a different beginning. She was abandoned by her parents at the doorstep of a pleasure house. She was found by Kapoor, the prostitute building owner. Kapoor, charmed by Jirmak's beauty, adopted Jirmak and raised her as her daughter. Jirmak was sent to school and trained in the art of dance and music. Kapoor raised Jirmak to carry herself with grace in high social status, harboring a secret hope that Jirmak would marry a rich man and move to a mansion in the capital with servants, and Jirmak would be able to provide for Kapoor in her old age. As Jirmak grew, her beauty became legendary. Men and women from all over the village would gather just to catch a glimpse of her dancing and singing. Jirmak grew more beautiful and elegant day by day. Though many suitors proposed, Kapoor rejected them all. She had big plans for her daughter's future.

● *THE ESCAPE AND MEETING*

One day early in the morning, just as the sun began to break, Jirmak attempted a desperate escape. Driven by the weight of her mother's obsession, she took a small boat to the sea, hoping to find a life of her own. While trying to sail on her little boat, a storm started, and the waves were unforgiving. Jirmak slipped and fell into the sea, and she didn't know how to swim.

Luckily, Tarma returned from a long night of fishing with his father, Irshi. Seeing the struggle, Tarma dove deep into the water to save Jirmak. When he brought her back to the sand, Jirmak was not breathing. He tried to revive her, but she remained still. In a final, desperate act, Tarma breathed his own air into her lungs. It worked, and she opened her eyes and screamed. As Jirmak looked into the eyes of her rescuer, they both fell deeply in love.

Jirmak started meeting Tarma in secret, and their love became deeper and deeper. Two years later, Tarma proposed to Jirmak. Jirmak joyfully accepted, but their happiness was met with a wall of gold and pride. Luisa, Tarma's mother, could not accept Jirmak's upbringing; she was greatly displeased and banned her son Tarma from seeing Jirmak. Kapoor, Jirmak's mother, in her greed for wealth, banned Jirmak from seeing Tarma or going outside alone.

Faced with the world that wanted to keep them apart, Tarma and Jirmak chose each other. They married in secret, a quiet vow between their two souls. When the truth came out, they were both cast out by the villagers and disowned by their family. Jirmak's mother found out and decided to disown her, and Luisa was displeased by her son's decision, so she decided to kick him out. With nothing but love and small savings, they built a small hut outside the village.

- ***THE BEGINNING: The Birth of Rosana***

To provide for their new life, Tarma chose to become a sailor. His days were spent navigating the waves, traveling to the capital to trade merchandise. Jirmak stayed behind on solid ground; her near-drowning experience had left her with a deep fear of the water. Instead, Jirmak leaned into the gifts she was raised with, and she became a renowned dancer and singer. She performed at a famous theater in the neighboring village. The couple found themselves living a successful and stable life. Yet, despite their success, their family still cut all contact with them.

- ***THE MEETING OF THE PROPHET***

One year later, while Jirmak was gathering supplies in the bustling market, she was approached by a figure of immense presence: a powerful prophet named Kafura.

Kafura looked deep into Jirmak's eyes and spoke a revelation that chilled her blood:

"You will give birth to the most beautiful woman in the entire world. But greatness comes with a price. Your daughter will face trials of immense pain and challenges that would break a common soul. Yet, she will rise as a powerful queen, the one destined to deliver your people from the grip of the colonizers and change the very course of the world."

Kafura's voice grew urgent. "Teach her everything you know, Jirmak. Do not hold back your skills, for she will need every ounce of your wisdom to survive the future that awaits her."

Fear gripped Jirmak. "What mother would wish for her child to suffer?" she cried out. "I want my daughter to have a happy, normal life free from pain and struggle. Please help me! How can I save my daughter from her destiny?"

Kafura looked at her with pity and resolve. "My dear daughter Jirmak, I have been watching you for a very long time; I know the depth of your sacrifice. But even the most powerful prophet cannot rewrite what God has spoken. It is impossible; as Esther, Ruth, and Deborah, she must walk this path. However, I can help you delay the prophecy."

As the prophet turned to leave, his final word lingered in the air like a vow: "I will return to visit you the moment the promised child is born."

- ***The Cost of The Prophecy***

Jirmak returned from the market with the prophet's words echoing in her mind like a drumbeat. She ran home to her loving husband and told him the good news of her pregnancy, but she kept the fire of that secret locked deep within her; she knew this was no ordinary child.

As time passed, Jirmak's physical body grew weak, and her pregnancy became visible to the villagers. The sea became restless, churning with fury no one had seen before, and strange natural disasters began to plague the land. As the months passed, the prophecy began to take a toll on her. Jirmak couldn't walk or leave her bed, and the air felt heavy with an omen they couldn't name. The villagers, growing in terror, began to point fingers at Jirmak's growing womb, calling her unborn child an evil seed, which turned into a threat to kill both the mother and the unborn child.

Tarma, seeing the danger, made the choice to stop working to protect and care for his family. Because they could not work and had nobody to support them, early in the morning in the cold, Tarma had to go to the sea to fish for food and desperately return before his wife woke up.

One gray, rainy morning, Jirmak dragged herself outside the hut, her body weak, waiting for her husband to return. Suddenly, a wave of deep labor pains struck her stomach. She collapsed into the mud and screamed in agony. The cruel villagers ignored her and walked away, leaving her alone in the rain.

When Tarma finally crested the hill on his way back, he heard Jirmak crying. He dropped his catch and ran to hold her, and realized that she was in labor. Realizing he could not afford any nurse or hospital, Tarma ran to his old friend and begged for help on his knees in the rain. Feeling sorry and remembering the old days, his friend had mercy and reached out to help.

Tarma's friend Kurita and his wife did not hesitate. They ran into the freezing rain, lifting Jirmak's limp body. Inside the hut, the reality of their poverty was laid bare: a muddy floor with a single mat and one knit blanket. The only light came from the candle flickering against the damp walls. Dishes sat forgotten on the left side of the entry as the room erupted into chaos.

"Put her on the floor, put her on the floor now!" Kurita's wife screamed. "Bring me water! I need a wiper! Jirmak, breathe deeply, you've got two lives!"

Jirmak was fading. "Please! Please Jirmak! I need you!"

"Push!" Jirmak screamed. "It hurts! It hurts! I can't, I can't!"

"I need you! I need you, wife!" Tarma cried out. "Please! Push! Push!"

Kurita's wife shouted, "She is losing too much blood, Tarma, I do not know if she is going to make it!"

"She will make it; she has to!"

"Wifey, you've got this! Push!!"

With a final, gagged breath, Jirmak gathered all her strength, and she gave one massive, bone-shattering push. The silence that followed was broken by the cry of the baby.

“It is a girl, it is a girl!”

She gave birth to a very gorgeous girl. "Thank you, God! We made it."

But the cost was absolute. The labor cost Jirmak her health and ability to conceive. Jirmak would never conceive or do hard labor again.

As the child was wrapped in the knit blanket and handed to Jirmak and her husband, the room went cold.

“What is this?” Tarma asked. “Where did you see a foreign man behind my back, Jirmak? Everyone in the village looked the same; everyone in the village had dark and brown hair with tan skin and brown eyes. She has blue eyes, blue hair like the sea, and tan glowing skin.”

Jirmak sat up and was about to answer her husband, but was interrupted by someone yelling outside: “Misfortune and blessing have come! Misfortune and blessing have come!”

The stranger was walking toward Tarma's house. Tarma: “Who is yelling such things in my land?!”

THE DECLARATION OF THE PROPHECY: Evil or Blessing?

Tarma: “Who is yelling such things in my land?”

Prophet Kafura: “It is I, Prophet Kafura. God has sent me to your house to tell you the future of your daughter.”

Tarma: *(Whispering to himself, his eyes darting to the blue-haired child)* “I am not even sure if she is mine...”

(As the prophet interrupts him)

Prophet Kafura: *(Interrupting with a voice of thunder)* “My dear son Tarma, son of Irsha and Luisa. Do not be fooled by appearance and temptation! Fear not! That little girl is your daughter. She is of your blood and spirit.”

Villagers: *(Screaming as they run toward him to take his blessing)* “It is the Prophet Kafura!”

Villagers: “The prophet is here! Prophet! Prophet! Welcome to our humble village; we are honored to have you as our guest. Please give us your blessing!”

Prophet Kafura: *(His face stern and disappointed, refusing to enter their homes)* “No, my children. I am not here to stay, nor am I here to be pleased by your hospitality. I have come on a mission, and I am not allowed to linger. Where is Jirmak?”

The crowd hissed at the name of the woman they had abandoned and tormented.

Villagers: “Jirmak! That prostitute from the pleasure house! We knew you were a righteous prophet; permit us to burn this witch and her demon.”

Others whispered, “What mission could a holy prophet have with such a thing?”

The door of the hut opened. Jirmak appeared, leaning heavily on the doorframe, her body still trembling from the labor, but her spirit standing tall with pride. In her arms, she held the sea-blue miracle wrapped in a knit blanket.

Jirmak: *(Her voice a raspy whisper of relief)* “Prophet! Prophet...”

Prophet Kafura: *(Looking at her with deep, tearful eyes)* “Oh, I cry for you, Jirmak. I cry for your misery, I cry for your pain!”

Prophet Kafura: “I cry for your suffering. Cry, Jirmak, cry, my daughter. For misery has come to your door, but fear not, smile at my daughter. No matter how long the night is, the day always comes. Let me hold her!”

Villagers: *(Whispering)* “What?!”

Jirmak, with her trembling hands, placed the baby into Kafura's arms and gave the baby to the prophet.

Prophet Kafura: “Indeed, it is her: blue eyes, hair like her mother the sea, skin that glows like the sun, and lips red as blood. You will be named Rosanna! Rosanna, the rising sun. Rosanna, the promised child. Rosanna will be a free slave, but hear me: Rosanna will be taken away, Rosanna will cross the sea, the sea will cry for her, she will be beaten, she will be taken advantage of, she will be homeless, she will have no family, her home will be burned...”

A gasp went through the villagers, but the prophet's voice only grew stronger.

Villagers: *(Whispering)* “We were right, she is a cursed child.”

Prophet Kafura: “She will be a sword in God's hand to bring justice and save the nation. Queen, Empress Rosanna.”

Villagers: *(Whispering in fear)* “We were right... She is a cursed child. Swords only bring blood.”

Tarma: *(His voice trembling with awe)* “My daughter? The promised child? How is that possible?”

Jirmak: *(Clutching the baby to her chest, her eyes wide open with terror)* “No! No! NO! Not my daughter! I won't let them! I will not let her take her away from me...! No! Nooo!”

Villagers: *(Sneering toward the hut)* “Why, prophet? Why the daughter of a prostitute? We should have killed them earlier and had God choose us.”

Tarma: *(Exploded with a roar of anger)* “My wife is not a prostitute!”

He bowed down and carried his wife out of the mud. "Jirmak! You've got me! I am here! I will protect our daughter. Nothing will happen to her! I promise."

Prophet Kafura: *(Looking at them with heavy divine sadness)* "Tarma, you cannot change destiny. This is her destiny. God has spoken. The God of Israel never fails."

Jirmak: *(Struggling to stand as she cries in the rain)* "Prophet, help me! Help my family! Help my daughter! As her mother, I cannot see her in such pain; I cannot handle it. Please, I beg you... hear the cry of a poor, sick woman!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Gently handing the baby to Tarma and taking hold of Jirmak's trembling hands)* "Woman, even I, the prophet, cannot go against God's will, but I can stand with you."

Villagers: *(Breaking into a chaotic roar, interrupting the holy man)* "They should all be kicked out of our village!! His family will only bring misfortune; what are we waiting for?! Let gooo!"
(Running toward Jirmak and Tarma to kill them)

Prophet Kafura: "Stopppppp!!!!!!!"

The world responded. A powerful wind rose, and the sea erupted. Waves, tsunamis, and water tornadoes stood in the air to defend Rosanna. The prophet stood firm to defend Rosanna, his hair whipping in the wind as he held his staff.

Prophet Kafura: "You shall do no more! You shall not hurt Rosanna nor her family! This girl is the future QUEEN, and she shall be treated as such from this moment."

Villagers: *(Lying down in the mud in terror as the sea calmed and the wind stopped)* "We promise to never hurt the Queen and her family."

Jirmak: "It's true, my daughter is truly the promised child. Prophet! Why don't you take her away and raise her? You can teach her everything she needs for the future to come!"

Prophet Kafura: "That is not God's will. Rosanna will be raised here. You, Jirmak, will be the one to teach her what she needs to succeed; have faith."

THE BEGINNING OF ROSANNA'S JOURNEY_season 1

The villagers stood quiet, in shame.

Prophet Kafura: "Why do you all look sad? Why is shame written on your face?"

Jirmak: "Prophet! Help me! I want my daughter to have a different life than what I had. I want her to be happy. I do not want my beloved Rosanna to sit and complain about her future. I want to give her memories that will change a stormy day into a bright, warm sun." *(As tears fall out)*

Prophet Kafura: *(Deep breath)* "Jirmak, do you want to know your real parents?"

Jirmak: "I am a child of the wind. No one ever wanted me, but I met a man who gave me a reason to be, and now I have a beautiful daughter. It is all I need, a family of my own, but fate had another surprise for me."

Chief Leader: *(Interrupted Jirmak)* "We made sure to give you a hard time. Now I know that I have wronged you, we have wronged you, and it was wrong for me to keep a rage over your rejection of my son's marriage proposal."

Villagers: *(Whisper)* "Yes, we are very sorry."

Tarma: *(With a smile)* "It is ok! We are a family. Well, I just hope that my parents were here with me, but it's all good. I will be the father she deserves, and my house is always open for you all."

Jirmak: *(Smiles)* "Hopefully the villagers will be kinder to our daughter."

Villagers: *(Look down in shame and embarrassment)*

Prophet Kafura: "I will put a spell on Rosanna. I will turn her blue hair into black, her blue eyes into brown, and her glowing skin into non-glowing."

He holds Rosanna in his arms, lifts her to the sky, and cries out to God. Suddenly, white thunder erupts across the air, striking down until it touches the water with a sharp echoing sound. As the vibration settles and a single teardrop touches Rosanna, her hair changes into black, her blue eyes into brown, and her skin into non-glowing.

The Secret

Jirmak: "OMG! Thank you! Thank you, Prophet." *(As the prophet puts Rosana in her mother's arms, she smiles and smiles)*

Tarma: "She just looks just like you." *(He gets close to his family)*

Jirmak: "Ahahaha! No, she got your nose and eyes. OMG, look at her little heart-shaped lips!"

Tarma: "Yes! That's ours, ahahaha. Our Rosanna. Look at her tiny cute fingers! She is so adorable!"

Jirmak: "Hey! You are not complimenting me." *(Makes a cute face)*

Tarma: "Okay, my jealous wife. You are so adorable too, ahahah." *(They hug and stare at their daughter)*

Prophet Kafura: "Okay, okay, okay, I am not done... God's word will come to pass. What I did was delay the prophecy. The spell will be broken when she is 8 years old, when she dives deep into the sea to save the life of the evil seed of the land." *(As he disappears)* "I will be watching you."

Jirmak: (*Whisper in her heart*) "That will never happen." "Tarma, promise me you will never take Rosanna to the sea or lake?"

Tarma: "I promise, I will keep you safe, and our beloved daughter too. Look to the sky: I always wanted a family, and now I have one; I will never lose it." (*Whispering in his heart: Rosanna*)

Chief: "Well, it is time to party! We have a new member in the village!"

Villagers: "Yeah!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

The villagers party from day to night. Rosanna's birth ceremony was done, and her parents were welcomed back to the community.

Chief Leader: "I give this necklace to her; it will keep her safe and remind her of home."

Rosanna's Parents: "Thank you, chief." (*As they put the necklace around her neck*)

Villagers: (*Applaud*)

The party came to an end. Jirmak reconciled with her mother, but Tarma's parents were nowhere to be found. Jirmak, Tarma, and Rosanna were adopted by the chief leader and moved into his house.

The house was full of servants, giving Jirmak plenty of time to spend with her daughter. She would spend her time telling her stories and singing her songs.

Tarma would go fishing with the chief's son, Srikaris. He would come back at night and tell Rosanna and his wife the stories of the sea, and bring plenty of goods from different regions.

Every night, when Rosanna was asleep, Jirmak would bring her pipa to her side and play while singing in her language, and her husband would accompany her on his flute.

Lyrics:

The bird will be taken away when her wings start to grow.

Rosanna, the bird will leave the dry land.

Take her away through the sea.

Rosanna, the bird will go into an unknown land.

In the cage where she will stay.

Rosanna, Rosanna, Rosanna.

Cry for the weak, sad for the powerless.

We are linked by fate, and destiny has chosen us.

Rosanna, Rosanna, Rosanna.

Rosanna, go forward.

When dawn comes, do not be scared; the sun will rise again.

Rosanna, lift your head high.

The morning will come, and all your tears will be wiped away.

Rosanna, mommy is waiting for you to come home.

Rosanna, you are not alone; we love you.

Rosanna, Rosanna, Rosanna.

Rosanna, usilie; Mungu yu pamoja nawe. Rosanna eh.

Rosanna, usiogope kutakapo pambazuka. Jua litachomoza tena, na nuru yako itang'aa.

Rosanna, usilie lie Mungu yu pamoja nawe. Rosanna eh.

Rosanna, usiogope kutakapo pambazuka. Jua litachomoza tena, na nuru yako itang'aa.

Rosanna started growing up. She was smart and a fast learner, but she was not allowed to leave the house without a guard or her mother. Because of this, she had a short temper. Rosanna was raised like a princess, but her mother did not allow her to go to school. She decided to teach Rosanna the arts of cultural dance and music.

Rosanna would spend her days practicing and learning the proper ways of a princess. At night, she would go to the top of the roof and watch the waves, singing to the blue sea and dancing under the stars.

Rosanna: *(Taking a deep breath)* “I wonder what it is like to go outside? I have become a bird locked in a cage. I try to keep my wings alive, but the more I try, the more my true nature comes out. The sky looks far because it is far. The pain in my heart cannot be understood; sometimes I don't even understand how ironic it is.”

When her father was finished with work, he would join her and ask her about her day. He would tell her the stories of the sea and the people he met. One night, when her father joined her, Rosanna asked him:

Rosanna: “Dad!”

Tarma: “Yes... I know, right? I got plenty of stories to tell you, and I brought you a lot of presents! You don't believe me, I'll tell you what happened when I was—”

Rosanna: *(Interrupted)* “No, no, it is not that! I want to know why I am not allowed to go outside? Why can I not play in the sea like other kids? Why do I spend all day learning these stupid dances? I do not even like dancing; I am tired of singing the same old stupid songs! Dad, do you know what Jack said?”

Tarma: “What did he say? Wait... for what?! Who is Jack?”

Rosanna: “Oh... I am feeling tired... I am going to sleep!” *(She runs away down from the rooftop to her bed)*

Tarma: “My child has grown! Wait, what? What if he is... Rosanna! Come here!!” *(As he follows her to her room)* “Rosanna! Who is Jack? Where did you meet him? And why is your hair not blue? You still have brown eyes! How did you get to the sea? Does your mom know?” *(He begins to freak out)*

Rosanna: “What? Dad, it is just colors from the village. A servant was playing with paints, and I joined them and asked them to color my hair blue, ahahah. You are saying funny stuff, daddy, ahahaha! Why would my hair turn blue? Dad, why am I not allowed to go see the sea?”

Tarma: “Whatever decisions your mom made for you, it is for your good. She is suffering a lot.”

Rosanna: “Really, huh? She is bossy.”

Tarma: “Yes, that's your mom for you, ahahaha.”

Rosanna: “Now, I wonder why you married her. Look, I just want to live like other kids. If it weren't for Jack, my life would be pretty miserable, and his drawings are amazing.” *(Smiles)*

Tarma: “Oh yeah, who is Jack?”

Rosanna: “Promise you won't tell mom!”

Tarma: “Pinky promise!”

Rosanna: “With a mouth seal?”

Tarma: "With a mouth seal."

Rosanna: "He is the son of one of our servants, and guess what..." *(Whispers)* "He is very cute."

Tarma: "Ahahaha, you're only seven years old, haha. Do you like him?"

Rosanna: *(Shyly)* "It is not like that... let's just say it is a crush. A little tiny crush, but I want to marry him one day." *(She covers herself with a blanket, feeling embarrassed)*

Tarma: "You cannot marry him, ahahaha!"

Rosanna: "Why not? Daddy... Can I marry him please...?" *(Cute eyes)*

Tarma: "No, he is just a servant, and you are my princess. It is not like it is up to me." *(He whispers)*

Rosanna: "Huh? What did you say?"

Tarma: "Nothing! A princess is a princess, and a servant is a servant. I do not think you should talk to a servant!" *(He says it with pride, trying to sound firm)*

Rosanna: "Then I do not want to be a princess." *(A long pause)* "I want to be free."

Tarma: "We just want to keep you safe." *(Smiles)*

Rosanna: "From what? Safe from what?! Seriously!"

The sound of footsteps coming toward the door.

Rosanna: "Mom is coming! OMG..."

Tarma: "Come on! Go to bed!... Here, get under the blanket, be fast!"

(The door opens)

Jirmak: "Rosanna, are you still...? Tarma, you're here?"

Tarma: "Oh yeah, I just got here. I wanted to see her sleep."

Jirmak: "Yeah! She is just so adorable." *(She walks toward the bed)*

Tarma: "Oh yeah, and I miss you." *(He walks toward his wife and hugs her)* "Let's just let her rest and go have some fun." *(He walks with her out of the room)*

They left the room, walking together toward the living room. Jirmak turned on the lamp, and Tarma took a seat.

Tarma: "How are you?"

Jirmak: "I am doing well. How was your trip today? I hope you found something interesting other than spending time with your family."

Tarma: "Not again! You know I need to work!"

Jirmak: "Really? Do you? We have everything here!"

Tarma: "Jirmak, this is not our house. What do you want me to do? Sit at home and dance all day?"

Jirmak: "Well, yeah! At least you will spend some time with your daughter!! I am very ill; how do you expect me to take care of her and this house alone?"

Tarma: "There are billions of servants in this house! The only thing you are doing is playing with Rosanna, who is not even happy!"

Jirmak: "Do you think taking care of a kid is easy?"

Tarma: "Well, if you could make her happy, I am sure it would be an easy job!"

Jirmak: "You are saying I'm the reason my daughter is unhappy?" *(She started coughing and having a hard time breathing)* "You are so selfish! I am stuck here with an incurable illness while you're going out having fun!" *(More coughing)*

Tarma: "Jirmak!"

Jirmak: *(Coughing and falling)* "You... y...yo...you..." *(Passes out)*

Tarma: "Jirmak!!!!!!"

Tarma carries his wife to their room and lays her in bed. It was close to midnight, and no doctor was available to treat Jirmak. When the chief leader heard the news, he came down to treat his adoptive daughter with herbs. The herbs relieved Jirmak's pain, and the fever went down. Jirmak slept for the entire night, and her husband stayed up to watch her.

Early in the morning, the doctor of the village came to check up on Jirmak, as ordered by the chief leader.

Servant: *(Yelling)* "The doctor is here!"

Tarma: "Finally, good morning, doctor!" *(As he walks toward the door)*

Doctor: "Good morning! Where is the patient?"

Tarma: "Oh sure, please follow me!" *(He leads the way to the room)* "Jirmak! You're awake! Thank God, I was so worried about you." *(He sits down beside her and holds her hand)* "The doctor is here; everything will be okay."

Doctor: "Excuse me, mister, I need to perform an examination."

Tarma: "Sorry... please go ahead!"

Jirmak: "Is Rosanna awake?"

Tarma: "She is still sleeping; do not worry about her. Just get better."

Jirmak: "But today is—"

Doctor: (*Interrupting*) "I am done!"

Doctor: "I am done!" (*As he interrupts them again*)

Tarma: "What is the news? Will she get better? What's wrong with her? Is it serious?"

Doctor: "No, it is not serious, and whatever you gave her at night saved her life. In her condition, she should not be allowed to overwork herself. Her illness is not a joke, and someone should be with her all the time!"

Tarma: "I understand, doctor, I will be careful." (*Ashamed look*)

Doctor: "I will give you a prescription. The medicine will help her recover her strength, but not heal her. You can take a look at the note and come buy the medicine at my store."

Tarma: "Understood, I will be careful, doctor. Let me walk you out." (*He looks down in shame, then walks out with the doctor before returning back to the room*) "Hello, baby, how are you feeling now?"

Jirmak: "I am okay, today is Rosanna's..."

Rosanna: (*Running into the room, smiling*) "Mom, it is my birthday! Mom? You look sick, are you okay?"

Jirmak: (*Forcing a smile*) "Yes, I just woke up. That's why."

Rosanna: "What are we going to do today?! I am so excited, I want to go outside. Jack told me that the villagers are holding a festival for me. Can I go see it, please? We can go together like a family!"

Tarma: "Your mom is very tired; I do not think she can even stand up! How about you spend your birthday with me! I will be there for the entire day and night." (*Smiles*)

Rosanna: "Well, we never spend a day together! It will be so fun all together!"

Tarma: (*Whispering back*) "Your mom can't come."

Rosanna: (*Whispering back*) "Why?"

Tarma: (*Whispering*) "Because she will not allow you to go outside."

- ***The accomplishment of the prophecy***

Rosanna: “Really, we're going outside?”

Tarma: “Yes, it is your birthday, and I want to do something special for you.”

Rosanna: *(She gives a big smile)* “It's okay, Mom, you can stay. I know you're tired, and I don't mind spending my day with Dad.”

Jirmak: “Okay, haha, what did you tell her?”

Tarma: “Dad has his little tricks.” *(They all laugh)*

Rosanna: “Okay, Mom, we are out! See you later!”

Jirmak: “Be careful!”

Tarma: “Do not worry, I got this.”

Jirmak: “I know.” *(Kisses her husband, and her doctor left the room, and she lay back down to sleep)*

Rosanna: “I am so super excited, I can't wait to explore everything!”

Tarma: “Yeah, sure.” *(As he looks at the prescription)* “Are you ready?”

Rosanna: “Yes, let's go!” *(They start walking outside)* “Woow... omg, I just stepped outside!” *(She starts running, smiling)*

Tarma: “Rosana, wait!” *(Runs after her and grabs her by her arms)* “I said stop! You can not go running around, understand?” *(Says it angrily)* “Listen, do not let go of my hand, or I will take you back to the house, ok?”

Rosanna: “Okay... I just got excited; it was my first time outside. Why does everything look so different?”

Tarma: “Different? What do you mean? Everything is always the same, ahaha.”

Rosanna: “But the picture you showed me and the story?”

Tarma: “Ahahaha, that's the city!” *(He says with admiration)*

Rosanna: “Can we go see it?”

Tarma: “No. Your mom will kill me.”

- ***The Face of Destiny***

The villagers were celebrating Rosanna's birthday. Tarma did not want people to recognize his daughter, so they went to a store and bought some masks. Rosanna was excited to see everything for the first time.

Tarma was focusing on his wife's medical prescription. While walking around, Tarma asked people where the doctor's hospital was located.

Tarma: "Excuse me, madam!"

Madam: "Hello!"

Tarma: "Can you tell me where the hospital is located?"

Rosanna: "Are we going to the hospital?"

Madam: *(She smiles)* "Sure, just continue this way and turn to the left, and go straight—the third house is the hospital!"

Tarma: "Thank you very much!"

Madam: *(She walks away)* "Sure, happy Rosanna birthday festival!"

Rosanna and Her Father: "You too, madam!"

Rosanna: "It is so beautiful! And the villagers do not even know I am here!"

Tarma: "Yeah, yeah, yeah, sure! Let's go, do not let go of my hand!"

They started going forward, turned left, and then went straight until they were face-to-face with the sea.

Rosanna: "Ooooooh, the sea! Oh, my God, it is so beautiful! Omg! Daddy!"

Tarma: "She said the third house..." *(Looking at the prescription)* "1, 2, 3... this one, okay. Rosanna, this way, let's go." *(They entered the hospital, took a seat, and waited to be called by the nurse)*

Nurse: "Mr. Tarma?"

Tarma: "Yes, ma'am! Rosanna, stay here; I will be back. Do not move, okay?"

Rosanna: "Understood, mister."

Tarma left to go talk to the nurses and sign some papers. Rosanna was looking outside, staring at the sea, and saw a boat floating on the water. She walked out of the hospital toward the sea and saw a little boy falling into the water.

Rosanna: "Oh. My. God!"

Boy: "Help! Help! Help! You idiot, can't you see I am drowning, stupid?!"

Rosana: "Help! Help!" (*Looking around, but nobody is coming, she jumps into the sea trying to save the boy*)

The boy actually knew how to swim, and he was just playing around, but Rosanna did not know how to swim. Rosanna sinks deep into the sea.

Boy: "Hey, you can come out! I was just joking. Hello!" (*His eyes widen*) "Damn, she is drowning!" (*He dives deep to save her. They come up to the surface*) "You idiot, why did you try to kill yourself?"

Rosanna: (*Coughing*) "You can swim?"

Boy: "Yeah... Why did you jump in the water if you do not know how to swim? And your hair and eyes look so weird. Are you a foreigner?"

Rosanna: "I am from this village, and it is not funny what you did; you could kill someone!" (*Coughs*)

Boy: "Only a stupid person would jump into the sea knowing they cannot swim."

Rosanna: "I was trying to save you!"

Boy: "But I saved you; you owe me your life... Starting today, your life is mine!"

Rosanna: "Are you stupid? Do you know who I am?" (*Saying this proudly*)

Boy: "Well, the entire village should be scared of me; I am sure you will beg me to marry you if you know who I am!" (*Smugly*)

Rosanna: "Ah! Ahaha, I will marry only Jack; he is nothing like a brat like you." (*She stands up*) "Damn, this is very bad. My clothes are wet. Let's not meet again."

Boy: "That is for me to decide. Wait! What is your name? Where are you from?"

Rosanna: "I go by Rosana, and you, little brat?"

Boy: "I am Pri—"

Tarma: "Rosana! Rosana! Rosana!" (*Looking for her, he interrupts the boy*)

Rosanna: "Omg! That's my dad! Byeeee!!"

Boy: "Wait, I did not tell you my name!!" (*Rosanna ran to her father*)

Servant: "Third Prince Ian, it is time to go home."

Rosanna: "Dad?"

Tarma: (*Stares in silence...*) "Rosana?" (*In a low voice*)

Rosanna: "I am sorry I left the hospital. I saw a boy drowning, so I went to help."

Tarma: "What have I done!" (*Freezes in time*)

Rosanna: "Daddy? What's wrong?"

Tarma: "Let's go home."

They walked back home. Everyone was shocked to see the blue hair and her skin glowing, but they said nothing. Everyone knew what was coming, but not Rosanna. They entered the house, and Jirmak was waiting for them.

Jirmak: "I heard that you took Rosanna outside?"

Tarma: "Yes..."

Jirmak: "Why? Why did you take her?"

Tarma: (*Silence*) "Jirmak, I messed up..."

Jirmak: "What? What do you mean? Did you lose Rosanna? Where is my daughter? Did she get kidnapped?"

Rosana: "I am here, hi mom! You look better now.... Please do not be mad at Dad, it was all my fault, I just wanted to see outside."

Jirmak: (*Stares!..... Stares...*)

Jirmak: "Tarma, Tarma, what did you do..." (*Tears coming out*) "What did you do to my daughter? What did you do to her? Tell me!" (*She grabs him by his shirt*) "Why are you quiet? You took away my daughter? Why'd you steal her from me?" (*Dizzy*) "Why? Why?" (*She falls and starts crying*) "My daughter, my Rosanna, where are you?"

Rosana: "I am here, Mom! Stop crying, I am fine! Nothing happened to me. I am in one piece."

Tarma: "Jirmak, listen, I left her in the hospital and..."

Jirmak: "Shut up! How can you be so irresponsible!" (*She lets go of Rosanna and stands up*) "How could you do this to her? To me? To us?"

Tarma: "Jirmak, listen to me!"

Jirmak: "Shut up! Just shut up! Get out! Get out! Get out of the house! Get out!!" (*She pushes Tarma out of the door*)

Rosanna: "Mom, stop! Please stop!"

Jirmak: "Go to your room, Rosana!" *(She pushes her husband outside and locks the door)*

Rosanna: "Fine!" *(She runs to her bed, covers herself with her blanket, and starts crying)*

Jirmak: "Why! Why me? Why?" *(As she sits down and starts crying, she suddenly stands up and runs to her daughter's room)* "Rosana, I am so sorry. I couldn't protect you. I am sorry." *(She cries)*

Rosanna: "Mom, I am alright; you do not need to protect me! Why did you kick Dad out? Why do you two always argue?" *(Crying)*

Jirmak: "Listen to me carefully. Starting now, things will change; nothing will be the same: your life, my life, and the village."

Rosanna: "Why? How?" *(Confused)*

Jirmak: "Your hair and eyes changed... even your eyes..." *(Looking at her)* "Look in the mirror."

Rosanna: "Ah!!!!!!!!!!!!!" *(She screams)* "What? Omg, this is so cool, Jack will be surprised."

Jirmak: "Calm down, calm down, wait, what is Jack?"

Rosanna: "Mom, this is so cool! How did this happen? I love it, wow!"

Jirmak: "Who is Jack? Let me guess... is he the servant boy who works on the farm?"

Rosanna: "Yes, mommy, I knew you would find out sooner or later. Dad told me to keep it a secret because I know how much you hate disrespect of hierarchy."

Jirmak: "What? Does your dad know about it? Where did you meet this servant?"

Rosanna: "I was trying to sneak out of the house. The guards almost caught me, but he saved me, and we became friends."

Jirmak: "You tried to sneak out of the house?! Useless guards! What are they even here for? That boy will be expelled."

Rosanna: "Please, mommy, listen—"

Jirmak: "No more, Rosanna, listen to me now." *(Takes a deep breath)* "Listen, you are the only person who has blue hair and blue eyes." *(Calmly)* "In the future, you will be taken away by a handsome prince to a beautiful castle with billions of servants." *(Holding her tears, showing a fake smile)*

Rosana: "No! I do not want to marry a prince; I will marry Jack!"

Jirmak: "Ah, the servant boy? The reason why I hired him was that I pitied him and his sister. I found him in the street begging for food and money. I decided to take them in, give them a job, home, food, and money as long as they stayed loyal and faithful. I wanted you to have someone

to rely on in case one day I am gone. I did not expect them to take advantage of my kindness and scheme against my household! I hate ungrateful people. Anyway, this is not an option for you. The time for joking is over, and the future is a mystery. Soon the prophet Kafura will arrive, and we will figure out what to do. As for you, sleep now.”

Jirmak: *(Calling out)* “Guards! Bring me the boy who works on the farm. Him and his sister!”

Guards: “Yes, princess!”

The guards walk to the farm, grab Jack and his sister, and bring them before Jirmak.

Rosanna: “Mom, what are you doing!” *(Trying to interfere)*

Jirmak: “Guards, take Rosanna into her room, lock the door, and make sure she does not leave until I give the order. If you fail, your heads will make up for it.”

Rosanna: “Mommy, mom! Why! Why! You always ruin everything! You make my life miserable, I hate you, I hate you, I want daddy, daddy!” *(She screams as the guards carry her away and lock her room)*

Jirmak: “So you are Jack, and this is your sister. You grew up, let me guess... you are now eleven years old, and your sister is nine years old?”

Jack: “Yes, ma'am.”

Jirmak: “Let me ask you a question. Have I ever mistreated you? Wronged you, or treated you unfairly?”

Jack: “No, ma'am. Since we moved into this palace, our life has been more than what we could wish for.”

Jirmak: “Lift your head!”

Jack: “I dare not, ma'am.”

Jirmak: “Why not?”

Sister: “It is against the palace regulation for a maid or servant to look at the monarch. Lowly servants like us... It is an honor to find ourselves in your presence; it is a blessing that even my ancestors would never earn.”

Jirmak: *(Smiling)* “Someone here knows their place. So tell me, how dare you approach my daughter and put delusions in her head? For a lowly servant like you to come to the main palace... such audacity!”

Jack and Sister: *(Lay down on the ground)* “We beg your pardon, madam.”

Jack: “I had no bad intentions.”

Jirmak: “And you dare speak without permission? Guards, give him ten slaps!”

Guard: *(Moves closer and slaps him)*

Jirmak: “For a servant, you dare see yourself as the princess’s friend? Such audacity! In the palace, there are rules and regulations, and each one of them must be followed precisely. People lose their lives for less, but you dare lose your mind in front of my daughter. Jack, the head maid, told me how smart you were and how she was planning to promote you. I guess she was wrong; the wise one was actually your sister. Because of your sister, I will spare your life.”

Sister: “Thank you, your highness, you are truly benevolent.”

Jack: *(Angry, but dares not lift his head)*

Jirmak: “I will show more mercy. You are expelled from this palace and household.”

Jack: *(Panics)* “Your highness, expelling us is a death sentence! How do you expect two kids to survive in this village?”

Jirmak: “Is this my problem? Am I your mother?”

Sister: “Ma'am, I did warn my brother of his delusion and his friendship with the princess, but he did not listen. Who am I to tell the princess what to do? My lady, you are the head of the village, and we have worked for this palace since we were babies. Please, remember the years of our service, soften your heart, and forgive us. Give us one more chance.”

Jirmak: “It is good to talk to people who know their place. Jack, you should learn more from your sister, and let go of all the delusions you are building in your head. Because you have worked for this palace, I will show mercy, but you must leave. My decision is final. Guards, send them away! Take a carriage, give them gold and jewelry, and expel these kids from my palace. Send them to the next village, and never return.”

Guards: “Yes!” *(They carry Jack and his sister, put them in a carriage, and drive them toward the next village)*

Jirmak: *(To herself)* “I know this may sound heartless, but for the safety of my daughter, this must be done.”

Prophet Kafura: “This palace is very lively today.” *(He entered the palace)*

Jirmak: “Prophet Kafura! Thank God you are here. Rosanna.... Rosanna’s hair—” *(She starts crying and kneels to show respect)*

Prophet Kafura: “Woman, stand up. I know it all. God has sent me to you, and I am aware of everything that has happened.” *(He takes a deep breath)*

Jirmak: *(Stands up)* “I am not ready! I can’t lose Rosanna. She is just eight years old! Why now?”

Prophet Kafura: “Jirmak, I have been watching you and your family. You had more than enough time to prepare. Rosanna must be ready: heaven cannot wait forever!”

Jirmak: “So, you knew all along? Could you have stopped all of this? Could you have prevented Rosanna's hair from changing? Why didn't you do anything? You know my condition; you know how much I love my daughter. Why? Why?”

Prophet Kafura: “Jirmak, I did not come here to explain myself. I came here to bring the word and will of God. I think Rosanna should move to the temple and be raised there.”

Jirmak: “What?!”

Prophet Kafura: “Until today, she has not known about her destiny or the God we serve. There is much she must learn about the real world, the priesthood, and her path. She needs guidance.”

Jirmak: “So, you think I am not good enough to teach my own daughter? That I am not a fit mother? What kind of God is this, destroying families, separating a mother and daughter? Rosanna is my only child; I will never conceive again. How do you expect me to let it go? No, I will not; I did not choose this horrible fate or destiny. Why should I fulfill it? Why should I accept it? I will not.”

Prophet Kafura: “Bitterness against God never ends well and—”

Jirmak: (*Interrupted and yelling*) “I do not care! What does your God want? Money? Sacrifices? I have a farm! I have gold! How much does he want? Have I not prayed enough, given enough, cried enough, suffered enough? What is this?! I will not accept it!”

Prophet Kafura: (*Interrupting her*) “Jirmak! No one knows why God does what he does, but as people of God, we are supposed to obey and respect His will. To us, His will is law. Maybe at the end of this journey, we will understand the purpose behind this pain.”

Jirmak: (*Laughs bitterly as tears fall*) “Purpose? My world is turned upside down, my family is gone, my daughter is being taken... I have nothing left.”

Prophet Kafura: “Faith, hope, belief, trust, strength, Jirmak. You know our story. Because of the sins of our ancestors, the Lord left us, and we have been punished for fifty years. We are now slaves of this new Empire, Boparl. We live in this small village, Hikmid, and though it is peaceful now, there is a fire cooking in secret places. If our God has shown us mercy and chosen one of us to set us free, it is a blessing for the nation. Rosanna the Hikmidian. Rosanna the rising sun; she is the leading hope for our people. Jirmak, this is a sacred task for our people. Rosanna should live at the temple with other priests. We can prepare her and make her ready for her destiny... and marriage.”

Jirmak: “But why should I lose my daughter? Why must it be me?”

Rosanna: (*Calling out*) “Daddy?! Are you back already?!”

Jirmak: (*Choked*) “Rosanna?! How did you leave your room?! Where are the guards?!”

Rosanna: (*Smiling, turning toward them*) "I put them to sleep! Where is daddy?! Old man?! What are you doing here?!"

Prophet Kafura: (*Teasing her*) "Rosanna the Hikmidian, mtoto mkaidi."

Rosanna: (*Smiles, and gives a bow*) "Jambo."

Prophet Kafura: (*Holding his staff and nodding his head*) "Jambo binti mfalme."

Jirmak: (*Smiles despite herself*) "How many times have I told you not to misuse your skills or your gifts?!"

Rosanna: "I needed to know what you did to my friend! What did you do to them? Where are they? I hope you did not execute them?... Mommy, say something?!"

Jirmak: (*Fixing Rosanna's posture*) "I am not that heartless."

Rosanna: "Then what did you do? Are they back to the farm?!"

Jirmak: "I banished them."

Rosanna: "What?! Why? Why didn't you tell me or ask me what I thought about it?"

Jirmak: "Do I need to report to you when I do something?!"

Rosanna: "Yes, that's my friend."

Jirmak: "I am the mother, and you're the child; you do what I say, and that is final. I owe you no explanation."

Rosanna: (*With attitude*) "But your majesty, I am old enough to make my own decisions; I have feelings too! And—"

Prophet Kafura: "Mtoto, unapenda kubishana na watu. Acha kupigana na watu. You are still so young and have a big mouth."

Rosanna: "This is royal business! Who are you to interfere or disrupt us? How did you get in here anyway?!"

Jirmak: (*Side-eyes*) "Rosanna!"

Rosanna: (*Shakes off her mother's hand, circling the prophet*) "You are a beggar I saw in the street. I used to think you were a ghost. Turns out, everyone can see you."

Prophet Kafura: "Mtoto, I never said I was a ghost nor a beggar."

Rosanna: "Kusema uongo kwa chifu wa kijiji kinaweza kusababisha kifo chako. Usiniambie upo hapa kuomba chakula na pesa tena. Where did you get these clean clothes?! Did you steal them?!"

Jirmak: *(Yelled)* “Rosanna Hikmidian?!”

Rosanna: “But mom, it's true?!”

Jirmak: *(Whisper in Rosanna's heart)* “This is the prophet, the High Priest of our village and tribe!”

Rosanna: *(Immediately kneeling)* “Sorry, Mr. Priest! Please do not turn me into a frog!”

Jirmak, Guards, Prophet: *(Laughing out loud)*

Prophet Kafura: *(Clearing his throat)* “Binti mfalme, rise. I do not turn people into frogs, nor will I cause you harm.”

Rosanna: *(Refused to stand)* “My mother told me the story of all your wonders: how you protected my parents, how you watched over my mom during her pregnancy, and how you saved my life when I was born from being burned alive by the villagers. As a princess, I should have come in person to thank you for all you did for me.” *(Side-eyes her mom)* “But as you can see, I am not allowed to leave the main palace. I truly thank you; if there is anything you need now and in the future, do not hesitate to ask me. Also, my apologies for calling you a beggar. As you can see, I am just a kid with a small brain: please do not hold it against my family.”

Prophet Kafura: *(Holding Rosanna's hand and helping her up)* “I think I should be the one who bows down to God's chosen, not you, binti mfalme. But I have one question, or perhaps worry.”

Rosanna: “There is nothing that can compare to the three lives saved. Whatever you ask, if it is in our power, we shall fulfill it.”

Jirmak: *(Nodding her head)* “I was never able to thank you for saving my life and my family. So please, share your worries with us!”

Prophet Kafura: “I have one sheep left to me by my late mom. I have had that sheep since I was born: it is the only thing my family left me. But in this one village, there are no more animals to eat. Everyone has eaten vegetables for years, and their health is suffering. The entire village gathered and asked me to give up my sheep to be killed and eaten. But my heart cannot accept it; that sheep is my only family. On the other hand, people are dying. Unafikiri nifanye nini?!”

Rosanna: “I understand what you feel. I feel like I lose my dad every other day whenever they fight. But the lives of the villagers are more important; I believe you should give the sheep away and save them. If one life can save millions, it is worthy, and it is just a sheep, not people.”

Jirmak: *(Confused, watching her daughter's wisdom and listening to the prophet's question)*

Prophet Kafura: “A wise decision. Will you come to the temple to study?! I will teach you all you need to know!”

Jirmak and Rosanna: “What?!”

Jirmak: “No, it is not happening.”

Rosanna: *(Looking at her mother)* “Yes! It is happening!”

Jirmak: “I am your mother; what I say goes!”

Rosanna: “Like what you always say to Dad?!”

Jirmak: “What?!”

Rosanna: “I am tired of living in your cage, and I will not be like Dad. I am leaving?!”

Jirmak: *(Grabbing her hand)* “Rosanna!”

Rosanna: *(Trying to pull away)* “Let go of me! Let go!”

Prophet Kafura: “Enough! She made her decision. Rosanna is coming with me.”

Jirmak: “I am the chief princess of Hikmid! My word is law! And I said no!”

● ***Family Separation***

Prophet Kafura: *(Holding Rosanna)* “I am God's representative and the prophet of this tribe, and I will take Rosanna.”

Jirmak: “Guards, get them now!”

Prophet Kafura: *(He holds Rosanna, and they disappear in an instant)*

Jirmak: *(Unable to believe what happened)* “No, noooo! Rosanna! Rosanna, come back! Come back now! I said come back! Please come back! I need you to come back! Rosanna, I am sorry, sorry! I said sorry! Do not leave me, please. Prophet Kafura! Prophet... please return her, my! My! My! My daughter!!” *(She is screaming, yelling, walking around outside on the road until she faints)*

Prophet Kafura: *(Invisible, as they observe Jirmak from the spirit realm)* “Rosanna, are you sure you want to leave?”

Rosanna: *(In tears)* “Yes! It is better. Bye, mom!” *(Whisper)*

The Sacred Holy Mountain

Stranger: “Wake up! Wake up! Stand up, stand up! Everyone outside! Hurry, hurry! Do you want to get up, or want me to get you up? Wake up, everyone! Hurry! Hurry! Outside and line up! Straight line, everyone!”

Rosanna: *(Opening her eyes)* “What? Why are they so loud? Who is screaming? It is too early to wake up...”

Stranger: “You freak, get up! I said GET UP!” *(She grabs Rosanna by her arm and throws her out of the bed)*

Rosanna: “How dare you! How dare you be so insolent?!” *(She stands up, grabs the stranger by her hair, and begins to punch and slap her)*

Stranger: “OMG! Get them! Get them! Stop them! I said pull them apart!”

Group of Kids: “Fight! Fight! Fight! Fight!...”

Stranger: *(Looking to her right and telling her followers)* “Why are you standing here?! I said, ‘Go get them!’”

Stranger: “I got the freak. Are you okay?”

Rosanna: “Let me go! Let me go! What are you doing! You were supposed to get her! Do you want to lose your head too?!”

Stranger: “Yes, I am fine. What took you so long? She almost scratched my face! Hold her well; I will teach her a lesson.” *(She slaps Rosanna)*

Rosanna: *(In shock, trying to pull herself out)* “What?! You dare?! I will teach you a lesson! LET ME GO! I said, ‘LET ME GO!’”

Stranger: *(Slapping Rosanna harder and harder)* “I will teach you a lesson.”

Rosanna: “How dare you? Do you know who I am?!”

Stranger: *(Pulling Rosanna's hair up and forcing her to kneel)* “Hahaha! Do you know who I am? I will make an example of you!”

(Listen, everyone): “This is not your mama’s house, not your daddy’s house. Everything you know, forget it! Who you are, forget it. You are nobody, less than trash. If you do not listen, you will face worse than this blue-haired freak. Understand!” *(Holding down Rosanna)*

“My name is Resekelushi. I am the daughter of the head priestess of this chamber. There are twelve chambers in total; this is the twelfth one, the lowest of the low. It is called the Servant Chambers. You are newbies, so I will forgive your misbehavior this once, but next time, you will wish for death. You are abandoned; you are orphans. Nobody is looking for you or waiting for you, so if you die, we will simply throw your bodies away.”

Rosanna: “I am not abandoned, and I am not an orphan.”

Everyone: *(Giggles and whispers)*

Resekelushi: “Hahaha, I guess each year we get freakier and more freakier. Let her go!”

“So, freak, I got something fun for you: which state are you from?”

Rosanna: *(Stands up with dignity)* “I am binti mfalme of Hikmid, Rosanna.”

Everyone: *(Laughing loudly)* “She is a freak and delusional, too! Ahahaha!”

Rosanna: “I am Rosanna, the second chief princess!”

Resekelushi: “Every year, it is something new. Another fan of the princess. This is a temple, not a mental hospital.” *(She steps closer, her eyes narrowing until they are like slits; she leans into Rosanna’s face, smelling of incense and old dust)* “Everyone knows the story of Princess Rosanna. After her family was saved by the high head priest, the prophet, the princess’s health got weaker every year. Her body was frail, and she could not even go outside. Nobody has ever seen her or knows what she looks like. But the story says she has blue hair and eyes like the sky and sea.”

Rosanna: “What—”

Resekelushi: “If you were a princess, you would be in the first chamber or secret place with the prophet. Here, you just bow your head until your face disappears! Ahahahaha!” *(She turned to the crowd of girls)* “What do we do with royalty when they forget their place?”

Crowd: “We give them the heaviest bucket!!”

Resekelushi: “Take the princess, wash off her paint, and show her how things get done here!” *(She leaves)*

Rosanna: “It is true, I am the princess, I am Rosa—”

Girls: *(They grab her by force, shove her into water, and try to scrub her by force)* “It is not coming off! What kind of paint did she use? Fine, leave her here outside until she figures out how to fix herself.”

Shy Girl (Elara): “But it is cold outside! She might die, and she is soaking wet!”

Girls: *(Pushes Elara toward Rosanna)* “Then you join her and die together, ahahaha!” *(They leave them both outside in the cold)*

Rosanna: “Wait, wait! Please do not do this!”

Young Girl: “Don’t fight them; it is not worth it. It will only make your punishment longer. I am Elara. I will help you carry and clean up. Follow me.”

Rosanna: “Thank you. I am Rosanna!”

Elara: “I think you should stop using that name here.”

Rosanna: “But that is my name!”

Elara: “Just listen and observe. Your paint is not coming out!”

Rosanna: "I told you, that is my hair."

Elara: "Anyway, we will figure it out once the priest arrives."

Rosanna: "Where did they go?!"

Elara: "They went to pick up a very important person."

Rosanna: "Who is more important here? More than me?"

Elara: "Here we are all slaves and servants. You will have to wait for the priest to give you a new name. But it might take months for them to return to the temple."

Rosanna: "So this is the temple?!"

Elara: "Yes! Is it your first time at a temple?!"

Rosanna: "Yes, it is my first time out of the palace."

Elara: (*As they walk toward the changing room*) "Really? You live in the palace."

Rosanna: "Yes! With maids and servants!"

Elara: "How did you end up in a dump like this?" Rosanna: "It is a long story."

Elara: (*Looking at Rosanna's clothes, thinking maybe it is true*) "Anyway, here in the changing room, I am going to let you borrow my clothes until you get your name tag and uniform."

Rosanna: "Thank you! Once I get back to the palace, I will reward you greatly!"

They enter the changing room. Elara pulls out a bin, picks up a robe with holes in it, and gives it to Rosanna.

Rosanna: "What? It has holes in it!"

Elara: "Well, those are my best clothes. I usually wear them when we have important rituals."

Rosanna: (*Looking at Elara*) "Well, what you are wearing is messy too!"

Elara: "You have to change fast; we cannot be late for breakfast!"

Rosanna: "How do you wear these?!"

Elara: "Wait, you do not know how to put on your own clothes?!"

Rosanna: "Yes, that is maids' and servants' jobs."

Elara: (*Helping Rosanna put on her clothes*) "Well, guess what! You are one now. Put on your clothes and let's go! We cannot be late."

They walk into the cafeteria.

Girls: "Here comes the freak and her stinky friend. Ahahaha!"

Rosanna: *(About to go and fight)*

Elara: *(Holding her back from behind)* "Listen, Princess, you do not have to fight them!"

Rosanna: "Bring your faces here and see what I will do to you!"

Girls: "Fight! Fight! FIGHT!"

Cafeteria Priest: "What is going on here? Everyone be quiet!"

Resekelushi: "It is the freak's fault!"

Cafeteria Priest: "How many times have I told you not to call people names?" *(Turning toward Rosanna)* "Why is your hair blue?" *(To Elara)* "Why did you not show her how things get done here?"

Elara: "I tried to wash her hair, but the paint did not come out!"

Rosanna: "How many times should I tell you that it is my real hair? I am Rosanna!" Cafeteria Priest: *(Getting closer)* "Many people are saying the same thing." *(She holds Rosanna's hair to check it)* "Can you prove it?"

Rosanna: "Yes, I took my seal out of my pocket. Go and verify this seal."

Cafeteria Priest: *(Looking and whispering)* "This looks real."

Resekelushi: "She probably stole it!"

Girls: "Yes! Hahahah! She looks like a thief."

Rosanna: "No, I am not!" Cafeteria Priest: "Be quiet, I said! I will go verify this seal. If you lied, you will regret it."

Elara: *(Looking at Rosanna and whispering)* "Rosanna, are you sure?!"

Rosanna: "Yes! Yes." Cafeteria Priest: "Okay. Because you are late, you will stay and clean up the cafeteria. Elara, I am putting you in charge of her. Make sure she knows how this place works before I come back. And you, Resekelushi, you and your friends are punished by washing the dishes."

Resekelushi: *(Standing up)* "I will not! My mom is the head priest of these apartments. If you want to do anything with me, talk to my mom!"

Cafeteria Priest: "Guess what, girl? Your mom is not here, and I am in charge. You do what I said, or you sleep outside. You decide." *(She walks out of the cafeteria.)*

Resekelushi: "Freak, it is all your fault. I will make sure you regret it. Watch me!" *(She walks away with her friends.)*

Rosanna: *(Sitting down on the bench and taking a deep breath)* "Girls are scary."

Elara: "Some girls are scary, and some you should just avoid. Well, let's start mopping the floor. Long day ahead."

Rosanna: "Who is bringing the food?!"

Elara: "We were late; there is no food!"

Rosanna: "What? How! We are people, not animals."

Elara: "What is the difference between an animal and a servant here? Come on, I am tired. Let's clean up. Go into the kitchen, take the bucket, and go to the well to get water. I will take the dirty dishes outside."

Rosanna: "Okay, sorry." *(She walks into the kitchen, gets the bucket, and goes to the well to get water.)*

Prince Ian: "Why is it so noisy this morning? It is usually quiet, and why is nobody bringing my food to my room?"

Servants: *(Looking down)* "Your Highness, the kitchen was facing a little delay."

Prince Ian: "What kind of delay? You know I hate lazy people."

Servants: "There is this new girl who is causing chaos this morning."

Prince Ian: "And what is her name? Where is she from?!" Servants: "She has blue hair and eyes. She is from the village, and she said her name is Rosanna."

Prince Ian: "Why didn't you tell me earlier?!" *(He jumps out of his bed to go look for Rosanna.)*

Servants: "Prince Ian, wait! Wait for us, Your Highness!"

Rosanna: *(Going to the well)* "I miss home, I miss my mom. I did not expect life at the temple to be this hard." Prince Ian: "Hello, idiot?" Rosanna: *(Looking up)* "You again?"

Prince Ian: "What, you miss me already?"

Rosanna: "You stupid face! Of course not."

Servants: *(Whispering)* "OMG, is she talking to the prince of the empire like that?!"

Prince Ian: *(Staring at them with side-eyes)* "Rosanna, you are a servant at this temple."

Rosanna: "No, it is a huge misunderstanding."

Prince Ian: *(Looking at her)* "Really? Where is your dad?"

Rosanna: "Long story." Prince Ian: "Maybe I can help... if you bow down and say how amazing I am."

Rosanna: "Are you crazy? I am the princess of this village! Why should I bow down to an arrogant brat?"

Servant: *(Giggles)* "Brat."

Prince Ian: "Can you prove it, or are you just delusional?"

Rosanna: "I gave away my seal to one of the priests to verify it, but I have a necklace."

Prince Ian: "Let me see." *(He takes it and puts it around his own neck.)* "I will take this as a wedding gift from you."

Rosanna: "What? Give it back! Give it back! Come here, come here!" *(She runs after him.)*

Elara: *(Calling out)* "Water!! Where is the water?!"

Rosanna: "Oh my God, I will deal with you later!" *(She runs to get water from the well.)*

Prince Ian: "Do you need help to carry the bucket?" *(He watches her pull water from the well.)*

Rosanna: "I do not want to owe you anything, and you need to return my necklace."

Prince Ian: "It is mine now. Once you give a gift, you don't ask for it back. It belongs to the person who receives it."

Rosanna: *(Pulling water)* "When did I say it was your necklace?"

Prince Ian: "Doesn't matter. You should be good to me; I am the future king and your husband."

Rosanna: *(Standing up and staring at him)* "You? With those bones of yours? To be a king, you have to be a part of the royal family, and you are just a servant. You are the delusional one." *(She begins walking with the heavy bucket of water.)*

Prince Ian: "What if I was part of the royal family?!"

Rosanna: "Huh? Why would a royal member live in a slave village?!"

Prince Ian: "Long story. I will leave the temple for a few days, but I will return to pick you up, wifey." *(He laughs as he turns and runs away.)*

Rosanna: *(Standing there in shock)* "Oh my God!"

Elara: *(Calling out)* "Water!! Where is the water?!"

Rosanna: *(Picks up the heavy bucket and starts running toward Elara, but Resekelushi and her friends deliberately trip her. Rosanna falls hard on the ground, and the water spills everywhere.)*
"Why... why would you do that?" Resekelushi: "It is just the beginning. Ahahahah!"

Elara: *(Running toward Rosanna)* “Are you okay? Resekelushi, that is very mean!”

Resekelushi: “What was that, stinky? Do you want to join her?”

Elara: *(Stays quiet)* Resekelushi: “That's what I thought. Let's go, girls.” *(Resekelushi and her group walk off to wash the dishes, laughing.)*

Elara: “Let’s go treat your wound.” Rosanna: “It's okay. I’m used to getting wounded every time I climb the palace walls to look at the sea.”

Elara: “It is better to treat it now; we can mop after. Listen, you should avoid Resekelushi. Please, do not fight with her.”

Rosanna: “I know, let’s just go mop.” *(Rosanna and Elara begin to mop the floor, but Resekelushi and her group deliberately spill their dirty dishwater across the clean tiles.)*
“What?!”

Elara: “Just let it go.”

Resekelushi: “Freak, looks like you still have some mopping to do! Hahaha. We’re finished with our work. See you later, stinky. And by the way, make sure you keep that freak away from me. Let's go, girls, ahahaha.”

Girls: “I heard freakness is contagious, ahahaha!” *(They laugh as they walk away.)*

Narrator: Rosanna and Elara spent the entire morning mopping. Elara had to teach Rosanna how to mop, clean, wash, and fold clothes properly. By the evening, all the girls had gathered for lunch. Rosanna and Elara arrived first in the cafeteria. Rosanna: “I am so hungry. Working all day without eating until sunrise is hard.” Elara: “Yes, *nina njaa*.” Head Priest: “So you are the girl who was causing trouble in my court.” Elara: *(Bowing down immediately)* “Habari kuhani.” Rosanna: *(Confused, looking around)*

Elara: *(Grabs Rosanna, pulls her down, and whispers)* “That is the head priest of the servants’ chamber, Resekelushi’s mother.” Rosanna: *(Bowing down)* “Habari kuhani. I believe there has been a misunderstanding.”

Head Priest: “Really? Are you telling me I lack discernment?” Rosanna: “No, it's just—” Head Priest: “It's just what? You dare talk back to me? After everybody finishes eating, you stay and clean up this entire place.”

Rosanna: “What? We just spent our entire morning cleaning this place! We are exhausted.”

Head Priest: *(Slaps Rosanna)* “You dare talk back to me, servant? I believe you do not know your place. You will wash the dishes too.” Rosanna: “No, I—”

Elara: *(Quickly grabs her and covers her mouth)* “Yes, kuhani, she will.”

Head Priest: "Good." *(She turns and leaves the place.)* Resekelushi: *(Makes a mocking face at Rosanna and skips away toward her mother.)*

Rosanna: *(Slowly stands up and sits on her bench. She starts eating her food in silence.)*

Elara: *(Joins her)* "Are you okay?" Rosanna: *(Quietly...)* *Resekelushi and the others finish eating and take their plates to the kitchen. Rosanna immediately begins mopping.*

Elara: *(Watching Rosanna)* "I will help you wash the dishes. You focus only on the mopping."

Rosanna: *(Quiet)*

Narrator: They finished cleaning the kitchen just as the sun was going down. The temple was very massive, divided into twelve different departments known as the twelve chambers.

Rosanna: "I am so tired."

Elara: "It is easier once you get used to it and learn the regulations."

Rosanna: *(As they sit together on the cafeteria entrance stairway)* "How can anyone get used to this?"

Elara: "You will be fine. Look, the sunset is beautiful."

Resekelushi: *(Approaching them)* "Hello, loser. I hope you did your cleaning well this time. You wouldn't want to upset the head priest again."

Crowd: "Finally, it's dinner time. I am exhausted from all the studying and cleaning." Girls: "Yes! The books about the history of the empires and the prophecy are massive to read and study."

A Girl: "I just hope I pass my exam and get promoted. I want to leave this toxic place as fast as I can." Crowd: "Yes! Agreed. Let's go eat."

Rosanna: *(Looking at Elara)* "Is it dinner time?" Elara: "After sundown, it is always dinner time."

Rosanna: "Okay, okay... let's go! My whole body hurts."

Elara: "Do you need help? Let me help you get inside!" *(She helps Rosanna stand up and walk inside the cafeteria. They find a seat and begin to eat their meal.)*

Resekelushi: "Behave, freak, or mommy will punish you again! Ahahaha!"

Rosanna: *(Ignoring her and eating her food)*

Elara: "After we finish eating, I will show you where the bedrooms are. We share a room." *(They finish their meal, and Elara leads Rosanna to their shared quarters.)*

Rosanna: *(Collapses onto her bed and falls asleep immediately.)*

Elara: "You must be so tired." *(Elara covers Rosanna with a blanket before falling asleep herself.)*

Assistant Priest: *(Shouting the next morning)* "Wake up! Wake up! Everyone! It is morning! Go get water for the priests. Clean, wash, sew clothes! Make sure you do not miss your breakfast, lunch, or dinner, and please take a shower. There is a list posted outside that tells you which area you are assigned to today. Go read it. Find your name and your duty for the day."

Elara: *(Grabs Rosanna and runs outside to look at the list)* "I found my name! I am on cooking duty today. What about you?"

Rosanna: "Can't see my name on any of these papers."

Resekelushi: "Of course it's on there! Look right here! It says the 'Freak' is assigned to sewing duty!"

Rosanna: "I have a name! You could try being nice for once!"

Elara: *(Takes the paper and finds the tag for Rosanna)* "It... it actually says Freak!" Rosanna: *(Takes her new name tag and checks the paper)* "What? Freak!"

Resekelushi: "See, I told you. I was actually being nice. Since you do not appreciate my help, I am going to do my own duty, which is reading books. Ahahaha!" *(She walks off arrogantly.)*

Elara: *(Whispering to Rosanna)* "All of this is happening because her mom is the head of the twelve chambers."

Rosanna: "It does not matter anymore. I am still Rosanna binti mfalme of Hikmid. This name tag does not change anything. Elara, can you show me where the sewing department is? I do not want to be late for my duty."

Elara: "In all the departments, the eleventh chamber is the sewing department. They are currently recruiting new servants. If you get selected, you will get promoted to the eleventh department, known as the clothes chamber. You'd even move out of the regular quarters, but be careful—the head priest of the clothes department is very moody. He has never found anyone who he thinks is good enough." Rosanna: "I see!"

Elara: "Here we are. I wish you good luck on the test. May the God of David be with you!"

Rosanna: "You too!" *(She enters the new chamber and takes her seat, waiting for her name to be called for her test.)* Priest: *(Looking at the candidate list)* "Freak!"

Rosanna: *(Running to the front from the back of the crowd)* "Here!"

Priest: *(Staring at her in disgust)* "What is this?" *(Looks at the head priest of the clothes chamber)* "It seems the head priest of the servant chamber is sending us all the trash. Look, freak, go back. We do not need any more craziness here." *(The priest sends her away.)*

Rosanna: *(As she is being dragged away)* “No! No, give me a chance, please! I beg you! One chance, that is all! The book says people look at the outside, but the Lord looks at the inside, at the heart of man. As a priest, isn’t it wrong for you to judge me by my appearance?”

Head Priest: “Stop! We are not God; we cannot see into your heart. We can only judge you by how you present yourself to us. However... you are right. It seems you know your word. I will give you a test. If you pass, I will promote you to the fifth rank of the clothes chamber. But if you fail, you will be permanently banned from the clothes chamber.”

Rosanna: “Yes! I agree to the condition. In the name of Jehovah!” *(She raises her hand in a small prayer.)*

Head Priest: “*Mpe zana zote anahitaji kwa mtihani. Kwanza!*” Rosanna: *(Sits at the front and begins sewing with a needle and thread. Thirty minutes later)* “I am finished!”

Head Priest: *(Looks at the other priest)* “Go get it.”

Priest: *(Nods, walks over to Rosanna, takes the fabric, and gives it to the head priest.)* Head

Priest: *(Eyes wide open in shock)* “What?! How?”

Priest: “Hold her! Kick her out of the palace immediately!”

Rosanna: *(Terrified)* “Wait!”

Head Priest: “Wait! How do you know how to sew like this? Who taught you?”

Rosanna: “My mother, since I was a child. She taught me many art forms, and sewing was one of them, Priest.” Head Priest: “What is your mom's name?”

Rosanna: “Jirmak!” Crowd: *(Whispering)* “Her mother has the same name as the princess chief...”

Head Priest: “Be quiet. I guess your name is Rosanna.” Rosanna: “Yes! Rosanna binti mfalme of Hikmid.”

Priest: *(Laughing)* “How did you end up here if you're a princess? Ahahaha!”

Rosanna: “Prophet Kafura brought me here. I do not know how, but I woke up, and I was here.”

Priest: “There is nobody called Prophet Kafura.”

Head Priest: “Be quiet! Rosanna... or... Freak, do you remember what he looked like? Can you describe him to me?” Rosanna: “Yes, Head Priest. He had a staff and wore white glowing clothes. He had a long white beard, a small purse, and a bald head.”

Crowd: “She is making up things again!”

Head Priest: *(Suddenly bows down)* “*Mtakatifu, mtakatifu!*” Crowd: *(Confused)* “...What?”

Priest: *(Eyes widening as he bows down)* “*Mtakatifu, mtakatifu!*”

Crowd: *(Bows down)* “*Mtakatifu, mtakatifu!*” Rosanna: *(Confused)* “What is going on? I am not a saint. I am Rosanna, the princess of Hikmid.”

Head Priest: “Forgive us for our disrespect. I will immediately send a few of my priests to gather your belongings and move you into my chambers. I will report to my supervisor, and a full investigation will be conducted.”

Rosanna: “I want to talk to Prophet Kafura!”

Head Priest: “The Holy Head Priest Prophet traveled to the capital with Prince Ian of the Empire. Do we not know when he will return?”

Rosanna: “What? What am I going to do now?” Head Priest: “*Mtakatifu, mtakatifu!* We have someone in charge at the level one chamber; I will travel immediately to bring the news. For now, you can stay here in my chamber until we clean up this mess, *mtakatifu, mtakatifu.*”

Rosanna: *(Sits down and sighs)*

Head Priest: “Priest, take Rosanna to the servant chamber. Let the princess pick up her belongings and move into the clothes chamber!”

Guard Priest: “Yes! Let's go, *mtakatifu, mtakatifu!*” *(They walk away to collect Rosanna's things.)*

Priest: *(Whispering to the head priest)* “What's wrong? What happened?”

Head Priest: “She sewed a purple lily.”

Priest: “So what? I understand that the skills were lost ages ago, but calling her *mtakatifu, mtakatifu* is too much!”

Head Priest: *(Staring sternly at the priest)* “It was never lost. These skills are only taught to people of direct lineage—from priesthood to priesthood, royal family to royal family, mother to daughter, prophet to prophet. Only those who spent years practicing can identify it, let alone sew it. As a priest, you should know all of this. I demote you to the 7th rank! Go back, read your books, and make sure Rosanna is settled well here, or you will be expelled.” 7th Servant Chamber Priest: “Yes, Head Priest!”

Head Priest: *(As she walks away, whispering to herself)* “There is a rumor spreading outside the temple that the princess is missing. The chief princess argued with Prophet Kafura, and he took the princess away. Jirmak is my childhood friend and my promised sister, and she once saved my life. I owe her many favors. I will go directly to ask her about this fabric and the princess!”

Rosanna: *(To herself, wondering)* “Who is Prince Ian? Why would the prince of the empire visit Hikmid, the slave village? Why was he at the temple?”

Guard Priest: *(Arriving at the gate of the servant quarters)* “Open the gate! By order of the head priest of the clothes chamber, we are here to collect the princess's clothes and belongings. She is to be moved to the eleventh chamber immediately!”

Crowd: “Who is the princess?! Where? Here in this dump?!”

Elara: *(Running toward the gate)* “Where is Rosanna? Did she cause trouble? Please understand that she just arrived yesterday. She does not know about the regulations of the temple. Please forgive her this once! Rosanna! Rosanna!”

Rosanna: “Elara!”

Elara: *(Runs and hugs Rosanna)* “Are you okay? Why is the priest with you? Do not tell me you fought with someone again! I told you to ignore them and—”

Rosanna: “Calm down, it is not like that. I got promoted!”

Elara: “What?! Really?!” Resekelushi: “Impossible! You can’t even mop! Ahahaha, delusion!”

Girls: “Ahahaha!”

Rosanna: *(Gently moves Elara aside and looks at the priest)* “Priest, give her ten slaps!” Guard

Priest: “Yes!” *(He holds Resekelushi down and slaps her hard.)*

Resekelushi: *(Screaming)* “You can’t do this to me! My mother is the head of the servants’ chamber! You cannot do anything without her consent here!” *(Yelled)*

Rosanna: “Keep slapping her!” *(As the priest continues to slap her)*

Head Servant Priest: *(Running onto the scene)* “My daughter! Stop! Stop! I said stop!”

Rosanna: *(Coldly)* “Keep slapping! There are five slaps left!” Head Servant Priest: “You freak, who are you to give orders here? Grab her and beat her to death!”

Rosanna: “Hold her too and slap her!”

Guard Priests: *(Immediately hold the head servant chamber down and begin slapping her.)* Head

Servant Chamber: “How dare you? Do you know who I am? I am the head priest of the twelve chambers! How are you going to touch me?”

Rosanna: “You enjoy watching other people’s children suffer, but you cannot tolerate just ten slaps for your daughter?! You are biased and unworthy to be in charge of these chambers. As Rosanna, the princess of Hikmid and the daughter of Chief Princess Jirmak and Chief Prince Tarma, I strip you of all rights and titles. You will be put in prison to await your judgment.”

Head Servant Chamber: *(Laughing hysterically)* “You are just a brat with no rights! I did nothing wrong. All of these kids are rejected, ahahaha, sold, abandoned, orphans! Even if they die, who cares? Ahahaha!”

Resekelushi: *(Losing her mind)* “You are just a freak! Just a freak, hahaha! Freak! Just wait until I get promoted; I will have you executed! How much did she pay this priest, huh? How much? Tell me! She is a fake!”

Head Servant Priest: “I will not accept this! You are just a kid. What power do you have?! Ahahaha. Impossible! I have worked my entire life for this temple; I will not lose anything! Nothing!”

Rosanna: “Really? Watch me. Guards, take the head priest, her daughter, and all their followers! Give them twenty whips each. Then throw them in prison to await Prophet Kafura's return. They receive only one meal a day.”

Guard Priests: “As you commanded, *binti mfalme*.” (*They drag the screaming Resekelushi and her mother away.*)

Narrator: The cafeteria fell into a stunned silence. The rejects and orphans looked at Rosanna with a mixture of fear and newfound hope. Rosanna turned to her friend, who was still trembling. Rosanna: “Elara!” Elara: “Rosanna, so you are *binti mfalme*?!” Rosanna: “Yes!”

Elara: (*Immediately bows down together with the crowd*) “*Binti mfalme*, please do not punish me.” Rosanna: (*Holds her friend up*) “Elara, from this moment on, you are the head of the servant chambers. You will oversee the twelve departments here until further notice.”

Elara: “*Binti mfalme*, I am only eleven. I am not worthy of such honor, and I do not know how to run a chamber.” Rosanna: “Please, Elara, call me Rosanna. You know how to be kind. You know how to treat people like human beings. To me, you are more than qualified. I will be moving to the eleventh chamber for the next ten days until the priest returns.”

Narrator: Prophet Kafura and Prince Ian were observing the situation from afar.

Prince Ian: “She is spicy.”

Prophet Kafura: “I believe she handled the situation well.”

Prince Ian: “She showed too much mercy and kindness. People like that should be cut off immediately. They are a ticking bomb.”

Prophet Kafura: “What will you do in this situation, *mkuu*?”

Prince Ian: “I will execute them immediately. And what does *mkuu* mean?”

Prophet Kafura: “*Mfalme wa baadaye*?”

Prince Ian: “I will marry this girl, keep her well, and—funny—she is actually a princess.” (*As he looks at the necklace*) “Rare diamond.”

Guard Priest: “Princess, we finished collecting your belongings. We are ready to move to the next chamber.”

Elara: (*Holds Rosanna's hand*) “I will miss you, Rosanna!” Rosanna: “I will miss you too. Now that you are the head, feel free to come see me at any time. Okay?”

Elara: “Okay, princess!”

Narrator: Rosanna carries all her belongings. The guards open the gate, and she walks out proudly toward the next chamber.

Prince Ian: "Hello, Queen of my heart!"

Rosanna: "You again!" Prince Ian: (*Being playful*) "Do I need permission to see my own wife? I just miss your face so much."

Rosanna: (*To the guards*) "Guards, get him! Are you scared of him?"

Guards: (*Stay quiet*) Prince Ian: (*Picking up Rosanna and setting her down*) "I am going to the capital. I do not know when I will be back. Be good and wait for me, okay?"

Rosanna: "What are you going to do in the capital?" Prince Ian: "I am going to be king and make you my queen."

Rosanna: "Right!" Prince Ian: (*Taking a necklace he created himself, putting it around Rosanna's neck, and kissing her*) "My Queen!"

Rosanna: (*Stunned*) Prince Ian: (*Running away*) "See you later, wifey!"

Rosanna: "Come here! Come here!" (*Feeling so shy and embarrassed*) "Wait, what? Why am I embarrassed?" (*Whispering to herself*) "But he is so cute." (*Smiles*) "Maybe next time I can cook for him or give him a gift or something. Of course, as a princess, I can give gifts to my subjects, so there is nothing wrong with me giving him a gift or cooking for him."

Prince Ian: "Are you still thinking of me again?"

Rosanna: "How did you get here?!"

Prince Ian: "I came back for one more kiss. I miss you too much."

Rosanna: "Well, I can kiss you on your forehead. That's formal."

Prince Ian: "But we're husband and wife, though."

Rosanna: "I am only eight years old."

Prince Ian: "More reason for us to get to know each other, and it will be nice to grow old together." (*Deep breath*) "I know I am eleven years old, just a year older than your friend. Honestly, I know what I want, and I want you."

Rosanna: (*Shy*) Prince Ian: (*Looking straight into her eyes*) "Take the time to think about it while I am in the capital. Once I am ready, I will come to get you, and we can live together safely, okay?!"

Rosanna: "How do you know that you will come back?! What if you go to the capital and find someone better, or fall deeply in love with someone else? What if, as you grow older, you forget about me?!"

Prince Ian: *(Smiling)* “I will never forget my wife. From now on, we are soulmates. I swear by heaven and earth to take you as my only wife and be faithful.”

Rosanna: “I am only eight years old. What if I forget and marry someone else?” Prince Ian: “It’s okay. I will just kill your husband and marry you.”

Rosanna: “How does that sound logical to you? How can I trust the words of a little boy?”

Prince Ian: “You cannot trust the words of a little boy, but you can trust the words of a king. It is the law.”

Rosanna: “Then do not forget to visit once you get to the capital. And you do not need to return my necklace; you can keep it.” Prince Ian: *(Holding Rosanna's cheek)* “Thank you, *binti mfalme*, for your generosity. My time is up. Take care of yourself and do not die before me. See you later, wifey!” *(He waves at her while walking toward the exit door.)*

Rosanna: *(Staring at his back, she suddenly sees his image as a grown-up)* “What is your name?!”

Prince Ian: *(Yelled back as the gate closes)* “I am Ian! Call me Ian!”

Rosanna: *(Whispering to herself)* “Ian! I saw a lion in his eyes, the grown-up version of him, so handsome. Maybe I am daydreaming... this place can make anyone crazy.”

Prophet Kafura: *(Staring at them from afar and whispering to himself)* “Our Lord and God did not change His mind.”

Narrator: Rosanna moved to a new location with better conditions, where she continued to study the history of the empire. Meanwhile, Prince Ian moved back to the capital. Ian was the son of a concubine—the third wife of his father and the fourth son in the family. His father's wife despised him and his mother. Though the king at that time was deeply in love with Prince Ian's mother, he had to marry the first daughter of the prime minister to balance power in the court, as she held control of the military. For his own safety, Ian had to flee to Hikmid, the slave village of the Empire of Boparl, where he met Rosanna, *binti mfalme* of Hikmid. The people from Hikmid had their own tradition and their own God. Now, Prince Ian had to return to the capital to face the Malkia (*ma wa baba yake*) along with his stepbrother and his sisters. At the same time, the head priest of the clothes chamber was about to meet with Jirmak, Rosanna's mother, to confirm that Rosanna was indeed a princess. However, because Prophet Kafura was no longer in the temple, Rosanna had to remain there until she turned eighteen years old.

Narrator: Rosanna lived in the temple until she turned 18 years old. Once each year, the temple would open its doors for people to visit. During this time, Rosanna was promoted to the third chamber and became a priest's assistant. Jirmak eventually found out where Rosanna was and began visiting her once a year. Once Rosanna's identity was verified, everyone who had bullied her got fired, executed, or banished. Jirmak and Prophet Kafura held a meeting, and the prophet allowed Jirmak and Tarma to visit more often to continue teaching Rosanna. However, despite all these changes, nobody dared to talk about the prophecy.

- *The Accomplishment of the Prophecy*

Narrator: Jirmak continued to teach Rosanna. Though everyone in the village knew the spell was broken, a shadow of the past remained. Jirmak wanted to make Rosanna happy in the short time they had left together. She sent Rosanna to school and allowed her to go everywhere she wished, though the sea was only permitted when her mother was there to watch over her. During those eight years, Tarma never gave up on Jirmak. He tried to be the father Rosanna deserved, attempting to apologize for the past, but Jirmak's pain over the thought of her daughter leaving was greater than any love her husband could offer. Then, on the second day of the new year, a massive ship appeared on the horizon. It was filled with soldiers flying national flags. The soldiers were assigned to bring the blue-haired girl to the palace and to destroy everything in their path. They had been assigned a dark mission: find the girl with blue hair and destroy everything in their path. The soldiers stormed the village, entering every house in search of Rosanna. People fled in terror as houses were set ablaze. Tarma, hearing the news, ran home to warn his wife. Rosanna was away at school.

Tarma: (*Knocking harder and yelling*) "Open the door! Open!" Servant: (*Opens the door*) "Hello, Mr. Tarma."

Tarma: (*Pushes him*) "Jirmak? Jirmak! Jirmak!!"

Jirmak: "Who is yelling inside my house?" Tarma: "Jirmak, the soldiers are here! Where is Rosanna?"

Jirmak: (*Confused*) "Soldiers here?"

Servant: (*Frightened*) "Princess, the imperial soldiers are here! They are looking for Miss Rosanna!"

Jirmak: (*Panic setting in*) "Rosanna? Rosanna! She is at school!"

Narrator: They all ran out to save her. The road was a nightmare, filled with the bodies of the fallen, blood everywhere, and houses engulfed in flames. When they arrived at school, the courtyard was empty, the classes were destroyed, and students lay injured. The remaining students told Tarma that Rosanna had been taken toward the ship. They had tried to fight back, but it was no use. Jirmak thanked them, and they rushed toward the docks. On the road, they finally saw them: a group of soldiers holding Rosanna captive, her hands bound tightly with a rope. Tarma charged, trying to fight the soldiers, but he was outnumbered and beaten. He refused to let go. He was knocked to the ground, nearly losing consciousness, gripping one soldier's boot with his remaining strength.

Tarma: (*Grip tightening*) "I will not let you go! Give me back my daughter!"

Soldier: "How cute, ahahaha!" Soldiers: "Ahahaha, such a brave man!" Rosanna: "You heartless monsters! Let my dad go!" (*She struggles wildly against the soldiers holding her.*)

Jirmak: "Tarma!"

Narrator: Jirmak ran to join the fight, but the soldiers shoved her away with ease. She fell hard down, and her head struck a jagged rock. The world went black as she lost consciousness.
Tarma: “JIRMAK!!!!!!!!!!”

Rosanna: *(Sobbing)* “Mom!! Let me go! Let me go! Please stop this. What did we do to you? Please... I will go with you! I will go quietly!” Soldier: *(Looking down at his trapped leg)* “She asked for it. Well, playtime is over. Time to go home. Now will you let go of my leg?” Tarma: “Never! Let go of my daughter...!”

Soldier: “Well, I didn’t want to do this...”

Narrator: The soldier took his sword and struck. Tarma twisted in agony as the blade found its mark, and then he fell still.

Rosanna: “Dad!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!” *(She screamed until her throat was raw, her cries echoing through the village.)* “My dad! Nooo!”

Jirmak: *(Opening her eyes)* “No... no, no. It isn’t real. It is just a dream; it has to be a dream.”

Narrator: She stumbled toward her husband’s body and pulled him into her arms. Jirmak: “Tarma! Tarma! Wake up! Please, do not leave me!” Tarma: *(Opening his eyes one final time)* “I am sorry... I failed you. You are the most important person in my life. I love you so much. I am sorry...”

Jirmak: “No, no, no, no! I forgive you! It’s okay... you can wake up now... Everything will be alright, okay? Talk to me! Please! Open your eyes!” *(In a frantic panic)* “Okay, then I didn’t forgive you! You can’t die! You cannot leave me! Please! Tarma! No, no, no!... I will kill you, monsters!” *(She attacks the soldiers.)*

The Painful Road Narrator: Jirmak lunged at the soldiers with a mother’s fury. One soldier drew his sword, intending only to scare her away, but the blade caught Jirmak across the eyes. Darkness swallowed her, and she went blind. Rosanna wept her heart out; she was helpless. Jirmak lay in the dirt, crying out her daughter’s name, her hands searching blindly for a touch she could no longer find. The haunting horn of the ship sang out as it pulled away from the docks. On the ship, Rosanna was locked in a cold room. Back in the village, the survivors buried their dead. Now blind and broken, Jirmak was taken in by Prophet Kafura, the only leader left alive in the village. The journey to the capital took two years. During this time, the king of Boparl passed away four years before Rosanna’s capture, and his fourth son became king. Rosanna was eighteen, and the new king was twenty-two. Royal Guard: *(Announcing)* “Presenting here... King Benson!” King Benson: “Where is my future wife?!” Royal Soldier: *(Pushes Rosanna forward)* King Benson: *(Steps forward and pulls her into a hug)* “Oh, my beautiful Rosanna, long time no see! How have you been?” *(He looks at the guards, his voice hardening)* “Why is my wife tied up?” Rosanna: *(Looking at him and whispering to herself)* “He knows my name?” Soldiers: “Your wife was very stubborn, Sire. We had no choice.”

King Benson: “Well, as long as she is in one piece, that is all I need. Great work, my men. Every single one of you shall receive a reward!”

Rosanna: (*Lunging at the king in a sudden attack*) “So it is YOU? You are the one who destroyedldiers: “Thank you, our king!”

King Benson: (*Catching Rosanna easily, he holds her and picks her up*) “I miss you too. Slow down.”

King Benson: “Maids!”

Maids: (*Appearing instantly*) “Present! Your Majesty!”

Concubine Tiju: (*Watching from a far distance, whispering to herself*) “So that is Rosanna. They should have killed her in the village. Now I have more work to do.”

King Benson: “Take my future wife to her quarters to rest. Bath her and make her presentable!”

Maid: “Yes, Sire!!”

Narrator: The maids escorted Rosanna to her new palace. Rosanna’s room was personally chosen by the king, and everything inside was exclusive and grand. She had a small army of maids to serve her, and everyone worked to welcome her warmly. But Rosanna’s mind was left in the dark. She kept playing that terrible death scene over in her head. The maid bathed her, changed her clothes, and finally put her to bed. Later that night, the king came to visit her room quietly and watched her while she slept. When he finally left, he asked the maids, “How is she doing?”

Narrator: After the king visited Rosanna, he spoke with the maids for a while, giving them strict instructions to follow. In the palace, the king also had three high-ranking concubines. Each concubine held a specific rank, and the higher the rank, the more power and authority they wielded. The first concubine was Tiju, known among the palace maids for her cruelty, jealousy, and pride. She was the daughter of the prime minister, a man feared and respected in the court. Tiju was also a childhood friend of the king. The second concubine was Rika, the daughter of the king’s maternal aunt. While the nation praised Rika and Tiju for their grace and beauty, Rika was a different kind of threat: she was kind on the surface, but a master manipulator. The third was Waiwe, the king's childhood friend and the niece of the king’s mother, the imperial consort; she was in charge of the harem.

Concubine Tiju: (*Smiling coldly*) “The king just brought home a new woman... I think it is time to pay her a sweet visit, maids!”

Maids: “Present, my lady!”

Concubine Tiju: “Gather some gifts and food. We must welcome our new guest properly!” (*She says with a smug grin.*)

Narrator: While Concubine Tiju prepares for her visit, Rosanna finally wakes up. Under the care of her maids, she looked like a goddess. They helped her comb her hair, dressed her in exquisite new silks, and applied her makeup. Rosanna chose one maid, Guana, to be the leader of her staff. Guana: “Master! You look so beautiful. It is no wonder why the king chose you. The other concubines should fear you, for you clearly have the king’s favor.”

Rosanna: *(Looking deeply sad)* “I am not here for power, riches, or favor. I just want to go home.”

Concubine Tiju: *(Entering Rosanna’s palace as the maids bow down in fear)* “I hope your attention is true! So you are the new girl? I don’t like you. I do not know what is wrong with the king leaving all these worthy women in the capital for... this.” *(Fake smile)*

Rosanna: “Yes, I am. And you are?”

Concubine Tiju: *(With immense pride)* “I am the master of the women's arena. All the palaces belong to me; I am in charge here. The only person above me is the king himself.”

Concubine Rika: *(Entering the palace and telling the maids to rise)* “Are you sure, sister? Do not ruin our family name. Remember there is still an imperial consort above us all.”

Maids: *(Standing up)* “Thank you, Concubine Rika!”

Concubine Rika: “You know, sister, it is not nice to keep people bowing for too long.” *(She turns to Rosanna)* “Hello, Rosanna! Welcome to the palace!”

Rosanna: “Thank you, concubine... huh...?”

Concubine Rika: “I am Rika, but you may call me sister! We are all sisters here! After all, we are serving the same man.” *(She says this with a playful glint in her eyes, clearly trying to irritate Tiju.)*

Concubine Tiju: *(Rolling her eyes and looking away in annoyance)*

Concubine Rika: “I hope my sister was being kind to you. She can lose her temper sometimes, so you must be very careful around her.”

Concubine Tiju: “Are you saying I am wicked?”

Adviser: *(Calling out)* “King Benson is here!!”

Narrator: King Benson entered Rosanna’s palace. Everyone instantly bowed their heads in respect—except for Rosanna. She remained standing, her eyes locked onto his with a gaze of pure, straight hate.

King Benson: *(Calmly, to the room)* “You can all rise!” *(He looks at Rosanna, seemingly unfazed by her defiance.)*

King Benson: “Rosanna, you look well.”

Rosanna: “No thanks to you! I will never forget what you did!”

Concubine Rika: *(Interrupting)* “Did something happen between you two?”

King Benson: *(Confused, but masking it)* "Couple's problem. You are all dismissed; I want to be alone with my future wife."

Rosanna: "I will never marry you! I'd rather die. I hate you!"

King Benson: *(Laughs)* "I love your character; no wonder I fell for you the first time I saw you, hahaha. Well, my soldiers told me that your mom is still alive! Maybe my soldiers should pay her a small visit? What do you think?"

Rosanna: "You are such an evil man! I will kill you with my own hands, monster!"

King Benson: *(Smiling)* "Why do you hate me so much? Our wedding is coming up; smile, please! Your face looks scary." *(As he leaves the room)*

Concubines: *(Smirking)* "Well, we are leaving. Take care of our future sister."

Concubine Rika: *(Hissing in a quiet corner)* "She will never become queen; I will never allow it. Tiju, you were supposed to get the job done. Why is she still alive? The imperial consort is furious. You know how she gets when things do not go her way!"

Concubine Tiju: *(Panicking)* "I know! I thought the guards got the job done. Let's hope the king doesn't find out. I hate her. Did you see her room? Her courtyard? How expensive and unique is everything? Just for a village girl! She isn't worthy of any of it! I hate her, I want her dead!"

Concubine Rika: "Get it done quickly, or we can't keep you in this palace. It is either you or her. You pick." *(She turns and leaves without waiting for an answer.)*

Concubine Tiju: *(Clenching her fists, muttering to herself)* "They always see me as their servant, just here to get their dirty work done. If we weren't from the same family, I would kill them both."

Personal Maid: "My lady, this is very dangerous. If the issue gets discovered, we will be the first to fall. Your sister and cousin will keep their hands clean, and we will be the hand they cut off!"

Concubine Tiju: "Don't you think I know that?! Make everything I told you ready. We have a sheep to kill. The old way. Since I offered her mercy and she refused, I will make sure she begs me to kill her."

Rosanna: *(Sitting on her bed)* "Why is this happening to me? I did not ask for this." *(She sighs deeply, starting to tear up as her memories come flooding back)* "Maid!"

Maid Guana: "Master, look at the situation positively. If you get married to the king, you will have the power to do whatever you want, even visit your home or rebuild your village."

Rosanna: "But all the power in the universe will not bring back my dad or give back my mom's eyes. I need to be alone. You are dismissed."

Maid Guana: "Okay." *(Gently bows and leaves the room)*

Concubine Tiju: *(Back in her own palace quarters, she throws things onto the floor and breaks some glasses)* “I cannot believe he left the council court just to make sure that lowly girl was safe! How dare she take his attention away from me? I will teach her a lesson! Rika is only powerful because she is directly related to the king. The king never touched me, not even once, never. Every time he says he is saving himself for someone... if that person is that village girl, she must die. I hate my family and this courtyard. I must be the future queen; I will never let them look down on me.” *(She grabs a whip and takes her anger out on the furniture.)* Concubine Rika: “Well, well, well! This new girl is really something. Wow, I never expected anyone to dare stand up to the king. Things will be very interesting. The king left the court just to protect her... wow, how sweet. Tonight, the harem will not sleep.” *(She smiles, though her eyes are filled with anger.)*

King's Advisor: “My dear king, you look happy today!”

King Benson: *(Laughing softly)* “Ahahaha, why would I not be? I am getting married tomorrow! But I do not know why she is angry with me.” Advisor: “Well, the girl looks like a goddess, but she is so ungrateful and has no manners. Are you sure you want her? Because my bed is free, ahahaha!”

King Benson: *(Instantly slaps him across the face)* “That woman is my future wife!”

Advisor: *(Kneeling in terror)* “I am sorry, King! I overstepped my boundaries!” King Benson: “I have been waiting for this moment my whole life, and now it finally comes. You are dismissed!”

Advisor: “Okay!” *(The advisor leaves the throne room in a hurry, exiting the main palace. Fuming with humiliation, he marches straight toward his daughter Rika's quarters and bursts inside.)*

Maid: *(Bowing low)* “Good evening, sir.” Advisor: “Rise. Where is my daughter?”

Maid: “She is in her room, sir.”

Advisor: *(To the maid)* “You are dismissed.” *(He storms into the inner chamber)* “Rika! Rika!”

Concubine Rika: “Dad! Come in... please sit. Let me call the maid to serve you some tea.”

Advisor: “No need for a maid. I am fine. Listen to me. I heard the king brought a new woman to the palace and he plans to make her queen. I thought you got rid of her. Why is she still in the palace?” Concubine Rika: “Dad, what is wrong? Are you scared of slaves?”

Advisor: “The new girl! We must get rid of her as soon as we can!”

Concubine Rika: “That useless Tiju put us in all of this mess. Dad, you are worrying for nothing; she is not a challenge at all. I have a million ways to make her disappear. But you know the imperial consort is in prayer. We need to clean up this mess fast before she ends her isolation.”

Advisor: “Look, I almost got killed because of her. The king never slapped me for any reason, but today he slapped me for a woman, a slave! Rika, you must be careful. The crown must belong to our family just as it always has.”

Concubine Rika: (*Laughing hollowly*) “Ahahaha! When did the king ever care about anyone? And if Rosanna actually became a challenge, the king's mother will take care of her. Rosanna is just a lowly nobody, and the king's childhood sweetheart, the imperial consort, is still useful. Do not worry, Dad. That slap you took—our little slave will pay!”

Imperial Consort: (*Emerging from her isolation, her voice cold and dripping with rage*) “So she is finally here. I saw my brother drawing a picture of her. I hope the palace welcomes her well. I spent years and years helping my brother build this palace, hoping that he was building it for me. But ahahaha, he gave it to a slave! How dare a slave steal what is mine? She must die, and all those useless pawns who failed to get rid of her! My dad is the prime minister, and the king's mother is my aunt. My uncle controls the military. My brother is a general. I am the king's sweetheart and imperial consort, ahahaha!” (*She smashes her glass to the ground in a fury.*)

Concubine Tiju: (*On the floor, bleeding*) “Sorry, sister! Give me one more chance! One more chance! I will get rid of that village girl. I promise!”

Imperial Consort: (*With a knife in her hand, cutting flowers*) “One more chance? I hate people who are useless, and keeping you around is a lost cause. Maybe I should start preparing for your replacement. My dear Tiju, because I am so generous, I will forgive you. I will give you one more chance. Go tell the harem that the imperial consort is back, and everyone must pay their respects, including the new girl. Before the king finds out about the slave village, you must clean up the mess, or you will be cut off...” (*She holds Tiju's face*) “Tiju, I brought you to this palace, and I can get rid of you at any time, ahahaha.” (*She walks away into an inner court.*) Concubine Tiju: (*Terrified and shaking on the ground*) “I will not disappoint you!”

Personal Maid: (*Entering the imperial consort's chamber*) “Concubine Tiju, what do we do?”

Concubine Tiju: (*Bleeding on her face*) “Spread rumors. Tell everyone there is a witch in the palace who cursed the king and who caused the king's advisor to fall out of favor. Take a cursed doll, hide it in Rosanna's courtyard, and let the show play out. Also, send the imperial consort our gift too! Hahaha... a big show is coming.”

Maid: “It shall be done!” Imperial Consort: “Kneel!”

Concubine Rika: (*Immediately kneels*)

Imperial Consort: “You are the one who asked me to bring that useless Tiju into the palace, mentioning that she is our sister and the more from our family, the more power we have. But she only caused us problems!” (*She breaks a glass cup*) “I trusted your judgment; I thought you were smart!” Concubine Rika: “Please, sister, do not be angry at me. I trusted Tiju too; I thought she was a capable person. It turns out I was wrong.” Imperial Consort: (*Takes her seat on her couch*) “And so?”

Concubine Rika: “I will personally make sure things are done properly, and no trace is left. Nobody will track this back to you and me.”

Imperial Consort: (*Holds Rika's hand and helps her stand up*) "My dear sister, you know all of this is for our good—for your good. You are the only person I can trust in this palace. Although we are not from the same parents, we grew up together and assist each other. We cannot lose now, especially to a village girl."

Concubine Rika: (*Standing up, her knees bleeding*) "My dear sister, I will make sure it never happens. The crown can only belong to you and our family."

Imperial Consort: "That is good to hear. Go back to your palace. I will send the imperial doctor to check your wound and heal it without scars."

Concubine Rika: "Thank you, sister." Imperial Consort: "By the way, leave by the back door of my palace. I do not want any rumors."

Maid Weiwei: "Concubine Rika just left through the back door."

Imperial Consort: "Good. Send the imperial doctor to Rika, pick out some gifts, and send them to her." Maid Weiwei: "Your Highness is still so kind to Concubine Rika!"

Imperial Consort: "Well, she is the only friend I have."

Maid Weiwei: "Hopefully she can see your kindness." Imperial Consort: "I am tired. You are dismissed!"

Narrator: The greeting meeting of the imperial consort was scheduled after sundown, and all the king's women were present. But Rosanna was absent.

Imperial Consort: (*In the greeting palace*) "Welcome, all my sisters! It is so good to see you all. You know about my health issues... I just ended my prayer, and I wanted to spend some time with my sisters!"

Concubines: "Greetings, Imperial Consort! May you live long!"

Imperial Consort: (*Takes a sip of her tea*) "Thank you, my sisters. You may all sit down. I brought a few gifts for each of you. Please do not be shy; take as much as you can!"

Concubines: "Thank you for your generosity!" (*They all grab gifts according to their rank.*)

Imperial Consort: "I heard that the king brought us a sister from a different region. Where is she?"

Consort Sioma: "Sister, present yourself!... What is her name again?"

Concubine Rika: "Rosanna. She is so stunning, you would never believe that she is a slave!"

Concubines: (*Laughing*) "Ahahaha!"

Imperial Consort: "I heard that she caused the king's advisor to lose favor with the king, hahaha."

Concubine Rika: (*Angry*)

Concubines: “He got slapped too, ahaha! Who thought that would ever happen?” Imperial Consort: *(Giggles)* “Calm down, sister. We are all family here.”

Concubine Tiju: “A slap to my uncle is a slap to our entire family. We will not let it go. Maid, where is Rosanna?” Maid: “We do not know.”

Concubine Rika: “What?! So this slave thinks she is above us all and dares not show up? I think we need to teach her a lesson about the laws of this palace. Maid, bring us that seductress here!”

Rosanna: *(Enters the Greeting Palace of Virtue)* “I am sorry, my sisters. Greetings, Imperial Consort!” Consort Sioma: “How dare you make us wait for you?”

Concubines: “Because you think you have the king’s favor, that’s why you dare disrespect us and the harem!”

Concubine Tiju: *(Standing up and bowing to the imperial consort)* “Imperial Consort, I think Rosanna should be punished for breaking harem laws and disrespecting the monarchy!” Imperial Consort: *(Smiles)* “Sister, stand up. Rosanna is a new member of the palace; she does not know the regulations yet. She should be forgiven, at least this once. I do not want rumors to spread that I came out of seclusion and immediately started punishing the king’s women.”

Concubine Tiju: “If you do not punish her, everyone will follow in her footsteps and disrespect this palace. Please make an example out of her!”

Concubines: *(All the concubines get out of their chairs and bow down)* “Please, Imperial Consort, make an example out of her!”

Imperial Consort: “If Rosanna can give us an acceptable reason why she is late, she will be forgiven.”

Rosanna: “Thank you, Imperial Consort, for your kindness. I heard that the Imperial Consort is suffering from a cough. In my homeland, we sometimes drink water from flowers to ease our chests. I woke up early and started collecting the dew drops on each flower, but I lost track of time. Please, Imperial Consort, punish me. Guana, give the drink to the imperial consort!”

Guana: *(Walks with the drink and hands it to the imperial consort’s personal maid, who then serves the imperial consort.)*

Imperial Consort: *(Drinks the water)* “For such devotion, my sister Rosanna, you are forgiven. Please, everyone, sit, and let’s talk. So, the birthday of the king’s mother is coming up. What are your ideas about the party?!”

Narrator: Suddenly, the imperial consort feels dizzy and faints.

Concubine Rika: “Sister! Call the imperial doctor fast! Call them, call them!”

Narrator: In the imperial consort's inner chamber, the doctors and King Benson arrive. King Benson: “What happened here?!”

Concubine Rika: "We do not know! She suddenly fainted!" Imperial Doctor: "Your Majesty, the imperial consort will recover soon, but there is a problem"

King Benson: "A problem? What type of problem?"

Imperial Doctor: "She has been poisoned."

Concubines: "What? How?"

Concubines: *(In terror, they all bow down)* "Please calm down, Your Majesty!"

Concubine Tiju: "It is Rosanna!"

Rosanna: "What? No, it is not me!"

Concubine Tiju: "You are the one who gave the drink to my sister before she fainted. You are a murderer!"

Rosanna: "No, I did not poison her! Oh, Your Majesty, I am innocent!" Consort Sioma: "Bring the drink and let the doctor test it to see if it is poison."

Narrator: The doctor holds the water in the cup and uses a needle to test for poison. Imperial Doctor: "Your Majesty, it is poison."

Rosanna: *(Stands up)* "Impossible! I did not bring poison! I am innocent!"

Concubines: "You are the one who collected it and gave it to Her Highness!"

Rosanna: *(Thinking)* "The imperial consort's personal maid and Guana touched it too... It could be anyone."

Imperial Consort's Maid: "I have served my lady since she was a child. I love her like a mother. Are you saying I poisoned her? If I wanted to poison her, why now?"

Concubine Tiju: "Let every chamber of all the king's women be searched! The chamber where the poison is found is the chamber of the guilty party."

King Benson: "I agree! The guards will search each palace for poison!"

Imperial Guards: "Yes, oh King!"

Narrator: All the concubines and the king stay in the inner chamber of the imperial consort while the guards search each room.

Guards: "We found poison and a cursed doll!"

Concubines: "What? This type of practice is banned in the palace! Who would do such a thing?"

Concubine Tiju: *(Smiles)*

King Benson: "Where did you find it?"

Imperial Guard: "In Rosanna's inner chambers, and the cursed doll has a date on it." Rosanna: "No, no, no, no! It is not true, I am innocent! I did not do it!"

Consort Sioma: "Guards, take Rosanna and her maid into the interrogation room and torture them until they confess!"

Guards: "Yes!"

Rosanna: "I am innocent!!"

Narrator: The guards carry Rosanna and her maid to the prison to torture them. For four days in the prison, she was beaten, cut, tied down, and starved. After two days, the imperial consort woke up and had dinner with the king. Concubines Tiju and Rika decide to finish the job; they go to visit Rosanna in the prison to eliminate her while the king is out of the imperial palace.

Concubine Tiju: "Hey Rossee, Rosee, hahahah!"

Rosanna: (*Lying down, exhausted*) "Help!"

Concubine Rika: (*Slapping her*) "Ahaha, you slave, how dare you touch me!"

Rosanna: "I never did anything to you. Why harm me?"

Concubine Tiju: "Ahahahahaha, just looking at your face makes me angry! You slave, how dare you see yourself as our equal?!"

Rosanna: "In the eyes of God, there are no slaves; we are all equal." Concubine Rika: "Let your God save you then! Guards, kill her immediately!" Guards: (*Draw their swords and walk toward Rosanna.*)

Rosanna: "No! No, no, no!"

Concubine Tiju: "As a goodbye gift... I heard how much you love your village. Well, I am the one who destroyed your village, ahahaha. I burned it, destroyed it, ahahahah. Sweet dreams, Rosanna, ahaha."

Narrator: The concubines start walking away toward the exit of the prison as the guards drag Rosanna down to stab her.

King Benson: "Stop it now! Stay back! Rosanna, Rosanna... I am so sorry I am late."

Concubines: (*Bowing down to the king*) "Your Majesty, you are back so early." King Benson: (*Carrying Rosanna*) "Let go. I knew everything."

Narrator: He took Rosanna to his chamber and called the imperial doctor to treat her. The king called all the concubines to the throne room for interrogation.

King Benson: "How dare you touch my woman? You must wish for death for yourself and your family! Rika and Tiju, how dare you go against my order?"

Concubines: “Forgive us, forgive us!” Guards: *(Announcing)* “Here comes the imperial consort!” Imperial Consort: *(Bowing down)* “Greetings, Your Majesty! I heard about what happened to Rosanna! Forgive me for my inability to take care of the harem. Please, Your Majesty, punish me too.”

King Benson: “Please stand up. I know about your health. Take a seat.”

Imperial Consort: *(Immediately takes a seat and stares at her sisters)* “What is Your Majesty planning to do in this matter?”

King Benson: *(In anger, standing with a sword)* “The cursed doll was not a cursed doll. The date that was on it was Rosanna's birthday, and the poison was not Rosanna's doing. Someone bribed the maid and asked her to put poison in the drink. And who gave the order to burn the slave village? I never gave the order to burn or destroy the village! Tiju, who did it?”

Concubines: “We do not know. Please calm down.” Concubine Tiju: “Your Majesty, I am innocent! I never left the capital; I do not know anything about a slave village or Rosanna.” Consort Sioma: “Yes! We all met Rosanna here in the palace for the first time!”

King Benson: “Ahahah, do you take me for a fool, or stupid?”

Concubine: *(Terrified)*

King Benson: *(Walks toward Tiju and holds her face)* “Tell me who gave the order!!!!” Concubine Tiju: *(Looks at the imperial consort)*

Imperial Consort: *(Crying)* “I cannot believe you did something like this, Tiju! You dare burn the slave village and kill millions of people? You are so vicious! You deserve to die! You ruined our family name. What will your mother and your brother say when they hear this?!”

Concubine Tiju: “No, no, I did not! I did not! Your Majesty, listen, listen—”

Narrator: King Benson draws his sword and strikes Tiju. She falls to the ground, cold and lifeless. The court was quiet and terrified. King Benson: “Who ordered the guards to burn the slave village?? Rika, who did it?” *(He holds Rika up by her neck)* “How dare you try to kill my wife?”

Concubine Rika: *(Out of breath)* “I am sorry! Spare my life, please! Please! Remember our childhood! Please, just this once!”

King Benson: *(Squeezing harder)* “Join your sister.”

Guards: “Imperial Grand Queen, the mother of the king, is here!” Imperial Grand Queen: “Enough! Are you planning to kill my family for a slave?!” King Benson: “So what?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “You are not even willing to show your own mom respect?”

King Benson: *(Still holding Rika)* “When they abused my woman, did they show me respect?!”
Imperial Grand Queen: “If you spare her life, I will let Rosanna live in the palace and you can promote her.”

King Benson: “I am marrying her, not promoting her. She is my wife.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “How about you let her live in the palace for a while and get training before you give her the queen title?”

Imperial Consort: “No, Auntie, no...”

King Benson: “Okay, as you wish, Mother. Rika is banished to the cold palace with no servants and nobody to visit her. Her family will be sent to the border as slaves, never to return to the capital. Rosanna will be promoted as imperial noble consort to be in training to be queen! Second only to me.”

Imperial Consort: “No, brother, no!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Stop it, Imperial Consort.” Rika: “Thank you for your mercy, King Benson!”

King Benson: “Guards, take this dead body, feed it to the wolves, and take Rika away!” Imperial Grand Queen: *(Whispering)* “Imperial Consort, we retreat for now.” Concubines: “Even though the Imperial Grand Queen is not the birth mother of King Benson, he still shows respect to her. You know, the Imperial Grand Queen accused the biological mother of the king of having an affair with a guard. She was banished to a temple, and the king had to escape to a small village for his safety, though he later returned to reclaim his seat and fight for the throne. The queen’s own son died, so she had to adopt King Benson as her own. Nobody knows what happened to the king’s biological mother, and the king doesn’t like people talking about it. No wonder their family always looks down on King Benson, because he is the child of a disgraced concubine. I believe that is why King Benson is so protective of Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna.”

Narrator: The king went back to his inner chamber, looking at Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna lying unconscious.

King Benson: “Doctor, how is Rosanna?!”

Imperial Doctor: “Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna’s condition has stabilized. We just have to pray and hope that she wakes up.”

King Benson: “Well, I cannot just do that! Can you do anything else? I will reward you greatly!”
Imperial Doctor: “My dear King, I already worked on her wound; it will not leave any scars, and I stabilized her health. Now we just pray to God.”

King Benson: “Which God? In my empire, there are so many gods. But they seem to fail me whenever I need them.” Imperial Doctor: “Then, my King, pray to whoever answers you.”

King Benson: (*The king holds Rosanna's hand and looks at the imperial doctor*) "You are dismissed."

Imperial Doctor: "Thank you!"

Narrator: The doctor left the king's palace, and the king was left alone with Rosanna in the inner court. The king cried bitterly.

King Benson: "Rosanna *binti mfalme*, I love you so much. I am so sorry. I brought you here because I thought that we would live well together and grow old and grey. I did not think of all the challenges and pain you would face. I forgot how dangerous the palace is and how cruel the women in the palace are. I never imagined they would target you, your family, and your village. Because of me and my selfish desires, you got hurt. I am sorry, so sorry. It is me, Ian, the little boy at the lake and at the temple. You can wake up and look at me and remember me!" (*King Benson cried bitterly.*)

Narrator: King Benson left his inner chamber, walking in his garden and thinking. King's Eunuch: "My King, what bothers thee?"

King Benson: "A lot is on my head."

King's Eunuch: "The king's mind is deeper than the sea; I cannot reach it. But if you share your worries with me, your servant will do whatever it takes to lighten your burden. Please, my King, share your worries!"

King Benson: "Do you remember when we visited Hikmid?"

King's Eunuch: "Of course I remember. After your biological mother got accused of adultery and sent to the temple, you and I escaped to Farisa, to the small slave village called Hikmid. That was a fun, crazy, and dangerous time, my King."

King Benson: "Do you remember that little girl that jumped in the sea to save me?" King's Eunuch: "Of course, my King! How can I forget such an audacious woman, daring to disrespect my king? She should have been punished! But, my King, I recall you really loved that little girl. I also remember that after her dad picked her up, you spent years and years looking for her in the state of Farisa. And one day we met Prophet Kafura, who took us to the temple, where we saw your mother and that little girl. Ahaha, my King, you would spend time teasing her and playing together. After your father died, we had to return to the capital."

King Benson: "Ahahah, yes! She was so brave, daring, direct, and funny! She gave me the courage to return to the capital and fight for the throne. Who I am today is because of her and all the memories we made together. The funny part is, even in the harsh conditions of the temple, she had that dignified look and kept her faith and trust in God. I wish I had that too." (*The king looks at the necklace around his neck.*) King's Eunuch: "I also remember, my King, you told me that she gave you a necklace, and you said it was an engagement gift, and you also gave her a necklace that you handmade!"

King Benson: (*Holds the necklace around his neck and smiles*) “Yes, yes. She does not even remember.”

King’s Eunuch: “Maybe the king should find her and tell her?!”

King Benson: “After all the things that happened, do you think she will forgive me? Do you think we still have a chance? Will she take me back? Hear me and understand me? All these years I longed for a time like this. To hold her, kiss her, make love all night, and wake up to her face... was it all a fantasy?”

King’s Eunuch: “Who is that woman who worries you so much, my King? To the end of this earth, I will find her and bring her forth!” King Benson: “Ahaha, she is already in the palace!”

King’s Eunuch: “Who? Where? How? And why is the king sad if the woman is in the palace? Hmm... wait, my King. It’s her! Rosanna!”

King Benson: (*Angry*)

King’s Eunuch: “I mean, Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna... the future queen?!”

King Benson: (*Smiles*)

King’s Eunuch: “My dear King, I believe you should tell her when she wakes up!”

King Benson: “Do you think she will wake up?”

King’s Eunuch: “My King, definitely. I heard that the people of Hikmid served the real God. If their God is real, I believe Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna will wake up. We should be patient and have faith.”

King Benson: “I do not want to lose her.”

King’s Eunuch: “My King, you will not lose her. God did not bring you both together just to bring death.” Narrator: In the Imperial Grand Queen’s palace—the Palace of Rest... Imperial Consort: “Auntie, why did you agree?! Why did you say yes to the king? And to that slave?” Imperial Grand Queen: “Calm down, calm down, Imperial Consort.” Imperial Consort: “You promised me! Auntie, you promised me that you would make me queen! That is all I was raised and trained for—to one day be queen as you were! Will you let that village girl be queen?! Will you let that lowly woman from nowhere sit on top of us?”

Imperial Grand Queen: “I said calm down. If I did not stop the king, do you think you would even be standing up right now? I have been telling you to get pregnant and bear me a child. What have you provided? You have no leverage to hold the king accountable.”

Imperial Consort: (*Looks away*) “But, Auntie, you know about my health. The king is working for me to recover so I can conceive well.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Now you are back in the palace, it is well. I will send the king to your chambers. Make sure you do not let him leave until something enters your stomach.”

Imperial Consort: “Do you think this is the right time? Currently, the king is angry, and all his attention is focused on that slave girl.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “You will have to figure out how to get his attention back to you. I will make sure that slave girl stays asleep forever.”

Imperial Consort: “Yes, Imperial Grand Queen! I know you will never abandon me!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Go back to your chamber. I will send the king to you. Make yourself ready!”

Imperial Consort: “I will not disappoint you!” *(She whispers to herself)* “All of this is because of that useless Rika and Tiju. If they had taken care of business properly, I would never be in this situation; they are truly useless. Auntie, I will go to my chamber to prepare for the king's visit.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “You are dismissed!”

Narrator: The imperial consort and her women left the Palace of Rest to go back to her chamber. The Imperial Grand Queen called King Benson to her palace.

Imperial Guards: “King Benson is here!”

Maids: “Welcome, King Benson, to the Palace of Rest!” King Benson: *(As the king takes a seat)* “You may rise. Mother, you called me?”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Yes, King. I am worried about the royal lineage; you are now 22. I went to the harem to produce an heir. Now the imperial consort is back in the palace, I believe it is a great time to have kids. You and the imperial consort have known each other since you were kids, so I know this matter will not be a problem for both of you. And her health is fully recovered; it will not be hard for her to conceive.”

King Benson: “Mother, I understand you. All the ministers in my court have been telling me the same thing. But my queen alone should be the one who gives birth to my children.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “The imperial consort has been following you since she was a kid, and she is from our royal bloodline. I believe she is qualified for such a task.”

King Benson: “The matter of an heir—I prefer to be the one who decides on it.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Well, I understand. The imperial consort was wrong today. I believe you owe her an explanation. How about you spend the night at her palace to comfort her? I would greatly appreciate it, and our family too.”

King Benson: *(Standing to leave)* “I heard you. Take care of your health.” *(Whispering to himself)* “The Imperial Grand Queen's brother is the prime minister, Rika's father is my advisor, and Tiju's father is the commander of the army. All the ministers only listen to the Imperial

Grand Queen. All the power and treasure of this palace are held by her, and her excuse is that I am too young to rule or have control. Fighting with her right now is a losing battle. If I give her family an heir, she will have more power, and I will be in danger. No way.”

Narrator: As the king left the Rest Palace, walking toward the imperial consort’s chamber, a maid from the cold palace stood in his way and begged him to visit Rika. The king agreed to visit Rika at the cold palace.

Imperial Guard: “King Benson is here!”

Rika: (*Standing up in the inner cold of the cold palace and bowing down*) “Welcome, my King!”

King Benson: “Why did you call me here?”

Rika: “Now I have nothing left... what else is there to hide?”

King Benson: (*Standing between the entrance, about to leave*) “Then we have nothing to talk about. Stay here, stay quiet, and you will die in your old age.”

Rika: “Wait, my King!” King Benson: “What else is there to say?”

Rika: “My dear King, do you remember when we were children? When your mother got sent to the cold palace and transferred to the temple, the queen wanted to kill you. I helped you escape the palace and got punished by the queen. I got sent to the cold palace when I was 5 years old and abused by the guards. When you returned to the capital, you promised me that in the future, you would repay me for such a sacrifice. Please, my King, remember!”

King Benson: “So what do you want?”

Rika: “If the king can show me some mercy, only this time, repay me completely and restore my crown!”

King Benson: “In this world, nobody is as important as my wife. I will never forget what you did to my wife, but at the same time, I owe you my life. I will repay your kindness. You are now Imperial Consort Rika. You will live next to your sister, the imperial consort, but your family will stay forever at the border to pay for the harm you caused to my wife.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Thank you, my King. I will never forget your kindness.”

Narrator: King Benson left the cold palace and walked toward the imperial consort’s palace, but an imperial guard ran to him and told him that Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna had awakened! The king rushed back to his palace and met with the Imperial Grand Queen’s doctor. The doctor was trying to check Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna.

King Benson: “I do not remember seeing you in the palace. Who are you?”

Doctor: “I work in the department of medicine, and today is my turn to take care of Imperial Noble Consort... Rosanna!”

King Benson: "Where is my personal imperial doctor?" Doctor: "Lately, our department has been busy treating noble ladies and concubines, so—"

King Benson: "So what? He is in charge of taking care of the king! Why would he be busy with other duties? Guards, go and bring the imperial doctor!"

Imperial Guard: "Yes, Your Majesty!" Narrator: The king entered his inner chamber and saw Rosanna sitting on his bed. He ran to her with a big smile, calling her name.

King Benson: (*Holding her*) "Rosanna!! Rosanna! You are finally awake!! I am so happy!"
Rosanna: "Where am I?! What happened?"

Guana: (*Crying*) "Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna, you have been asleep for 2 days and 2 nights! You scared us!"

Rosanna: "Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna?!"

King Benson: (*Smiling with eyes full of tears*) "I know such a title is too small, but you need to be trained in politics, regulations, and harem etiquette, so I had to compromise. But once you recover and finish your training, we will get married, and you will be officially my legal wife and my queen."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "My head hurts so much... Wait, where are Tiju and Rika? They have to pay for what they did to my village and me!"

Guana: "Your Highness, Tiju is dead, and Rika is in the cold palace, and her family is banished to the border to work as slaves."

King Benson: "Well, I recently took Rika out of the cold palace. I promoted her to imperial consort, but her family will serve at the border as slaves forever."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "Why?! You know what they did to me and my village! Why would you let her go so easily?!"

King Benson: "It is complicated, but it is all to keep you safe. The situation is complicated."
Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "You are the king! What situation is complicated? Tiju is dead; I want her dead too!"

Guard: "Imperial Consort Rika is here!"

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Entering the king's inner chambers and kneeling down*) "Greetings, My King and Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna."

Maids: "Greetings, Imperial Consort Rika!"

Imperial Consort Rika: "I am very sorry, Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna. I was full of bitterness and desire; I was blinded by hatred and caused you and your village so much harm. Please forgive me!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “I will never forgive you! You will pay for what you did to the slave village!” *(She coughs and faints.)*

King Benson: “Rosanna! Rosanna! Where is the imperial doctor?!”

Guards: “My King, we looked everywhere, but we did not find him.”

King Benson: “What and how? He was supposed to be in charge of Rosanna’s health!”

Guana: “I heard that the Grand Queen called him to check on her health, but since then, nobody has seen him.”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Glaring at the maid)* “Maybe something happened on the road, or he had a family emergency and left the palace.”

Guana: “Your Majesty, I know a few things about medicine. If it pleases the king, let me check on Imperial Consort Rosanna!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “How dare you, a slave, try to touch a noble lady of the palace?! My King, how about you let *this* doctor check Rosanna and give her some medicine?!”

King Benson: “Hmmm...”

Guana: “I have been serving my lady since she arrived at the palace. I know her best, my King.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “But you have no experience or training! You are just a maid. Your Majesty, I worry about the imperial noble consort’s health too. We cannot trust her life to a maid!” King Benson: “I think—”

Guana: “My King, give me a chance! If things go wrong, I will pay with my life!”

King Benson: “Okay, check my wife!” Imperial Consort Rika: “But, Your Majesty!”

King Benson: “My decision is final! Go back to your palace and do not leave until I call you!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Your Majesty! Okay... I shall!” *(She leaves the palace angrily and whispers to herself)* “Rosanna must pay for everything she did to my family. It will not end like this.”

Narrator: The maid was able to stabilize Rosanna. Rosanna slept peacefully in the king's inner chambers. In the morning, the imperial consort found out that the king spent his night with Rosanna and that Rika was now the same rank as her. She was filled with anger and destroyed her personal belongings.

Imperial Consort Weka: “What? What?! Rika... that stupid Rika?! How is it possible?! How can she have the same rank as me?! The king has no mercy on me, nor does he pity me. How can he do this to me? Does he not have me in his heart? Why humiliate me like this? I am angry! Now I have to bow down to that slave and to Rika!” *(Breaking glass, cups, and plates, throwing her palace into chaos)*

Maid: “Remember, Your Highness, the Grand Queen promised you that you will be queen, and Rika will never compare to you. She is born from a concubine, and you are born from the main house. So you will always be more noble and of higher rank; she can only dream of reaching your level!”

Imperial Consort Weka: “But she was thrown into the cold palace! She should have stayed there and begged for my help! But instead, she got promoted to imperial consort just like me! WHY?!”

Maid: *(Smiles)* “But her family is still at the border. In this life, that witch will never be queen—only you will. Because in this palace, only you have clean hands!” Imperial Consort: *(Wiping her tears)* “Yes, you are right. Only me! I had no hand in the accident that happened to the slave village, and I did not harm Rosanna. So I have clean hands! It is Rika and Tiju! Ahhahahha! Yes! Go, go, call the king! Tell him I am furious, my health has collapsed again, and I am stuck in bed! Go fast, fast!!” Maid: “Yes, Your Majesty!”

Imperial Consort Weka: *(Smiling)* “For all the things I did for him, for helping him ascend to his throne... he owes me it all! Ahhahahhah! Yes, he will come, hahhah! I am his sweetheart. My auntie is the Imperial Grand Queen. My father is the prime minister, that stupid Rika’s dad, and my father’s brother is the king’s advisor, and Tiju’s father is the commander of the army. After her father finds out that Tiju is dead, he might rebel, aahaha! So the king needs me to calm down the family. I am more useful and valuable; he still has to bow down and show respect to our family. Maid! Help me take off these clothes and lie down. We have a show to play.”

Narrator: The personal maid of the imperial consort went into the throne court. The king was having a meeting with the ministers, and a minister was questioning the king about Rosanna and about her becoming his legal wife.

Minister of Revenue: *(Standing up in the middle of the court)* “Your Majesty, we heard from the palace maids that Tiju is dead, Rika was sent to the cold palace, and her family was banished to the border?!”

King’s Eunuch: *(Standing beside the king)* “It is correct. Out of jealousy, Tiju and Rika burned an entire village and caused harm to Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna. Tiju was the one who gave the imperial guards the order to burn and destroy the entire village in Hikmid in the Farisa state, and she was following Rika’s commands.”

Ministers: *(Shocked and whispering)* “What? That is horrible... exiled to the desert to be punished?”

Minister of Education: “I also heard that Rika got promoted to imperial consort? This situation is confusing, because, my King, in this situation, Rika is more guilty than Tiju!”

Ministers: “Yes! But who is the Imperial Noble Consort?! Where is she from, and which noble family is she from?!” King Benson: “What is going on in my house is my business! Do I need your permission to decide on the matters of my household? Am I the king, or are you the king?” Minister of Treasury: “But the matter of imperial noble titles and who becomes the mother of the empire involves more than the king’s household. Background, family status and titles, accomplishments, and the matter of the heir matter! Those positions are only reserved for noble families!”

Ministers: “Yes, that's right! Because we want to choose a clean royal bloodline, not impure slave blood mixed with servant blood. It is good for the king to marry a noble lady from a powerful family to stabilize the nation and increase the king's fame. Mixing different classes is not right, my King!”

King Benson: “You call yourselves noble, yet all the positions you obtained in my court were through influence, corruption, and manipulation! I tell you, this Rosanna is more noble than all of you combined! If it were up to me, you would all be executed! I am the king! I decide who I am with, who I share my bed with, who rules beside me, and that is final!” Prime Minister: “All the king’s wives come from our family. My daughter, the imperial consort, has sacrificed greatly. She is from the main family with a royal lineage and pure blood. She stood by the king’s side when you were just an illegitimate child of a concubine, and because of her love for you, we decided to stand by you and support your enthronement! Without our family, you would never sit where you are today. I believe the king should show more respect and give us some face.” King Benson: *(Angry and whispering to himself)* “The only reason you supported me was because I was a powerless prince, and you thought I would be easy to control by you and your family. If the queen’s son did not die or my father never left a formal decree, you would be the one sitting up here.”

Ministers: *(Bowing down)* “Please, our King, change your decision!”

Maid: *(Bursting into the court)* “Your Majesty! The imperial consort fainted, and her health has worsened!”

King Benson: *(Getting a headache and shaking his head)* “Meeting dismissed!”

Narrator: The king ended the meeting with the ministers and went to see the imperial consort. Once he got there and talked to her, he received news about the commander of the army—Tiju’s father, who was keeping the border safe—asking for permission to return to the capital. King Benson: *(The king enters the imperial consort’s room; it is a mess)* “What happened here? Why is this place not cleaned up? Maids, clean up this place! Where is the imperial consort?”

Maid: “She is lying down in the inner chambers, Your Majesty!”

King Benson: *(He enters the inner court and sits beside the imperial consort)* Imperial Consort: *(Playing weak)* “Your Majesty! I thought I would never see you again!”

King Benson: “Why would you think that?”

Imperial Consort: “Since the new girl entered the palace, Your Majesty has given her all his attention and never visited this palace. I thought Your Majesty forgot me.”

King Benson: “How can I forget a childhood friend? You are precious to me.”

Imperial Consort: “Is it true?” King Benson: “Yes, definitely. I know I have wronged you. You recently returned to the palace from your prayer isolation and got stuck solving harem problems from day one.”

Imperial Consort: “Your Majesty, it is my pleasure to help lighten your burden. But now there is a new head of the palace, I cannot be in charge anymore. I will have to give the seal to Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna, and now Rika is the same rank as me! The whole palace will be laughing at me!”

King Benson: “I am sorry. I know I promised you that I would never let you be wronged in this palace. I am the first person who has failed you in this matter! If I can make it up to you, tell me, what do you want?!”

Imperial Consort: *(Trying to take off the king's robes)* “I remember we have never consummated our relationship. Everyone in the palace has been saying the king is saving himself for me. Now I am back in the palace, I believe it is the right time for us to get to know each other deeper. What do you think? It will be my greatest reward to carry the king's heir!”

King Benson: “You know what happened between me and my brothers. I will never have an illegitimate heir. All my children will be born from only one woman, and that will be my wife.”

Imperial Consort: “Who is that? Are you really planning to make that village girl your wife?! In all these years I served the king, the king does not consider my feelings?! Am I just a decoration in this palace?!”

King Benson: “From a young age, I told you about Rosanna. You were the only person who knew about my feelings for her and her existence. I told you in advance: she would be the only woman I will marry and the only one who will share my bed. But you insisted on moving into the harem anyway.”

Imperial Consort: “But I did it for you, Your Highness! The court was pressuring you to get a wife and move women into the palace. As your best friend, I volunteered to help, to take care of the harem so my king never worries about it.”

King Benson: “And I appreciate all you did, with all my heart. That was a huge sacrifice you made for me. As a king, I can testify about your purity. I can issue a decree to move you out of the palace. I can arrange a good marriage for you to a respectable man, and you can live peacefully and properly recover your health!”

Imperial Consort: “So in all these years, the king never caught any feelings for me?! Does the king plan to discard me like that?! You want me to become an unwanted woman and be laughed at by people in the empire?!”

King Benson: “Of course not. You are my best friend; I care about you and your health.”

Imperial Consort: *(Trying to force herself onto the king)* “I do not want to be your best friend or friend, I want more! I cannot bow down to that village girl, and I cannot be the same rank as that Rika!”

Imperial Guard: *(Interrupting)* “Your Majesty! Tiju's father, the commander, is asking for permission to return to the capital!”

Imperial Consort: *(Smiling and whispering)* “You have no choice; by force, I can make you. If I cannot have you, nobody can! Maid, go tell my auntie that the plan has failed. Ask her to add

more pressure and not give the king any way out except through this palace! At the end of the day, he will understand that I am the only one he needs and the only person who can help him. Let's see, between love and power, who will he choose! Ahahah!"

Maid: "Yes, Your Majesty!"

King Benson: "What? Forgive me, I have to go."

Imperial Consort: "Benson! Benson! Do not do this, do not leave! Benson..."

Narrator: The king left the palace, but on his way he left one of his servants behind in the imperial consort's palace. The king then went back to his chamber, thinking of what to do next.

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "So now I am Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna?!" Guana: "Yes, Your Majesty! Tomorrow morning, all the king's women will come to your new palace to pay respect to you!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "But I do not even know where my palace is! Since I left the prison, the king has let me stay in his chamber."

Guana: "That is the greatest sign of love! The king never lets any woman enter his chambers or inner court. In this palace, you are the first, Your Highness!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "Really? Hmmm... I do not understand why the king loves me so much and why he insists on marrying me. It is the first time we met, but he is already in love with me." Guana: "I guess it is love at first sight, ahaha!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "I do not know. After all that happened to my village and me, I do not know if I have the heart to love anymore. All I ever wanted was to grow old together with the people I knew, get married, and have my own beautiful family. My parents always fought over petty reasons, even though they loved each other very much. I wanted something different. All this crown, these fancy things, palace things—I never thought of them. I was happy and satisfied where I was. I used to think that nothing would ever change, that the people I knew would always be the people I know, the place I went would always be the place I would be. Now everything has turned into sand."

Guana: "A heart such as yours is more qualified to be the mother of the empire, and your experiences will guide you in your governing. I believe you are more qualified and more noble than every woman in the palace. You deserve all the king's love. Why don't you give him a chance and hear him out? After all, Your Highness, he has nothing to do with what happened to your village!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Smiles)* "But he is not completely innocent either, you know. I cannot go easy on them." *(Fixing her hair)* "Even though I am a village girl, I still have some standards and honor. If I go easy on them, they will think I am easy to bully. I can't let that happen. But I am not foolish."

Guana: *(Smiles)* "So, are you thinking of giving the king a chance, Your Highness?"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Shy and hiding under her blanket*) “Well, he is handsome. Since I am the future queen, we have to get along. And I still have to take revenge on Rika. Only with the king’s help can I take her down and her family. I have no backer.”

King Benson: (*Listening behind the door and smiling*) Maids: “King Benson is here!”

King Benson: “Hello, Queen of my heart! How are you feeling today? Did I arrive at the right time?!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “It is your palace; you do not need permission to get in.” King Benson: “Now it is our home; I still need my wife’s permission. If your anger has gone down...”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Do not tell me the king of this empire is scared of a woman’s anger?”

King Benson: “No! I am scared of my wife’s anger, because you are the only affection I crave!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Blushes*) King Benson: “Everyone is dismissed! I want to be alone with my wife.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*The king carries Rosanna upon his shoulder to the garden, where they are completely alone*) “What? Nooooooooo... waittt!! I only have my night robe on, and I am not ready to go outside!!”

King Benson: “It is only us here, and you look perfect!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “You are such a flirt. Do you tell all the women you meet the same thing?” King Benson: “No, only my wife!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “We are not married yet.”

King Benson: “But in my soul, we are already married!” (*He kisses her cheek*)

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Shocked*) “What?! Hey, what are you doing?”

King Benson: (*Laughing and teasing her*) “Cute!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Notices the necklace around the king’s neck*) “Wait, what is that?” King Benson: “What is what?”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “The necklace... where did you get it?! Who gave it to you?!” King Benson: “I’ve had it since I was a kid. A girl from the temple gave it to me.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “OMG! OMG, do not tell me you are that brat from the temple?! Noooo way!”

King Benson: (*Smiling*) Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “OMG, IAN!!!!!!!!!!!!!!” King Benson: “Finally, you recognized me!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “So you are now king!?” King Benson: “I told you I will be king! And you will be my queen!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “What?! What?! So you were a prince?!” King Benson: “Yep!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “No wonder you were so arrogant and bratty!” King Benson: “Hey, go easy there on a man’s heart!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Whispering to herself*) “Rosanna *binti mfalme*, you could have lost your life, omg.”

King Benson: “What are you whispering, *binti mfalme*?!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Nothing, my King.”

King Benson: “I hate when you call me that; I feel so distant from you, like a stranger. Please call me Ian! Say my name one more time. I crave to see your lips say my name... I want to be close to you, to hold you, to possess you. I try to control myself, to give you time, to understand, but it is so hard on me. I cannot do it. I do not want to scare you away; I want you to let me be close to you on your own time, not manipulate you back to me. It's hard.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “But you are a king! I am just a village girl, with no power or influence. There is nothing I can give you or offer you. I am a slave. All the ministers and women in the palace are right.”

King Benson: “Have you tried to see yourself in my eyes? I admit, at the beginning I felt the same, I agreed with them. But as time passed by, I realized you are the only person who treated me with respect and honesty and saw me as a human being. You have everything I need and am looking for. I just want your love, your heart, your attention. I want to be all you need and want. In front of you, I am just a man in love—a man talking to his wife and soulmate. That is all I ever wanted to be: yours, and you mine.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “My attention is not pure. What if I want to use you to take revenge on those who hurt me?!”

King Benson: “As long as it is you, I do not mind. But you will have to pay me back every time you use me and my hands.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “What will you want in return?!”

King Benson: (*He kisses her*) “Do you understand what I want?! If you give me what I want, you can do whatever you want. After all, we want the same thing: be my wife, marry me, carry my children, and let me have all of you without limit, boundary, or restriction. All of you! All of mine!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*She kisses him back*) “Okay, deal!”

Narrative: The king carried the queen to their inner chamber; they became one. All night, the king did not close his eyes, and the light of the chamber stayed on with them. Only loud noises were heard outside, around the king’s court across the entire palace. I

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Waking up in the king’s arms*)

King Benson: (*Kissing Rosanna more*) Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “No more kisses.”

King Benson: (*Kissing her*) "I want more kisses! Give me more kisses, I want more!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "But my lips hurt now, they are all red." King Benson: (*Looks at her lips*) "Yes? Does it hurt?!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "My whole body hurts."

King Benson: (*Teasing her*) "If I kiss you a little more, it will stop. Give me more kisses!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Laughing*) "Heyyy... I won't be able to speak, ahahaa!"

King Benson: (*Keeps kissing her and turning her upside down*) "It's okay, that way I can enjoy your voice alone."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "My King!" King Benson: (*Continuing*) "Ian! I want more! Give me more of you!"

Narrator: It was morning. The entire palace knew that the king had consummated his marriage with Rosanna. The king gave his first night to a village girl. The king's women made themselves ready to go meet Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna at the king's palace.

Imperial Guard: "Your Majesty! All the women are waiting for Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna."

King Benson: "How dare you interrupt us?!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Out of breath*) "Tell them I will be coming in a few minutes!"

King Benson: "It will be impossible. You were awake all night, and you are going to pass out soon!" (*The king holds Rosanna and pulls her back into his bed, smiling*) "I still need more."

Narrator: The king and the queen spent all night and morning in their bed. The king had to leave their inner chamber for the morning court and to talk to the women of the harem.

King Benson: "Maids! Help me dress. Do not let anyone bother my wife. Let her rest for the day; I will talk to the women and the court." Maids: "Yes, Your Majesty!"

King Benson: (*Enters the throne court and sits on his throne, whispering to himself*) "I know those ministers will not let it go this easily. But now I am a married man and have my wife to protect. I will not repeat my father's mistake. I will live peacefully with my wife in this empire and clean up the court and the harem for our future children."

Eunuch: "The king is here! Show your respect!" Ministers: (*Bow down and show respect*) "Long life to the King!"

King's Eunuch: "Bring your reports to the King!"

Prime Minister: "The king has spent the night with the Imperial Noble Consort?"

King Benson: "Yes, my wife and I have consummated our marriage."

Minister of Treasury: “Has the king married her already?”

King Benson: “Yes, but I still have to officially present my wife and crown her.”

King’s Eunuch: “Make sure everything is ready—the clothes, the treasures, decorations according to imperial rank, color, and tradition. Everything must arrive before the ceremony.”

Minister of Treasury: “Such waste for a slave woman! Such an amount of gold is usually spent on a noble lady!”

Minister of Education: “She recently arrived in the palace—not even a year—and the king promoted her to imperial noble consort? And without an heir, the king is crowning her queen? Such things have never happened in the empire!”

Minister of the Department of Clothes: “The king maybe needs to slow down and think wisely. The king already has women from the imperial family who are more noble and have powerful backing. Such strength can help the king stabilize the empire.”

King Benson: “Right, like I am stupid enough to listen to your nonsense!”

Prime Minister: “Maybe my King is too young to understand and rule this empire. It is my job as a prime minister to advise you, and us ministers to guide you on the right path. If the king persists in pursuing this matter, do not blame our family for starting to take precautions.”

King Benson: “Is that a threat? You dare threaten your king in his court? Are you planning to rebel?”

Imperial Guards: *(Point their swords toward the prime minister)*

Eunuch: “Welcome the Grand Imperial Queen to the court hearing!”

Ministers: *(Bow down to show respect)* “Welcome the Grand Imperial Queen to the court hearing!” King Benson: “Welcome, Mother. Please take a seat!”

Grand Imperial Queen: *(Standing in the middle of the court in front of the king)* “Please, my ministers, forgive my son. He is still young and learning the matters of politics. He is still ignorant about some court matters. Do not take to heart what he said; as his mother, I truly apologize. It is true: the king has consummated his first night with Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna, but they are not legally married yet. To appease my family, who has been wronged in this matter, and my brother, who lost his daughter Tiju and is still defending our border in the war, I decided to promote my niece, the imperial consort, to Imperial Noble Consort Weka. Together with the Imperial Noble Consort, she will rule the harem and support the king.”

Ministers: “Long life to the Grand Imperial Queen! Long life to the Grand Imperial Queen!”

King Benson: “The court meeting is dismissed. Mother, we need to talk.”

Narrator: The court was dismissed. All the ministers were sent back to their homes and estates. The king went to the Grand Imperial Queen’s palace to talk to his mother. King Benson: “Mother, why would you do that?”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Do what, my King?”

King Benson: “Why would you promote the imperial consort to Imperial Noble Consort Weka?!”

Grand Imperial Queen: “My son, I did it for your own good. The imperial consort has been wronged in this matter. Our family cannot serve a slave woman. Try to give the imperial family some face.”

King Benson: “You know I never had feelings for any of the women you sent to the harem. You keep forcing those women on me even when you know that my heart belongs to someone else. How many times should I tell you? The only woman I want is Rosanna.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “You are too young. You do not understand the matters of politics, fame, and love. But when you get older, you will understand that all I am doing is for your own good!”
King Benson: “For my own good, or for the good of your family to maintain your family’s power and control? I will not be a puppet or be under your family’s control. My love life is my own business—do not interfere!”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Is this how you talk to your mother? You dare talk to me like this for a woman? A mere slave?!”

King Benson: “That woman is my wife, the mother of my children, and the future mother of my empire! You better prepare yourself and your family to accept this. If anything happens to my wife, I promise you, you and your family will pay for it!”

Grand Imperial Queen: “I raised you, and you dare threaten me for a slave?!”

King Benson: “We both know the truth of how you raised me. We both know you would have never chosen me if your son did not pass away! We know how your imperial family forced my mother to become a concubine so you could be where you are today! I will never let your family manipulate my love life or hurt my wife again!”

Grand Imperial Queen: *(Interrupting with a slap to the king)* “Benson! You are just the son of a concubine, and you dare disrespect my family? Listen: by now I thought that the past was buried in the past. You dare be ungrateful in front of me?!”

King Benson: “You dare rule over your king?! I am the king, the owner of the empire! Aside from God, my decision is final. I will not repeat myself again: if you dare harm me or my wife, do not blame me for being ruthless!” *(He walks out of the court.)*

Grand Imperial Queen: *(Falling back onto her couch)* “Did I just slap the king...?”

King’s Eunuch: “Your Majesty, what are we planning to do next?”

King Benson: “Let’s go back to check on Rosanna.” Narrator: All the king’s women were seated, waiting for Rosanna to come out.

Concubines: “Is the Imperial Noble Consort coming out?”

Consorts: “Probably not. She wanted to humiliate us here by making us wait.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “She is, after all, from the village. How can she know about manners?”

Imperial Consort: “I guess we all have to endure.”

Concubines: “Imperial Consort, you used to sit at the top, and we all used to come to your palace to pay our respects!” Consorts: “The imperial consort treated us with so much kindness. We are afraid that this village girl will put the harem in chaos!”

Noble Lady: “By the way, there is news that the king spent his first night with Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna. I thought that the king’s affection was toward the imperial consort, but who thought that a mere slave could steal the king’s heart so fast!”

Concubines: *(Giggle)* Consorts: “We all thought that the king was saving himself for the imperial consort!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Giggles)* “Well, now it is a matter of the past. My sister, Imperial Consort, I guess in our family we only have each other. We should take care of each other well.”

Concubines: “Imperial Consort Rika used to serve the imperial consort when she was a concubine. Your devotion touched the heavens, and now you are the same rank as the imperial consort.” Lady-in-Waiting: “Well, it is our fault for failing to capture the king’s heart.”

Concubines: “We are women of noble families; we cannot compare ourselves to a seductress. Only slaves learn such tricks.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Truly, God has eyes; He saw me well. My sister, let us work in harmony. I am sure God will reward each one of us for the hard work we do for this empire.”

Noble Lady: “It is true, God has. Now Tiju is dead. She was a vicious woman, abusing her imperial power to torment maids and the harem.”

Concubines: “Out of jealousy, she burned an entire village, thousands of people died, and she tortured the king’s favorite woman, almost causing Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna’s death.”

Noble Lady: “She was not the mastermind; she was just a pawn in someone else’s game.”

Concubines: *(Look at Imperial Consort Rika)* “Your family was banished to the border, but you got promoted! After all the things you did behind the king’s back, the king must love you so much.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “We all learned from our mistakes; the past is the past. My sister, let us turn over a new leaf.”

Imperial Consort: *(Giggles and whispers)* “Serves you right, Rika, thinking you can be on the same level as me.”

Maid: “Here comes Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna! Pay respect!” Harem’s Women: *(Stand up and bow down)* “Congratulations, Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna, for consummating with the king and for your promotion. Long life! Long life!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “You may all be seated, my sisters. I am sorry for being late. The king ordered my servants not to wake me up, so I stayed late in bed. After serving the king all night and morning, my body was hurting.”

Imperial Consort: (*Whispers to herself*) “Show-off.” Concubines: “Is Imperial Noble Consort planning to take charge now?” Imperial Consort: “Greetings, Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna. Now that you are the head of the harem, I must return the queen’s seal to you. All the palaces, departments, harem, and chambers are under your control and command.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “My sister, no need for formality. When I moved into the palace, Imperial Consort was the only person who was nice to me; I will definitely repay your kindness toward you.” (*She looks at Rika*) “Imperial Consort Rika, how do you think this palace should be handled? I am still new in the palace; I have so much to learn from all my sisters.” (*She holds the queen’s seal in her hand.*)

Grand Imperial Queen’s Eunuch: “Receive the Grand Imperial Queen’s decree!”

Narrator: All the women in the king’s palace bow down to hear the decree! Grand Imperial Queen’s Eunuch: (*Reading*) “The imperial consort has lived in the palace since she was a young girl; she has served the palace well and was loyal to the imperial family. By the power of the Grand Imperial Queen, I promote her to Imperial Noble Consort Weka, to assist Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna in ruling the palace!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “What?!!!!!!!” Concubines: “What?!”

Noble Ladies: “Imperial powers...”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “I accept the decree and send many thanks to Auntie for her support. Does that mean I can keep the queen’s seal?”

King Benson: “No. The seal will be kept by Rosanna, my wife! The queen of my empire.”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Upset*) “Benson!” King Benson: (*Walking toward Rosanna*) “I told the maids to keep you in bed. How did you have the strength to stand up and walk?”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “I did not walk, they carried me here! I cannot miss the first meeting with my sisters. You should have been gentle last night; you know it is my first time!”

King Benson: “It is our first time—the start of many of our shared nights. You know I am a greedy man. For helping you now, you will have to work hard tonight to pay me back!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Ian, you are teasing me again!” King Benson: (*Looking at the women in the palace*) “The seal will be kept by my wife, Rosanna. In a few days, we will have our marriage ceremony. Even though she is still in training, she has the same rights and powers as the king. Whoever harms my wife harms the king, and there will be no mercy!”

King’s Women: (*Bow down*) “We understand.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “The meeting is dismissed!” King Benson: “How are you planning to repay my kindness?”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Do you have something in mind?”

King Benson: "I will send my eunuch to pick you up after sundown. Be ready!" Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Trying to leave the meeting room)* "See you then!"

King Benson: "Are you going to leave like that?" Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Confused)* "Like what?!"

King Benson: "Like that. What if it's the last time you see me, or something happens?"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "What can happen? This is the king's palace! Are you scared of something?"

King Benson: *(Pulling Rosanna close)* "Yes, I worry that every time I see you might be the last. Kiss me." Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(She kisses the king and stops)*

King Benson: *(Cupping her face)* "Do not stop, I want more!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Trying to pull away)* "We know if you start, you will not stop." King Benson: "The more you pull, the more I want. The more you want, the more I want. The more you push me away, the more I want you. The more you want me, the more I want you."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Puts her hand on his chest)* "So there is no solution." King Benson: "Hmmm, there is no escape. Just let me love you and accept my love."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "Hmmm."

King Benson: "I am starving, but I have a few things to take care of. See you tonight." *(Walks out of the meeting room)*

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Blushing hard)* "Okay, let's go back to the palace!"

Maids: *(Giggling)* "Yes, Your Highness!"

King Benson: *(Talking to his eunuch)* "Who knew that making love to a woman would be so fulfilling?"

King's Eunuch: "Last night was the king's first night; how did it go?"

King Benson: "The best night and moment of my life! She was delicious! It was amazing. I have never felt this way, and I want more."

King's Eunuch: "Does this mean the king will start visiting other women in the palace?"

King Benson: "I do not know what spell she put on me. Every time I look at other women, I feel disgusted, and now I cannot stand another woman beside me if it is not her. Once we get married, I am planning to dismiss the entire harem. It will be just her and me—husband and wife."

King's Eunuch: "The palace will be too big for both of you!"

King Benson: "We will have maids and eunuchs, and the rest of the palace will be filled with our children. I never wanted a harem, but the Grand Imperial Queen and the ministers forced the harem on me. Now my wife is here, I just want her to live with me peacefully and safely." King's Eunuch: "I do not think your mother will allow it, especially her family, who have been in power for generations. Removing the harem and her nieces and spies will cause chaos. I do not think the king's family and ministers will let you go that easily, my King."

King Benson: "My imperial family has become bigger than the crown; such a thing is a danger to our empire. For the safety of my future family, we need to remove the root and cut their hope for the throne."

King's Eunuch: "What is my King's plan?"

King Benson: "It is going to be a surprise!"

Narrator: All the king's women returned to their palaces.

Imperial Noble Consort Weka went to the Palace of Rest to visit her auntie, the Grand Imperial Queen.

Eunuch: (*Announcing*) "Presenting Imperial Noble Consort Weka!"

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Excitedly*) "Weka?" Imperial Noble Consort Weka: "Auntie!"

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Holds Weka's hands*) "How did the meeting go? Did that slave make a fool of herself? Tell me! Tell me now!"

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Bowing down*) "First, Auntie, thank you for promoting me to imperial noble consort."

Grand Imperial Queen: "What are you doing? Stand up! You know I see you as my own daughter; I watched you grow up in this palace. From a young age, I wanted you to be with my son. In this palace, nobody is fit to be queen like you! Come on, stand up! Weka, stand up, my daughter!"

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Standing up and holding her auntie's hand*) "Thank you, Auntie, I am so grateful. Since my mother passed away, you have always been there for me; I see you as my own mother. I am so happy that after everything that happened in the palace, you still look out for me."

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Sitting down gracefully*) "Since your mother passed away—my older sister passed away—my life has never been the same. On her deathbed, she begged me to raise you. I had no choice but to bring you to the palace and raise you as my own."

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: "And I am so grateful. I love you and the palace, but now my cousin Benson does not want me in this palace anymore. He only has eyes for Rosanna, and he still plans to make her his queen!"

Grand Imperial Queen: “I do not understand. I used to think that you and your cousin had a good relationship and were in love. How did that suddenly change?”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “All of this is because of that seductress Rosanna! I used to be the only one in his eyes; he would leave everything for me and sacrifice it all for me. I was the apple of his eye, but everything changed since that slave came into the palace. Suddenly, all his attention went to her alone, as if I never existed. Now, all the palaces are laughing at me because they all know that the king has never touched me or favored me.” Grand Imperial Queen: “With me as your backer, who dares look down on you? Nobody will dare look down on our family. Everything is in my control: the ministers, the army, and the people in this palace. I promise you, the honors and the high seat will only belong to our family and you. In the end, a concubine’s son will always be a concubine’s son; he will never have the interests of our family at heart. If you can manage to get pregnant, I will do whatever it takes to give it all to you!” Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “Thank you so much, Auntie! I know I can always count on you!” Grand Imperial Queen: “Now that I have promoted you to Imperial Noble Consort Weka, the same rank as that slave, nobody will look down on you. Even if you share a rank, you are from a noble bloodline, and she is just a slave—she will never compare to you! Tell me, were you able to keep the seal?!”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “I was about to, but the king arrived and gave the queen's seal to Rosanna, and he threatened the entire harem! Now everyone is scared to make a move against Rosanna because she has the king as her backer.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “I am the Grand Imperial Queen! Let's see if nobody dares make a move against her! Even if it takes alcohol, the king has to spend the night with you, Weka!”

Narrator: It was sundown. The imperial noble consort returned to her palace. Meanwhile, the king’s eunuch went to fetch Rosanna for her to meet the king.

Maid: (*In the king’s palace*) “The king’s eunuch has arrived!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “You are finally here! How do I look? Is this proper to meet the king?”

King’s Eunuch: (*Holding up a garment*) “Do not worry, my lady. The king sent me with new clothes for you to wear before you go to meet him. Please, my lady, change into these clothes and jewelry!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Holding up the garment*) “Wow, it is beautiful! I have never seen such exquisite material and fabric. Give us a minute, I need to change.”

Narrator: Rosanna went and dressed. Her beauty made the moon hide high in the clouds, and flowers bloomed in embarrassment upon looking at her. Rosanna then entered the garden and met the king. Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Bowing*) “Hello, my King.”

King Benson: (*Holding her close*) “We are not strangers. What do you think of the garden?!”
Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “It is so beautiful! The candles, the petals, the decoration, the

bed, and flowers... and look, there is... wait, what? What is that doing here?" (*Laughing*)
"Ahaiah... is someone preaching to us tonight?"

King Benson: "Maybe, it depends on your answer! Hopefully, you say yes."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Confused*) "Do you have something to tell me?!"

King Benson: "I have a lot to tell you. I was born from a concubine. My mother was from a noble family, but her family was not too powerful and had no influence. She met my dad when he was visiting a small state. They were very young; my dad fell in love with her. He wanted to marry her; he did everything according to tradition. He did not reveal to my mom that he was a prince. Later on, before they got married, the truth was discovered. My dad was determined to marry my mom and make her crown princess. But the imperial family schemed against her; she was forced to enter the palace as a concubine. My dad did everything to protect her and make her life comfortable, but his mother did not like my mom because they considered her to be of low birth. So they gave her a hard time. After my dad's father passed away, my dad was crowned king. He wanted to make my mother his legal wife and crown her as she deserved. But they took advantage of my dad being absent in the palaces—his mother, the Grand Imperial Queen, and the imperial family schemed against her. They accused her of having an affair with the guards; they wanted her to be executed. I was only 10 years old when I watched it happen. Luckily, my dad came on time to save her, but the ministers did not let it go so easily. They forced my dad to banish my mom to the temple, never to return to the capital. After my mother left the palace, the Grand Imperial Queen, my grandma, promoted her niece to the position of queen. Sometime later, my grandma passed away. At the funeral, the imperial family schemed again: they wanted to bury me together with my dead grandmother. That was when Rika helped me to escape the palace. I ran to the slave village where we first met, right around your 8th birthday."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "And you were a brat! I had no idea that you were a prince."

King Benson: "Ahaha, you tried to save me from drowning, but you did not even know how to swim, so I had to dive deep to save you. From that exact moment, I knew you were the one I wanted to spend my life with!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: "Really?"

King Benson: "Yes. After your dad picked you up, I looked for you everywhere, but I couldn't find you—until we met at the temple."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Laughing*) "Hahaha, at the temple, when you told me that you would be the future king, I thought that you were delusional."

King Benson: "A man always keeps his word. My imperial family is too powerful, and they want more power. They want to do the same thing to me that they did to my dad, but they forget: I am not my dad. I am Ian, I am myself, and I will protect the people I love with all that I have. I am sorry I got you involved in this mess. Because of me, your village was harmed, and I consistently put you in danger."

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “I might be a village girl, but I am not that weak; I can fight. In my village, I am the only person who has blue hair and tan skin. My parents were always fighting; I was never allowed to go outside. When we met for the first time at the sea, it was my first time outside.”

King Benson: “Really?!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Yes. My parents were fighting so much that Prophet Kafura had to take me away to the temple, where we met again. They always talk about a prophecy, destiny, and evil seeds; I never understand it, and nobody ever tells me.”

King Benson: “Maybe it is about our destiny—being together, serving God, bringing peace to our empire. Maybe our souls already knew each other before we met. We are soulmates and fated to be together.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Who knows? Maybe. But I am happy when I have you around; I feel safe and loved.”

King Benson: “Then marry me! Marry me right now! Be my wife! Share all your nights with me, all my days by my side. Rule with me, be my partner: one soul, one spirit, and one flesh!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Ian... but I am just a village girl. There is nothing I can offer you!”

King Benson: “Stay alive and have a long life with me! Let us grow old and grey together. Be mine—that's all I want! Be my wife!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “You know, after this, there is no turning back. Once you marry me, there will never be divorce or separation. Even death will never separate us. Are you sure I am what you want? There is no going back!”

King Benson: “Yes! Marry me right now!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Crying)* “Yes! I will marry you! Now, right now!” King Benson: *(Crying)* “Really, right now? Right now!” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Crying)* “Right now! Yes! Yes....!”

Narrator: They hugged each other and cried deeply.

Prophet Kafura: *(Interrupting warmly)* “I guess I will officiate the marriage.” Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “

Prophet Kafura!” Prophet Kafura: “*Binti mfalme!*”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Runs and hugs the prophet)* “OMG, where have you been? I have been looking for you since the temple!”

Prophet Kafura: *(Hugs her back)* “*Habari yako? Umekuwa muda sijaona!* You've grown so much!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Well, I am not that 8-year-old girl anymore!”

King Benson: *(Smiling)* “Okay, enough hugging! I want my wife back!”

Prophet Kafura: *(Laughing)* “Okay! Okay, lover, let's start the wedding. Repeat after me: I, Rosanna *binti mfalme*, take as my lawful and traditional husband Ian, King Benson, to be one soul, one spirit, one flesh, even death will not take us apart!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Repeats loudly and proudly)* “I, Rosanna *binti mfalme*, take as my lawful and traditional husband Ian, King Benson, to be one soul, one spirit, one flesh, even death will not take us apart!”

Prophet Kafura: “King Benson, repeat after me: I, Ian, King Benson, take Rosanna *binti mfalme* as my lawful and traditional wife, to be one soul, one spirit, one flesh, even death will not take us apart!” King Benson: *(Repeats loudly and proudly)* “I, Ian, King Benson, take Rosanna *binti mfalme* as my lawful and traditional wife, to be one soul, one spirit, one flesh, even death will not take us apart!”

Prophet Kafura: “In all of heaven, all of earth, and in all dimensions, I, Prophet Kafura, chosen by the almighty, powerful God of Israel, declare you husband and wife and seal this covenant as heaven witnesses. Amen. You may kiss your wife.” *(As he speaks, he disappears into the air.)*
Narrator: Under the moon, all alone, the king and queen sign the lawful papers and covenant. They spent all night in the garden becoming one on their wedding day. The next day, they both woke up in the garden, embracing each other.

King Benson: “Good morning, Queen of my heart!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Good morning, my husband!” King Benson: “Maybe you should say, ‘Good morning, my only husband!’” I

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Ahaha, good morning, my only husband!” King Benson: *(Kisses his wife)* “Good morning, my only world. How was your night?”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “It was beautiful! And yours, my only handsome husband?” King Benson: “It was magical—a miracle from God. I want you to accompany me to the court today.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Me? Are you sure it is my place to be there?” King Benson: “It is my wife's place to be wherever I am. We will accompany each other for the rest of our lives; let's start from here.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: “Okay, should we go make ourselves ready?!”

King Benson: *(Turns the queen toward him and kisses her)* “Hmmmm, after you love me more. I want you now. Give me more.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “We will be late, ahaha.” King Benson: “They just have to wait for us then! More!”

Narrator: After the bride and groom shared their intimacy in the morning, the king and queen returned to their palace to make themselves ready for the court meeting. They put on their royal robes filled with gold and royal colors and designs, and they placed their crowns on. Finally, they held hands as all the people in the palaces bowed down, and the ceremony began.

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Looks at her husband*) “Wow, this robe is so beautiful! This jewelry is incredible. Are you sure it is for me?” King Benson: “Everything you see is yours. If you want it, you take it.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Looks at the material with amazement*) “Are you sure?”

King Benson: (*Smiles mischievously*) “Yes, but you have to pay me back later on.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Giggles*) “You kept me up all night! Are you not satisfied?”

King Benson: (*Holds his wife and whispers in her ear*) “Never. The more you give me, the more I want. I am waiting for you to heal properly so we can enjoy each other more and I won’t have to hold back!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Blushing*) “It does not look like you have been holding back with me. I’m going to make myself ready.”

King Benson: (*Smiles and whispers*) “It’s okay, you can run for now, but you cannot escape. We still have all night. Eunuch! Help me dress, I’ve got some ministers to surprise!”

Maids: “The palace is being prepared for an important ceremony. I’ve seen people working since yesterday, all through the night, to decorate the palace. Someone is getting promoted today. With the amount spent on the decorations, it must be a very high rank. Also, all the ministers are wearing their imperial attire, so it must be huge. We wonder, who is going to do it?!”

Concubines: “Today there is an important ceremony. The king sent his eunuch to inform us and tell us to dress up. I wonder who is getting promoted.”

Noble Lady: “We do not know either; nobody informed us about the ceremony. We are as surprised as everyone else. Who is getting promoted today?!”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “Who else could be more worthy than me?! I am from an imperial family with pure blood. My auntie is the Grand Imperial Queen, my father is the king’s prime minister, my father’s brother is the king’s advisor, and my brother is the commander of the army. I am the most favored daughter in our imperial family. Since I was born, my father told me I will be queen of our empire, and my auntie took me to the palace to train me to be the future queen. I believe today is the day I become the queen.”

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Giggles*) “My dear sister, nobody knows for sure. Your main branch is way too powerful; it is overshadowing the crown. I believe in this life, my dear sister, you will never be queen. But do not worry, once my brother Benson crowns me queen, I will remember—I will not treat you unfairly!” Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Slaps Rika*) “How dare you, a daughter born from a concubine, dare challenge the main branch of my family?!”

Remember, your entering this palace was my wish. As I brought you here, I can end you at any time. Remember: you burned the slave village, tortured the king's beloved woman, and your family was banished to the border to be slaves!" (*Whispering to her*) "The only thing that is keeping you alive is the fact that you are from the imperial family, and I just have to lift my finger for you to be cut off. Never forget your place, you lowly servant." (*She pushes Rika to the ground.*) Imperial Consort Rika: "And do not forget that all the dirty work I did was ordered by you! I was just following my dear sister's commands. Just think: when King Benson discovers that most of his problems were caused by his childhood bestie and sweetheart... ahahaha, imagine the look on his face and what will happen to you! I fear that you and your proud imperial family will not escape his anger, ahhaaa!" Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Panics and composes herself*) "Ahahah, all of these are just empty words; your threat means nothing at all. There is no proof or link to me; my hands are completely clean. But *you* are a different subject, ahahahaha."

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Giggles*) "If that is what you choose to believe, ahahah. Listen to me, Weka: if I fall, we both fall."

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: "I think you forgot your place. I guess you do not worry about what happens to your mother and sister... Oh wait! And your little brother too! The moment you decided to challenge me was the moment you signed the death warrants of your family members, ahahahaha!"

Imperial Consort Rika: "What did you do? Tell me, what did you do to my mother? You witch!" (*Bowing her head to the ground*) "What did you... please, I beg you, Imperial Noble Consort Weka, do not do anything to my family! I will do everything you say, but I beg you not to harm my family! Please, I beg you....!"

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Smiling*) "Ahah, you know I hate disloyal people, and I knew this day was coming. I smelled your greed from afar, so I sent a letter to my main branch. I told them you were a threat and needed to be eliminated. A pawn that cannot be used is useless, ahahahaha!"

Eunuch: (*Interrupting and announcing*) "Presenting King Benson and Queen Rosanna!"

Narrator: The king and the queen enter the court holding each other's hands, walking with their heads high with pride.

Imperial Noble Consort Rosanna: (*Shocked, looks at her husband*) "Queen Rosanna?"

King Benson: (*Smiles*) "You are now my wife, my partner, my companion. This path to the highest place, we walk together—just us and our future children. I will clean this palace for you so we can live peacefully with our children."

Queen Rosanna: (*Smiles with happy tears*) "Yes, my King and my only husband!"

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: "What...? Queen..? Queen Rosanna?! How is it possible?!"

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Bows down to show respect*) "Why? What?! That slave... queen?!"

Noble Ladies: *(Bowing down in shock)* "...What...? Why?"

Concubines: *(Bowing down)* "We saw this coming!" Lady-in-Waiting: "A... a... a slave?!"

Ministers: *(Bowing down)* "What?! ...What...? Queen...? They got married?! When? How? Where?..."

King Benson: *(Standing in front of everybody in the court, holding Rosanna's hand)* "Here is my only sun, my holy moon, my soulmate, my wife, and my queen. I traveled the world and saw different kinds of women, but none compared to her, and none has touched my heart like she does. She is one in a million; traditionally, she is my wife and queen of all that is mine, including my life and empire. None is more qualified and worthy than her. Here I present to you your Queen! Queen Rosanna!"

Eunuch: "Bow down to the King and Queen!"

Everyone in the Court: *(Bowing down)* "Congratulations, Your Majesties, on your marriage! We bow down and show our respect and loyalty. Long life! Long life to the King and Queen!"

Narrator: The ceremony was very long, filled with singing, dancing, serving tea, gifts, and many rituals and protocols to follow. By the end of the day, the king and queen were utterly exhausted and drained.

Queen Rosanna: "Come on, help me take off my robe! It is so hot, and I am so hungry!"

King Benson: "Do not move, let me try to figure out how to take it off!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Taking off her robe, jewelry, and decorations, and lying down on her bed)* "The ceremony was so long! I am so tired! I did not know that you prepared such a huge festival."

King Benson: *(Taking off his robe, jewelry, and decorations, and lying down next to his wife)* "It was my wedding gift to you. Did you like it?"

Queen Rosanna: "Yes! I did not expect that I would be crowned today. I was scared that I would mess up and make a fool of myself."

King Benson: "I had everything prepared in advance, so even if you made a mistake, nobody would notice, ahahah. I know that a lot of people will not sleep tonight. I am planning to dismiss the harem; I do not want to put you in danger anymore. I am tired of all these scheming and vicious women; I just want to live peacefully and safely with you."

Queen Rosanna: "Yes, that will be nice. As husband and wife... but the Grand Imperial Queen will not allow it, especially the greedy ministers."

King Benson: "That is true, but I have my own plan, and I am the king, not them. I just wish my mom was here to watch our wedding and ceremony."

Queen Rosanna: "Why don't you bring her back to the palace?! She is your mom, after all. I believe she has suffered enough in the temple."

King Benson: “The Grand Imperial Queen is vicious. I worry that if my mother returns, she will be in even greater danger.”

Queen Rosanna: “You can return her crown and grant her the same power as the Grand Imperial Queen. You can pick the Palace of Splendor for her, where she can live there peacefully with us!” King Benson: “The imperial family is too powerful, and my mother has no political backing. Going toe-to-toe with the Grand Imperial Queen would be dangerous for her. My mom was my father's concubine, so her title will never be as high as the last queen of the empire.”

Queen Rosanna: “My dear husband, who is more powerful than the king? Is a political backer truly more powerful than the king himself? She is the birth mother of the king! What title is higher than that? Or is there something you are not telling me?”

King Benson: “I used to have a sister. She was beautiful, kind, talented, and intelligent. She was the firstborn daughter of my father, and she was his greatest favorite. But after my dad married the Grand Imperial Queen and gave her the title of queen, my family became her target. Even though she was queen, she did not have my dad's heart or favor, so she hated us. One day, when the prince of our neighboring empire visited, he saw the queen's daughter and fell in love with her, proposing a peace marriage. The Grand Queen did not want to lose her own daughter. The imperial family put pressure on my dad to let my sister go instead of the legal princess of the empire. My dad refused at first because he loved my sister and couldn't endure the separation. My mom, trusting my dad's words, stayed quiet and did nothing. My sister refused the marriage because she knew the three of us only had each other to depend on. But the Grand Imperial Queen kidnapped me and my mother, forcing my sister to sign the marriage papers by threatening to kill both of us in front of her. Out of fear for our lives, my sister signed the papers. During the preparations for the wedding, my sister hanged herself and left a letter.” Queen Rosanna: “What? Oh my goodness... What happened next?”

King Benson: *(Sitting up)* “Well, before my sister took her own life, she went through deep depression, terrible depression. She was the only person I truly loved in this cage of a palace. I went alone to stand before my father and beg him to cancel the wedding, but he wouldn't even receive me in the court; I was left outside kneeling all day and every day.”

Queen Rosanna: “What did your mom do?!” King Benson: “She tried to beg my dad too, but he wouldn't even come to visit us. As revenge, I schemed behind the scenes, and the legal princess of the empire—the Grand Imperial Queen's daughter—got sent to the neighboring empire instead. She remains there to this day!” Queen Rosanna: “So you hold a grudge against her?!”

King Benson: “Yes, I do. But I still love her and want to protect her.”

Queen Rosanna: “I think it is time to forgive each other and let the past go. And what about the letter?”

King Benson: “My sister tried to use her life to push the Grand Queen, but the imperial family covered it up, and I have not read the letter since then. As a king, I know and understand my dad; as a husband, I believe he is a fool; as a ruler, I get his perspective about the empire; but as a father, he has failed completely. My sister was like a mother to me, more than a mother. Anyway, I know what you mean. I should do as my queen said!”

Queen Rosanna: “Thank you! I love you!”

King Benson: “I love you more. Come on, let's rest, it is late.” Imperial Noble Consort Weka: *(In her palace, throwing and breaking everything her hands can touch)* “Benson!!!! Are you serious?! How dare you make a fool of me... How could you do this to me? I will kill her...! I want her dead...! Dead!!!! Now! Oh God!! Queen...! QUEEN! Why! ... Why her?! A mere slave?! A woman lower than a maid?! He dared!! He dared make me bow down to a slave?! Ah! No! No...! This cannot be happening, am I dreaming?! I am the queen! I am the queen! I am Queen Weka! Yes, yes, it is me!! It's me! Everyone bowed down to me!! Meee!!! Pay your respect to me!!! Ahhahah, me!” *(Slapping, whipping, and beating up her maid)*

Imperial Consort Rika: *(In her palace, dismissing all her maids and starting to cry)* “Benson, why... do you really like that slave? Why her? She has never done anything for you, and she cannot offer anything, why? What does she have that I do not have? What is so great about her, why? How can I now save my family from the border? She must die! No matter what, this slave queen must die; I will never accept it.” Nobles, Ladies, and Concubines: “Such a show. Today, nobody will sleep.”

Lady-in-Waiting: “A big change is coming.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Nice, nice, the king chose a queen. Who is it? Was it Weka?” Imperial Guard: *(Quiet)* Grand Imperial Queen: “Come on, tell me! Who is it? Was it Rika?”

Imperial Guard: “No, Your Majesty!”

Grand Imperial Queen: *(Smiling)* “Oh, my God! So it is Weka?! I knew it! The king still has me in his heart; he can still show respect to our imperial family!”

Imperial Guard: “No, Your Majesty. It is not Weka or Rika!” Grand Imperial Queen: “Who is more qualified than the members of our imperial family? My branch is the most powerful, influential, and qualified than any other branch! The king needs the power of the imperial family to stabilize the empire and his throne. Who is it?!”

Imperial Guard: “The king crowned Rosanna as his legal wife and queen of all that is his, including the empire!” Grand Imperial Queen: “No, that is impossible! It cannot happen! The queen of this empire cannot be a slave! No way! You heard wrong. Maid, go check the news back! Take the guards and execute them now!”

Imperial Guards: *(Screaming as they are dragged away)* “Please, Grand Imperial Queen, show mercy! We are not lying, it is true, the king did.....!” Prophet Kafura: *(Interrupting)* “*Kwa nini kumwaga damu isiyo na hatia?* It is time for God to repay you for all the evil you have done!”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Prophet Kafura, it is you again. I guess age did not kill you! *Yote haya ni makosa yako!*” Prophet Kafura: “How many times did I tell you? Fighting against God is useless, and this kingdom should never have belonged to you.” Grand

Imperial Queen: “*Sitaacha kupigana!* I am God! I decide who dies and who lives.” Prophet Kafura: “But you are dying too. I see age has eaten your flesh as well; you are not as young as you used to be.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Age is just a number! I am the Grand Imperial Queen, the most powerful person alive.”

Prophet Kafura: “*Usiwe mjinga*, let it go now while it is not too late, and repent. Maybe God will forgive you!”

Grand Imperial Queen: “I did nothing wrong, so I have nothing to repent of and nothing to confess! Guards, kill that man!” Prophet Kafura: (*Suddenly disappears, his voice echoing*) “Are you not scared that innocent blood will claim you? *Yesu Kristo Bwana wetu akusamehe*, and save His people.” Grand Imperial Queen: (*Faints from shock*)

Narrator: The next day, the king attended his court, and the queen met with the imperial women. Queen Rosanna: “Good morning, my sisters.” Harem’s Women: (*Bowing down*) “Congratulations on becoming queen of the empire.”

Queen Rosanna: “I sent people to the temple to pick up the king’s birth mother. She will be returning to the palace to live with us.” Concubines: “She was sent to the temple by the late king for having an affair. Why is she returning to the palace?”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Arrogantly interrupting and sitting down*) “Forgive me for being late. It took me time to dress myself; I had to go visit my auntie—she fainted last night.”

Noble Lady: “Well, you cannot sit until you show your respect to the new queen!” Imperial Consort Rika: (*Giggles*)

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Looks at the queen*) “We are all sisters. I know my sister does not mind, right?!” Lady-in-Waiting: “All of this are formalities and the harem protocols that were established by our ancestors. They must be followed carefully.”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Smirks and rolls her eyes*) Imperial Consort Rika: “Queen Rosanna, accept my bowing on behalf of the imperial noble consort. She must be tired from taking care of the Grand Imperial Queen.”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “Yes, Rika can bow for me!” Queen Rosanna: “Please, Rika, stand up. I accept your sincerity. Weka should be the one showing her respect!” Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “I will never bow down to a slave! I am from a noble bloodline, the niece of the Grand Imperial Queen, and my father is the prime minister. How dare you, a slave, try to make me bow down?” Queen Rosanna: “And I am the queen of this empire and palaces, crowned by the king of this empire. If I said bow, you bow. If I said roll, you roll. And if I said die, you die!” Imperial Noble Consort Weka: “Let me see who dares touch me! Who dares?! This palace is in my control.”

Queen Rosanna: “Guards, take the imperial noble consort and force her to her knees!” Grand Imperial Queen: (*Interrupting and entering the palace*) “Let me see who dares touch her!”

Imperial Noble Consort Weka: (*Starts crying*) “Auntie, you're finally here! You're finally here! See how they are bullying me!”

Harem's Women: (*Bowing down*) “Welcome the Grand Imperial Queen! We show our respect!”
Queen Rosanna: (*Stands up and bows down*) “Welcome, Mother-in-law!”

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Sitting down*) “Mother-in-law? How dare you! I was sick all night and all morning. As a daughter-in-law, it is your job to come visit me and care for me! Instead, you spent time here bullying the king's women and showing off your power. You just got crowned, and you cannot wait to show off your authority!”

Queen Rosanna: “No, Mother-in-law, I was just following the protocols of the palace.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “How dare you interrupt?! Maid, slap her hard!”

Mystery Person: “Let me see who dares.”

Grand Imperial Queen: (*In shock*) “You.....!”

Queen Rosanna: “My greetings to you, Mother!”

Harem's Women: “Who is this?!” Eunuch: (*Announcing*) “King Benson is here!”

King Benson: “Mother, you have finally arrived!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Bowing down*) “This is the birth mother of the king.”

King's Mother: “I failed to protect my daughter once, but it will not happen twice. We have an old debt to collect!”

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Angrily*) “Why did you let this adulteress back in the palace?! Guards, take this adulteress and execute her right now!”

King's Mother: “Why such a hurry? Are you not happy to see your old rival alive?”

Queen Rosanna: (*Standing up*) “Who dares touch my mother?!” Grand Imperial Queen: “You dare go against me?!”

Queen Rosanna: “You dare act recklessly in front of the king?! Your head is not above the sky!”
King Benson: (*Looks at the eunuch*) “Read the imperial decree!”

King's Eunuch: “Bow down to the imperial decree!” Narrator: Everyone bows down—except the king, the queen, and the Grand Imperial Queen.

King's Eunuch: “Here is the command: After an investigation, the king's birth mother was found to be wrongfully accused and sentenced to the temple for 12 years. As the king, here I decree her return to the palace and the full restoration of her crown. Her title shall be Imperial Grand Consort, and she will live in the Palace of Splendor. Furthermore, for scheming against the king's mother, the Grand Imperial Queen's title will be revoked, and she will not be allowed to leave

her palace until further decree. All her maids and eunuchs will be replaced by the king's people to make sure she prays during her isolation."

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Standing in pride*) "I am the Grand Imperial Queen, the head of the entire palace, the wife of the late king! What can you do to me? I put you on that seat; I can remove you!"

King Benson: "Imperial Noble Consort Weka, for disrespecting authority, your title is revoked as well. Stay in your palace. Guards, take both of them away! Make sure no spies get out of their palace to inform the imperial family."

Grand Imperial Queen: (*Being dragged away by the imperial guards*) "You will not do this to me! I will make you pay! Just wait and see!"

Imperial Grand Consort Versta: "Guards! Take away the Grand Imperial Queen and Imperial Noble Consort Weka... wait, I mean, ahaaha, take away Weka and—" (*Looks at her face*) "—Yuri. Lock them in the palace, never to be seen again!"

King Benson: "Also, I, King Benson—King Ian—am dismissing the harem. All of you will leave the palace and return to your homes. Each one of you will be rewarded amazingly, and I will testify to your purity: I never visited or touched any woman except my beloved wife. Go back to your palaces, pack your things and valuables. The eunuchs will be waiting for you outside to return you."

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Immediately faints*) Weka: (*Faints*) Narrator: All the women returned to their palaces. Yuri and Weka were locked in their respective palaces. Weeks later, the palace was finally at peace. Weka: (*From inside her locked palace*) "Guard, I beg you... Take this bracelet and give it to King Benson. When my crown gets restored, I will reward you greatly." Imperial Guards: (*In greed*) "Okay!" Narrator: Meanwhile, the king, the queen, and the Imperial Grand Consort were in the garden, drinking tea and enjoying dessert. Imperial Guard: (*Bowing down*) "My greetings, Your Majesties!" Imperial Grand Consort: "You may rise. What is the matter?" Imperial Guard: "I was sent to present this bracelet to the king!" King Benson: (*Holds the bracelet and looks at it carefully*) "Hmmm, let me see... Weka?!" Queen Rosanna: "You still remember that woman?!" King Benson: "I was the one who gave her this bracelet. I remember when my mother got sent to the temple, and I escaped the palace to go to the temple to visit her—where I met you again, my beautiful wife. After I left the temple, I was a powerless prince: Prince Ian. Weka used her influence to take care of me and support me. I gave her this bracelet as a promise that no matter what she does in the future, I will forgive her and never let her face injustice. That's how we became childhood friends." Queen Rosanna: "What are you planning to do with my only husband?!"

King Benson: (*Standing up to go see Weka in her confinement*) "Visit an old friend." Imperial Grand Consort: "My son, are you not going to stop him?!" Queen Rosanna: "I want to see if he has feelings for that woman, if he will choose her or me."

Imperial Grand Consort: "Are you testing him?!"

Queen Rosanna: "I just want to know where my true heart stands."

Imperial Grand Consort: "I understand, but since he met you as a child, the only thing he has talked about to me is you!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Smiling)* "Really?"

Imperial Grand Consort: *(With a smile full of love)* "Really. I believe you are the reason he is still sane in this crazy palace."

Weka: "He owes me a lot. I know he will not forget our childhood and all the sacrifices I made for him." Imperial Guard: *(Announcing)* "King Benson is here!"

Weka: *(Makes herself look messy)* "Greetings, King Benson. It is good to see you, Brother." King Benson: "Hmmm, likewise."

Weka: "Do you remember the promise you made me when we were growing up?"

King Benson: "Do you remember that promise when you schemed with the ex-Imperial Grand Queen and her daughter to send my sister to the neighboring empire?! Do you remember when you ordered my personal eunuch to be thrown alive and eaten by dogs? Do you remember how many maids and eunuchs you killed in this palace? How many concubines and consorts? ...How about the slave village that you ordered to be burned to the ground?! Or how about my wife, whom you almost killed in the prison?!"

Weka: "But she is just a slave!"

King Benson: "She is the woman I love!"

Weka: "So you knew everything from the beginning, ahahah!"

King Benson: "I tolerated it because I thought you were still kind. You were the only person who helped me when I was a powerless prince. I remembered our past, and I covered it up for you because you were my childhood friend."

Weka: "Since when? Where?! Hahahah, since when did you know?!"

King Benson: "From the moment I found out about the news of the slave village. Nobody knew about Rosanna. The only person I told about Rosanna and the mission to pick her up and crown her was you. You knew the day, the village, and her name. Only you could do such evil. I trusted you! Why?"

Weka: "Because I love you! You only have eyes for that slave! How dare she take away your love from me?! I did so much for you. Is this how you repay me?!"

King Benson: "You being alive is already a mercy. Stay here, stay quiet, and grow old." Weka: "Ahahah, I refuse! I want to be queen. Love me, please!"

King Benson: "That place is only for my wife. My beautiful Rosanna."

Weka: “Ahahah, that's why I should have killed your sister and you both at the same time. You are both useless!”

King Benson: “Wait, you killed my sister?!” Weka: “Ahahah, yes! Because she wanted to escape on her wedding day. My auntie wanted to send me to the neighboring empire to get married in her place; she loves her own daughter more than me. So, I just wanted to talk to your sister, but she got angry and tried to escape, so I accidentally killed her. I did not mean to, but I did. I did feel bad, but you returning to me crying and begging was more satisfying. I was happy either way—I got to stay, have you, and have my auntie's love, and I would be the future queen. Until you met that slave girl Rosanna, who ruined my plan. Ahahah, my work for years and years... They all deserved to die, ahahah, all of them, ahahah!”

King Benson: “You are so vicious and unrepentant. I thought spending time here would fix you, but I was wrong.”

Weka: “You are vicious too, using me to clean up your harem?!”

King Benson: “I never wanted a harem; all I wanted was Rosanna. But you and your auntie insisted on building one! For all your crimes, you will be executed tonight. It was good to see you again, Weka. In the next life, let's never meet, or I will kill you immediately.” *(Walks away)*
Weka: *(Crying)* “...I am Queen! I am Queen!”

King Benson: *(Calling out to his attendants as he walks away)* “Eunuch! Fetch a glass of poison and send it to Weka. In honor of our old friendship, ensure her death is quick.”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Who had been listening from afar, enters the cold palace after King Benson departs)* “Well, this isn't as interesting as I thought it would be.” Weka: *(Glaring at Rika)* “Are you here to laugh at me, Rika?”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Coldly correcting her)* “To you, it is Imperial Consort Rika!”

Weka: *(Spitting out her words)* “A dog biting its own master?”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Smirking calmly)* “Dogs are wild animals, Weka. If they aren't trained properly, they can crush human bones. That is a simple fact.”

Weka: “Then I should have chained you instead of Tiju!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Does it matter now? You are already a dead body walking. My only fear was that if it weren't you here, I would have shared the same fate as Tiju: dead.”

Weka: “I was always good to you! Why would you scheme against me after all the things I did for you?”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Being my ‘benefactor’ meant forcing me to be your loyal servant, getting my hands dirty for you while allowing me to sit peacefully in the harem acting like a saint. Ahaha, ridiculous.”

Weka: “I thought we were friends! We are from the same family! I helped your father become the king’s advisor and helped your brother, even though I knew you were born from a lowly concubine!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Did you care about our family connection when Tiju was killed? Or when I was banished to the cold palace?! If I had not taken matters into my own hands, I would be just as dead as Tiju.”

Weka: “I was planning to release you from the cold palace!” Imperial Consort Rika: *(Laughs bitterly)* “Ahahah, when? You were probably planning to pin all the blame on me for your own actions, just like Tiju!” Weka: “Once the Imperial Grand Queen finishes her confinement, I will be out of here. Even the king’s death decree will be useless. My branch of the family holds immense power and influence. In the end, I am the only one he truly needs.” Imperial Consort Rika: “Ahaha... I love seeing that arrogant look on your face. Well, let me enlighten you: your auntie, the Imperial Grand Queen, has been completely abolished and demoted to a commoner. The king has locked her away in solitary confinement and purged every single one of her spies. No one can report back to your precious imperial family line now. To top it all off, the king’s birth mother has been promoted to Imperial Grand Consort and is now in full charge of the harem. Every single one of the king’s women will be cast out of the palace; the king only wants his village girl. Also, your imperial family already found out what happened because I told them. They tried to pressure the king to liberate you and the Grand Queen, but the king exposed all your evil deeds to the citizens of our Empire of Boparl. Now, the people want you punished and dead, especially the family members of those you killed. So much for our beautiful imperial family, ahahah.”

Weka: “That is crazy! He cannot do that! The imperial family will never allow it; my imperial family will never accept my death! I am the legitimate daughter of the main branch! I am more valuable than anyone in the family.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Well, not anymore. I fear it is time for you to die peacefully and join Tiju. I cannot let our family name be stained by you. Ahahah.” Weka: *(Stands up, furious)* “You—nobody! A child of a concubine dares touch a daughter of the main branch?! I dare you!” Imperial Consort Rika: *(Coldly)* “Maids! Hold her.”

Maids: “Yes, Your Highness!” *(The maids rush forward, holding her down to choke her to death, then hang her up from the rafters of the cold palace.)*

Weka: *(With her every last breath)* “Rika... you will pay for this! You will not die a good death! Stop it! Help me! Help!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Looking at the hanging body, speaking to her servant)* “Go send out the news. State that Imperial Noble Consort Weka, consumed by overwhelming guilt and shame, decided to hang herself as a repentance for all the evil she has done and as an apology to the dead. Ahahahaha.” *(She turns on her heels and walks out of the cold palace.)* Narrator: The king returned to the garden and sat down together with his wife and mother.

Queen Rosanna: “Why do you look sad?”

King Benson: "It is nothing. Let us enjoy the sun and the weather; it looks beautiful today."

Queen Rosanna: "So, you do not want to tell me what happened?"

King Benson: "I just do not want to talk about it."

Queen Rosanna: "Are you going to let Weka out like you did for Rika?" King Benson: "No, it is not like that..."

Imperial Guard: (*Interrupting*) "Your Majesty, Weka is dead!" Queen Rosanna: (*In shock*) "What?! Husband, you killed her?!"

King Benson: "No... yes. But it was supposed to be tonight with poison. How did she die so fast?!" Imperial Guard: "Your Majesty, we found her hanging in her room at the Cold Palace. It was suicide."

King Benson: (*A bitter smile*) "With how prideful she always was, it is not shocking. Hmmm... I am tired." Imperial Grand Consort: "Do you want to go inside to rest?" King Benson: (*Stands up*) "Yes!"

Queen Rosanna: (*Trying to stop her husband*) "Huh, wait!" Imperial Grand Consort: (*Interrupts Rosanna by holding her hand and shaking her head*) "Do not." King Benson: (*Looking back*) "Did you say something?"

Queen Rosanna: "No, my husband, go rest. I will stay here in the garden with your mother." King Benson: (*Walking toward his palace*) "Do as my queen pleases!"

Queen Rosanna: "Mother, why did you stop me? Now he is going to our room to think about Weka!"

Imperial Grand Consort: "Calm down, my daughter. Do you think fighting will solve anything?"

Queen Rosanna: "But, Mother!" Imperial Grand Consort: (*Interrupting*) "Listen. The king knew Weka since they were babies. They played together and did everything together. Even though he was my concubine's child, Weka never looked down on him; Weka helped and assisted him. Everyone thought that it would be her he would marry—most people called them childhood sweethearts. So it must be hard for him to lose his only childhood friend."

Queen Rosanna: (*Making a sad baby face*) "I understand. I feel like everyone is related to the king and has done great things for him, but as for me, I did nothing for him. I feel unworthy. Now I have to compete with a dead person."

Imperial Grand Consort: "Well, because you feel unworthy... As a mother, I also wanted my son to marry someone powerful who could help him establish his empire. For someone from nowhere, that will be hard. But all powerful people want more power, and all powerful people want control. I ended up realizing that what my son needs is someone who sincerely loves him, cares about him, protects him, supports him, redirects him, guides him, and walks step by step with him. Someone he loves and someone who loves him. That type of love the imperial family

will never give him. That is where you came in. Everything he needs is in you. You are perfect for my son. I chose you for my son—not only for the empire, but for my only son. Your background might disqualify you or make you feel unworthy, but you are the only perfect fit for my son. Because he is the son of a concubine, he was always looked down upon; I do not want the same for you. So close your ears, and just focus on him and the empire God blessed you with, okay?”

Queen Rosanna: “Okay. I am perfect for your son?!”

Imperial Grand Consort: (*Giggles*) “Yes, you are for my son. You are perfect for my son.” Queen Rosanna: (*Crying*) “So, can I be part of your family? Can we be a family?”

Imperial Grand Consort: (*Giggles with tears in her eyes*) “You silly girl. I told you, you are perfect for my son. I have been waiting so long to see you again. When we met at the temple, I saw you working from afar; I admired you a lot, and I always wished to see you again and have you close. I admired the woman my son loves so much. It is my greatest happiness to finally call you my own daughter. Stop crying, silly.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Giggling and crying*) “If my daughter were alive, she would probably look like you.” Imperial Grand Consort: (*Holding and hugging Rosanna*) “I heard about the horrific things that happened to the slave village. I sent trusted people to investigate for us. Once the investigation and restoration of the slave village is finished, we can go and visit.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shocked, crying, and hugging the Imperial Grand Consort*) “Really? You did that for me?” Imperial Grand Consort: “Yes. Now you are the queen; you can do that yourself, but I wanted to surprise you and collect all that is owed to you—return it piece by piece. To me, you are my daughter; as a mother, it is my job to protect you, silly.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Crying*) “Mother!” Imperial Grand Consort: (*Smiles*) “It is okay, you can cry here.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Puts her head on the Imperial Grand Consort’s lap*) “I have a deep sadness in my heart. Every day it grows deeper, and every day my world gets darker. Every day my smile fades away. Sometimes, I wonder how much time I have left to live. Honestly, I am very disappointed with life, with myself, and with my God. My heart is full of regret and ‘what ifs.’ Maybe, if I had met you earlier, things would have been different. But now... life is just very tiring.”

Imperial Grand Consort: (*Sighing*) “I heard about your story. I am deeply sorry for everything that happened to you. If I had known earlier, I would have helped, but I was focused on fixing my own problems and helping my son. Because of my impulsiveness, both you and my son got hurt. I cannot change the past. Even if we could go back, nothing can be undone, because nothing changes the fact that what happened has already happened. Your feelings would still be there, even if we altered the past. Don't speak like someone already dead. You are so young, and my son is young too; you have the entire future ahead of you to make happy memories and give me beautiful grandchildren.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “Ahahaha. All my life I have been so lonely, fighting and defending myself, trying to protect the people and things that I love. But every time, everything I love gets taken away from me one by one, until I am left all alone in this dark world. I used to be scared of the darkness and loneliness; my deepest fear was to be lonely and spend the rest of my life alone. Every year that fear came to pass—I lost everything and was left alone in this world. Suddenly, I met my king and you, Mother. Now, I don't know what to do; these things that stopped scaring me are scaring me now... because now I have something and someone to lose.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Does that mean you care about us too?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Yes, and that terrifies me. I cannot sleep at night, and I live in fear and pain every day. I do not want to give life a reason to steal something from me again. The people in my village and temple used to call me a cursed child and a freak. Maybe I am just a curse—to myself and those I love.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Do you know, it all depends on perspective? To my son and me, you have only been a blessing. I am not going anywhere; we are a family. We stick together and fight together. You gained a mother, and I gained a daughter.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Smiles and falls asleep)* Imperial Grand Consort: “Guards!”

Imperial Guards: “Your Highness!” Imperial Grand Consort: “Go tell the king to come pick up his wife; she has fallen asleep.” Imperial Guards: “Yes, Your Highness!”

Narrator: The imperial guards went into the courtroom. They found the king at his office table reviewing records. Imperial Guards: “Respect to you, Your Majesty!”

King Benson: “Fear not, rise. What happened?!” Imperial Guards: “Imperial Grand Consort sent us to tell you that Queen Rosanna has fallen asleep!”

King Benson: *(Stands up with excitement)* “Okay, go! I will follow right behind you.”

Narrator: It was dawn. The king went into the garden. King Benson: “Mom, you asked for me?”

Imperial Grand Consort: “The queen fell asleep. I called you to take her back to your palace.”

King Benson: “She is so cute!” Imperial Grand Consort: “Indeed. I will have cute grandkids.”

King Benson: “Ahahaha, after I make the world safe for them, then we will.” Imperial Grand Consort: “Since all the king's women have been kicked out of the palace, the palace looks empty. If the queen doesn't visit me, I get so bored.”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Interrupting and bowing down)* “Greetings, Majesty!”

King Benson: *(Stares)* Imperial Grand Consort: “Greetings, Rika! What brought you here?!”

King Benson: “Hmmm.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “I was in my quarters when I heard from the palace maids that the king’s mother was hosting a tea party in the garden, so I came to join. Forgive me, Your Highness, for showing up without an invitation!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “This intimate gathering was only for me and my family. Strangers are not invited!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Then I am happy I came!” King Benson: “I don’t think you understand.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Your Majesty, forgive me for being late. I didn’t know the party was set for our imperial family. Nobody came to inform me.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “This party was only for my daughter and my son. You were not invited!” King Benson: “All the imperial women were escorted out of the palace, back to their families. Why are you still here?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “My King... you sentenced my family to work at the border as laborers. I have no family to return to. And I am taking care of Weka’s funeral arrangements.” King Benson: *(Gets angry)* “After all the things you did, you still dare to show your face here?!” Imperial Consort Rika: “But, Ian, all I did was follow Weka’s commands! She was in charge of the harem and held the highest rank. My family was under her control too; I couldn’t disobey!” King Benson: “You dare act familiar with me?” Imperial Consort Rika: “I’ve known you since we were children, Your Majesty! Please show mercy!” King Benson: “The fact that you and your family are even alive is already a great mercy, after you burned the slave village and almost killed my wife!” Imperial Consort Rika: “But I was just following orders, Your Majesty! Weka is the daughter of the imperial family’s main branch, and her father is the prime minister. Tiju’s dad is the commander, and my dad is your advisor. All the ministers are controlled by the Imperial Grand Queen; even if she is deposed by the king, her influence and the influence of the imperial family are too great. Once the news reaches the imperial family, they will rebel. I am the only one who can help you—the only woman left in the palace from the imperial family. Let the king use me to stabilize the court. I am the only one the king can rely on!” *(Smiles)*

King Benson: *(Stares at her)* “Are you threatening your king?!” Imperial Consort Rika: “I dare not!” *(Whispers in her heart)* “No matter what, I must save my family, take them away from the border, and restore our glory.”

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Stares at Rika)* “What if we plan to make the imperial family rebel so we can execute them all at once?” *(Takes a sword from the guards and points it directly at Rika)* “And what is stopping me from taking your head too? After all, you are from the imperial family as well. What if you reported us?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “I would never dare! Please show mercy! Imperial Grand Consort, when you were just the past king’s concubine and the imperial family wanted to get rid of you and King Benson, I stood by you. When you were falsely accused of adultery after the passing of your daughter and sent to the temple, and the king’s wife—the Imperial Grand Queen—wanted to kill your son, I helped him escape the capital. Please remember my loyalty and kindness!” Imperial Grand Consort: “Indeed, you have done that. I will reward you with your life. Go back to your quarters and wait for your judgment.”

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Leaves quickly*) "Thank you for your mercy!" (*Whispered*) "Since you are ruthless, do not blame me for being ruthless." King Benson: "Mom! Are you not scared that she will report us?!"

Imperial Grand Consort: "The louder, the better. That way we can see where her heart truly lies. She is not as innocent as you think; she is more vicious and greedy than all of them." King Benson: "What do you mean?" Imperial Grand Consort: "She is the one who is actually responsible for your sister's death and me being sent to the temple." King Benson: "What?!" Queen Rosanna: (*Waking up*) "What?!" Imperial Grand Consort: "So, you are awake?!" Queen Rosanna: (*Embarrassed*) "Hah! Hahahaha." Imperial Grand Consort: "Come here, my son, sit down. Let me tell you what actually happened." King Benson: (*Takes a seat*) Imperial Grand Consort: "Your advisor Mixian's late wife—Tiju's stepmother—was my best friend. We were from the same state. When your father was young, his closest friend, Mixian, came to visit our state; they met us at my father's store. To make a long story short, I married the king, and she married the king's best friend. We moved into the palace. Out of jealousy, my best friend's personal maid got drunk on Mixian's alcohol and slept with him. The maid got pregnant and gave birth to Rika. Mixian began to favor the maid more than his own wife. Out of grief, my best friend passed away, and the maid got promoted to a consort and was adopted into the imperial family, and Rika became the legitimate first daughter of the king's best friend. To bury the truth, my friend's name was erased, her title revoked, and her tomb removed from the imperial family grounds. Hearing this terrible news, I went into premature labor and gave birth to you. Your sister was furious and sent a letter exposing Mixian. At that time, Rika was three, and your sister was twelve. I was originally supposed to be queen, but the imperial family took advantage of my condition and forced your father to marry the Imperial Grand Queen instead. With the unofficial backing of the Imperial Grand Queen, Rika received full royal treatment. She attended the imperial school, where she met Weka, the queen's niece and the daughter of the prime minister; Tiju, the daughter of the commander; along with the queen's daughter and her own sister. Even though your sister was the favorite imperial princess, next to her, a mere concubine like me stood no chance against the imperial family; she was like an ant to them. She wasn't happy about Rika, so she sent a letter of complaint against Mixian to your father. Your father punished Mixian and confined him for a year. During the new year, the prince of our neighboring empire visited us. According to my investigation, Rika was the one who led the prince to the queen's daughter, believing that was your sister. On New Year's Eve, the neighboring prince requested a peace alliance through marriage, asking to marry the queen's daughter. The queen was completely against it; she tried to force your sister to take her daughter's place, but your dad refused. The queen's niece was next, but she was in love with your brother. When the queen kidnapped you and me to force your sister to marry in her daughter's place, the imperial family threatened your father with our lives. So finally your father agreed to the political marriage. On the wedding day, Mixian was supposed to secretly escape with your sister out of the palace, but Rika found out and told Weka. Before your sister escaped, Weka caught her and accidentally killed her. Rika then forged the suicide letter. That was when you began scheming against the queen. In the end, the queen's daughter was married off to the neighboring empire. Rika's main obstacle was gone, but I knew the truth and her true identity. Mixian's consort, Rika, and the queen schemed against me. Rika came to me and claimed she knew what happened to your sister, telling me that if I followed her into your sister's room, she would reveal everything to me. Once I stepped into your sister's room, I suddenly fainted. I had no idea what was happening until the harem women suddenly burst in and accused me of having an affair with a palace guard."

King Benson: *(Speechless)* “Impossible! She was only five by then! When you got accused of adultery, she was only five years old. How could she scheme so deeply?!”

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Takes a sip of her tea)* “Sadly, not all kids are angels; some are just devils. Who would suspect a five-year-old?! And in everything, who benefits the most?! And who is still standing in power right now?!”

King Benson: “When I visited Weka in the cold palace, she told me that she visited my sister on her wedding day. She just wanted to talk, but things got out of hand. They got into an argument; Weka was trying to stop my sister from escaping, and she accidentally killed her. Following the advice of her maid, she passed it off as a suicide.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “She is truly vicious!” King Benson: “But we have no proof.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “You keep your friends close, but your enemies closer. The best way to control and watch her is right here in the palace. Here, we have control.”

King Benson: “How will that help us punish her? Remember, my wife is in the palace too.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “We corner her and the imperial family and cut off their source all at once. Eventually, she will make a mistake. The bigger the mistake, the better.”

King Benson: “What is bigger than rebellion and treason?” Imperial Grand Consort: *(Smiles)*

King Benson: “Then we keep the plan.” Queen Rosanna: “Well, then we just have to play the game.”

King Benson: “Yes, a loving game. We will show the world how strong our love is. We will leave no room for anyone else, making Rika and the imperial family desperate until they rebel. After all, if the prime minister doesn't get his way, he will try to take it by force. He is a greedy man.”

Queen Rosanna: “So we play their game against them.” Imperial Grand Consort: *(Stands up)* “I am tired. I am going back to my quarters.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Stands up)* “Rest well, Mother.”

King Benson: *(Smiles)* Narrator: It was late at night when the king and queen returned to their quarters. The Imperial Grand Consort returned to her quarters, planning what to do next.

King Benson: *(Staring at his wife sleeping, then standing up, walking toward the balcony, and looking at the garden)* “Hmmm.”

Narrator: Thirty minutes later, Rosanna wakes up. She touches the bed, but the king isn't there.

Queen Rosanna: *(Standing up and looking for him)* “My king! Maid, where is my husband?”

Personal Maid: “My Queen, the king is on the balcony!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Walks toward the balcony)* “Maid, you can withdraw.” *(At the balcony)* “What keeps my husband up at night?!”

King Benson: *(Turns toward the queen and smiles)* “If it is not my queen! The queen of my heart, what else shall bother me?”

Queen Rosanna: “Then why is my king not in bed with me?! My husband, what bothers you?!”
King Benson: *(Smiles)* “Now that I see your face, nothing bothers me.”

Queen Rosanna: “You always make that face when you are thinking of something or doubting something.”

King Benson: *(Hugs his wife)* “I am thinking about us and our future, and reflecting on my journey. You were brought to the capital against your will, and because of that, your parents died, and your village was destroyed. I was careless, and you got hurt. My imperial family caused you so much harm. Do you blame me?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Of course I do. You caused so much mess and hurt.”

King Benson: *(Looks down)* “Hmmm.”

Queen Rosanna: “But at the same time, I understand. We both got used as weapons by other people, and we got used against each other. But I forgave you a long time ago.” *(She holds Benson’s face)* “I forgave you a long time ago. It is true that when I think about all that happened, I get sad and cry, but that will never change the fact that I love you. You are my only husband, my king, and my soulmate—the man I will share all my nights and days with.”

King Benson: “As a prince and a king, I was surrounded only by people who schemed against me, or people who used my hand to harm others. On some occasions, people called me ruthless or a playboy. Of course, as a king or prince, I had to scheme and hurt people too. But as a husband, you are my life and priority. I have heard a lot of people telling me that they love me, but all they loved was my influence, power, authority, and riches. They loved what I have and what I can give them. Each person expects something from me and wants something from me. How about you? Is your love as sincere as mine?!” Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “All I know is how to give and how to love others; that is how I was raised and who I decided to be. I don't know what it is like to be loved, protected, wanted, or cared for. I don't know how to receive it, especially good things. I am used to trouble, begging, crying, and fighting. Now, standing in front of you, I don't know how to keep my composure. Your love for me is too great; I don't know how to receive it, but at the same time, I am scared to lose it. You never ask me for anything, but instead, you only give me things. Sometimes, I really don't understand you, but I love it... and I love you, sincerely.”

King Benson: “I love you sincerely too. I want you, I need you. Mine. Wife.”

Queen Rosanna: “I want you all for myself. I don't want to share you; I am a very jealous woman. I hate sharing what is mine.”

King Benson: (*Kissing her*) “Then we are the same. Love me... make love to me... every day and every night. You don't have to give me anything; I just want you and your affection. All of it, everything for me only.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Kissing him back*) “It was always yours!”

Narrator: The king and queen became one all through the night. In the morning, the king and queen dressed in their royal robes and went to the court meeting room, walking hand in hand all the way to their thrones, and sat together.

King Benson: (*Teasing*) “Let me pour all my love on you tonight.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Turns away from the balcony*) “Right here? Outside?”

King Benson: (*Lifts her against the wall and kisses her*) “Right now!”

Queen Rosanna: “People will hear us, and I do not...”

King Benson: (*Interrupts*) “The louder, the better.”

Narrator: Early in the morning, there was a gathering in the court.

Ministers: (*Bow down and speak in unison*) “We show respect to the King and Queen. May harmony rule over the empire and harem. Long life! Long life!”

King Benson: (*Smiles*) “Rise, my royal ministers.”

Prime Minister: (*Stands in front of the ministers*) “I have a report, my King. Why is the harem dismissed? And this is a men's place—why is there a woman here?”

Queen Rosanna: “Insolent!” Prime Minister: “This is not your village; this is a courtroom. Go back to your harem and play house.”

Ministers: (*Whisper*) “Yes, yes... yes!”

King Benson: “You dare disrespect my queen in front of me?! Are you not afraid to lose your life?!” Ministers: (*Bow down in fear*)

Prime Minister: “Why are you bowing? We are just telling the truth!”

King Benson: (*Holds his sword inside his robe*) “You dare, Prime Minister? I see I gave you too much power, and now you dare ride over your king's head.”

Prime Minister: “My King, you are still young, and you need to be educated about how things work here. Maybe you are not fit to be king.”

King Benson: “You dare!” Queen Rosanna: (*Holds the king's hand*) “Guards, take that insolent man and beat him until he bleeds.”

Prime Minister: *(Standing up with pride)* “You dare?! Let me see who dares touch me!”

King Benson: *(Standing up from his throne)* “Today we will see if it is I who is king, or you and your imperial family!”

Prime Minister: “My family has been here since this empire was established, from the first king to your father! We have been loyal and faithful, fighting at the border and keeping the court in harmony. All the empire knows the tales of our imperial family.”

King Benson: “It seems all the rewards and accomplishments your family has received went to your head. Never forget that all those rewards and titles were given by the king and... can be taken away by the king.”

Prime Minister: “You dare!”

King Benson: “Guards, take this insolent man and flog him until my Queen is satisfied.” Prime Minister: “Who dares touch me?!”

Imperial Guards: *(Dragging the prime minister out of the courtroom and flogging him)* “Forgive us, sir.”

Queen Rosanna: “Keep beating him! Flog him hard!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Runs into the courtroom)* “Let me see who dares?!” *(Enters the courtroom)* “You, a village girl, dare touch the imperial family?!”

Ministers: *(Still bowing down)* “Respect, Imperial Consort!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Bows down)* “Greetings, Your Majesty.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Glares)* “What did I say? Keep flogging him hard!” Imperial Guards: *(Keep flogging the prime minister hard)* “Yes, Your Majesty!”

King Benson: *(Looks at the queen and whispers)* “This is so satisfying!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “Keep beating.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Your Majesty, what did the prime minister do to anger you? On my behalf and for all the service he has done for the empire, please show mercy on his old bones!”

Queen Rosanna: “I said beat him, continue beating!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “My King! The imperial government is always loyal and faithful. Please consider the length of our service. Because of a woman, the king is humiliating our imperial family?!”

King Benson: “Anyone who disrespects my wife disrespects me!”

Queen Rosanna: “And anyone who disrespects the king disrespects me too! You have to understand that the king owes your imperial family nothing; you are subjects of the empire. You hold the king hostage, and your disrespect has reached the heavens.”

King Benson: “The prime minister will be an example. Whoever disrespects the crown will face worse than flogging.” (*Looks at Rika*) “There will be no mercy.” Ministers: “Your ministers accept the decree.”

Queen Rosanna: “Keep flogging! If Imperial Consort Rika feels so deeply for his old bones, then feel free to join your uncle!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “I dare not!”

Queen Rosanna: “Was all that worry and affection about family fake?!”

King Benson: (*Holds his head*) “I am tired. I am going back to my quarters. The meeting is dismissed!”

Queen Rosanna: “Guana!” Personal Maid Guana: “Yes, Your Highness!”

Queen Rosanna: (*As the king and queen leave the courtroom*) “Supervise the punishment. Make sure it happens exactly as it was spoken.”

Personal Maid Guana: (*Joins the imperial guards*) “Keep beating!”

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Slaps Guana*) “How dare a lowly maid disrespect the imperial family?! You dare wish for death!”

Personal Maid Guana: “I dare not, Your Highness; I am just following the orders left by Their Majesties, the King and Queen!”

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Slaps her back*) “You dare speak back to me, maid?! Hold her down!”

Personal Maid Guana: “Who dares? I am the queen’s maid and under the king's protection. Who dares touch me?”

Maids: (*Stop*) Imperial Consort Rika: “If they cannot touch you, I can touch you. Let's see how that village girl protects you!”

Personal Maid Guana: (*Slaps the imperial consort back*)

Imperial Consort Rika: “You lowly maid, you dare to slap me?!”

Personal Maid Guana: (*Slapping her again*) “I slap and slap you, so what?! The king decreed that whoever dares disrespect the crown will face worse than flogging. So I slap and slap, and I will slap you again! As an imperial maidservant of the queen, I hold justice according to the queen's command.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Aha, I see! Now even a lowly maid can disrespect me. Wait until my auntie comes out of her punishment; I will deal with you.” (*Physically attacks Guana*) Imperial Guard: (*Interferes and pushes Imperial Consort Rika back*) “Please, Your Highness, respect yourself and return to your quarters!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “I see you are all working together, ahaha. The imperial family is still in power; I will wait and watch you all beg on your knees for your lives.” (*Looks at her uncle*) “Uncle, hang on! I am going to see the Grand Imperial Queen.”

Prime Minister: (*Being flogged*) “Your Majesty, you can't do this to me! I am the prime minister, the foundation of this empire! Show mercy, Your Majesty...!” (*Faints*)

Imperial Consort Rika: (*Back in her quarters, screaming and beating her maid*) “Why is this happening now? What can I do? There must be a way out. I need to see my aunt. Yes, yes... I can still use her. Yes! Maids!”

Maids: “Yes, Your Highness.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Get me ready, I am going to see the Grand Imperial Queen!” Maids: “Yes!” King Benson: (*Walking in the garden with the queen*) “You did well!” Queen Rosanna: “Really?!”

King Benson: (*Pulls her close to his chest*) “Yes, that was very cool.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Holds his waist*) “After this confrontation, there is no going back!” King Benson: (*Kisses her*) “Yes, that is why you have to stay close to me.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Kisses him back*) “I know. It means they are about to make a move; you have to be careful.”

King Benson: (*Starts slipping his hand inside her robe*) “Hmmm, yeah, yeah! I am very careful.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Looks at his hand entering her robe*) “Are you listening?!”

King Benson: (*Distracted, looking at her skin*) “Yeah, yeah. Very careful and gentle too!” (*Kisses her neck*)

Queen Rosanna: (*Pulls away and holds his cheek*) “You are not even paying attention!” King Benson: “Yes, I am listening!”

Queen Rosanna: “Really! What did I say?!” King Benson: “Ah... Hmmmm?!” Queen Rosanna: (*Puffy face, turning away*) “I am going to see your mom.”

King Benson: (*Following close behind her*) “No! No! I promise I was listening. Come on, my queen, don't be angry!” (*Smiling*) “I love you! Ahahaha.”

Imperial Guards: (*At the Palace of Splendor*) “Queen Rosanna is here. Respect to the Queen!” (*Bows down*)

Queen Rosanna: *(Entering her mother-in-law's quarters)* “Rise! Mother! Mom, where are you?!”
(She sits down)

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Coming out of her inner chamber)* “Queen! You are here! Tell me everything that happened in the courtroom.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles, holds her mother-in-law's hands)* “Oh. My. God. Mother, it was crazy! The prime minister was trying to put the king and me down, but we flogged him in front of all the officers, hahaha! He tried to use his influence and family name to oppress the king, but we shut it down and flogged him. Nobody stood up, hahahaha!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Oh. My. God, I should have been there to see it! Why didn't you inform me? I waited so long to put that old man in his place, hahaha! I heard from the maids that Rika also came to the court?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “Yes, she did. She tried to use her family against us, but we put her in her place. Now everyone knows that all her talk about caring for family is just empty words hiding a hunger for power! Ahahaha!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “She has already made her next move. The maids saw her going to see the Grand Imperial Queen. She is on her way right now!”

Imperial Guards: *(Bow down)* “King Benson is here. Respect to the King!” King Benson:
(Entering the quarters and taking a seat) “How are you, Mother?!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Come on, sit down and tell me everything that happened in the court! Sit! Sit! What do we do next?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Now the imperial family is realizing that the king can't be controlled and they are losing control. They will do everything to regain it!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Will this be enough to make them desperate?!”

King Benson: *(Thoughtfully)* “I guess that the prime minister already knows that the Grand Imperial Queen is in isolation and has been demoted to Yuri, her homeland family name, without a title. But she still has power and influence. Honestly, the imperial family does too. We will let Rika see the

Grand Imperial Queen; I will ask the imperial guards to give her a hard time before letting her enter the Palace of Virtues...”

Queen Rosanna: “How can we know what they will talk about? Those two together are dangerous!”

King Benson: "I already have arrangements for that. After all, all the imperial family's spies were removed and replaced by our people and by people whom the imperial family has harmed. This palace is crying for revenge!"

Queen Rosanna: "Are you sure we can trust those people?!"

King Benson: "I handpicked them myself!"

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Nods)* "That is good! How is the process of making a baby going?!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Shocked with embarrassment)* "Hmmm."

King Benson: *(Smiles)* "How is that process going, my queen?! Hahaha!"

Queen Rosanna: "Stop teasing me!"

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Smiles)* "So cute! I just want to keep you in my quarters. You can spend the evening with me; we will work on the garden, organize scrolls, study the words of God and poetry, and continue your training. I will personally teach you what I know!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Bows down)* "Thank you, Mother!"

King Benson: "What? No, Mother. I had plans for us this evening. How can I live without my wife?! I need my wife back!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Looks at the king and giggles)* "Mother, I would love to spend all day with you, to learn and study."

King Benson: "No, you would not. I am good at teaching, too."

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Laughs out loud)* "Ahahahaha! You are so funny! My quarters haven't been visited for a while. Let's have dinner here tonight."

King Benson: "Yes, and I am taking my wife with me too."

Queen Rosanna: *(Puffy face)* "Mother, your son keeps hitting on me all the time. I can't sleep at night or during the day! Even my lips hurt—look at my lips, they're swollen!"

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Looks at her lips)* "Yes, they are a little bit swollen. Maids, go call the imperial doctor!"

King Benson: "Let me see your lips!"

Queen Rosanna: "Look, see? It hurts, hmmm. You keep pulling on them!"

King Benson: "But last night, you bit my lips, and I bled."

Queen Rosanna: "That was because you didn't want to sleep..." Maids: "The imperial doctor is here!"

Imperial Doctor: *(Entering the quarters and bowing down)* “My greetings, Your Majesties!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Rise, please. Thank you for coming. Check the king and queen's lips—I mean, health!” *(Giggles)*

Imperial Doctor: *(Looks at the queen's eyes and lips, takes her pulse, checks her back and chest, then looks at the king...)* “Replying to the Imperial Grand Consort, the king and queen are both in strong shape. In my guess, the king is quite active, similar to the queen...!”

King Benson: “Do not be shy here, Doctor; we are family. And to your question: I am very active with my queen.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “How about the queen's health? How many times shall they try for me to get a grandchild?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Covers her face)*

Imperial Doctor: “The best time to do it is in the morning, at night, and between nights. Also, the queen needs rest; after her recovery and enough rest, conceiving will not be an issue. I will prescribe creams for the lips and change her diet for a quick pregnancy.”

Grand Imperial Queen: “Beautiful, beautiful! I know you will never disappoint me! You are dismissed. A reward!” *(Hahaha)* “My son, the king will stay tonight in my palace. After she recovers, she will return. Maids, serve dinner!”

King Benson: “See! I was right. Loving you in the morning, at night, and between nights was the right way to go.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Correction)* “My King, you mean all night!”

King Benson: “If you want, I will let you have control all night, too! And if you serve me well and I am pleased and satisfied, I will reward you amazingly.”

Queen Rosanna: “Hmmmm.”

King Benson: “After using me in the court today, you need to feed me well. Ahahaha, maid!”

Queen Rosanna: “I can pay you another way.”

King Benson: “Well, my bed is the only way.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Whispering to him)* “Your mom is here; can you be shy?”

King Benson: *(Looks at his mom and whispers back)* “Everyone already heard you screaming last night on the balcony and in the garden. Being shy will not work. The deal is a deal; you've got to pay me for using me.”

Queen Rosanna: “After my recovery.”

King Benson: “How long do you need?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Three days, maybe.”

King Benson: “And after that, you will end up needing a three-month bed rest recovering!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Puffy face)* “My husband!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “What are you two talking about?” King Benson: *(Puffy face)* “Mother, my queen needs to pay...”

Queen Rosanna: *(Interrupting and covering the king’s mouth)* “Nothing, absolutely nothing. Let’s have dinner.” *(Stares at the king and whispers)* “Be good and I will pay you!”

King Benson: *(Giggles and kisses/bites her hand)* “Deal! Maids, prepare two rooms!” Queen Rosanna: “Two rooms?!”

King Benson: “I will also stay in my mother’s quarters! Let’s go eat.” Imperial Grand Consort: *(Giggles and smiles)*

Narrator: After a few minutes, everyone moved to the dinner table. The maids served all the royal delicacies, including fish, meat, vegetables, dessert, and more. Meanwhile, later that evening, Imperial Consort Rika arrived at the Palace of Virtues to see her aunt, the Grand Imperial Queen.

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Trying to enter the Palace of Virtues)*

Imperial Guards: *(Stop her at the gate, bow down)* “Greetings, Imperial Consort Rika.” Imperial Consort Rika: *(Tries to enter)* “Rise!”

Imperial Guards: “Our apologies, these quarters were sealed by the king.”

Imperial Consort Rika: “How dare you stop me? Do you know who I am?! The Grand Imperial Queen is the one who is in charge of this palace, and the imperial family controls the empire. How dare you seal these quarters?!”

Imperial Guards: “We are just following the decree!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “When my family restores their authority in the palace, I will not treat you unfairly. Maid, give them some gold as a deposit.”

Imperial Guards: *(Take the gold)* “We give you ten minutes.” Imperial Consort Rika: *(Entering the quarters and crying)* “Auntie!”

Yuri: *(Ex-Grand Imperial Queen, running toward Rika)* “Rika, how are you?! Why do you look like a mess? What happened outside my quarters?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Holding her aunt and crying)* “Auntie, you have no idea. Ever since you got locked down, the entire palace has been looking down on us and punishing us. Our food and luxuries have been cut off; we barely eat.”

Yuri: “Who dares look down on this family?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Ever since the king promoted the village girl to queen and dismissed the harem permanently, he only has eyes for that slave. Nobody dares speak against her. The king's mother is in charge of the harem, so our family's movement is limited.”

Yuri: “This palace is full of our family's people and hostages; none of them dare betray us. And my brother, the prime minister, is in charge of the empire and court. Go ask him to put pressure on the king to release me!” Imperial Consort Rika: “Uncle got flopped; he is half-dead back at his mansion.”

Yuri: “Who dares touch my brother?! Shouldn't all their families be executed?!” Imperial Consort Rika: “It was the king; I was instigated by that Rosanna!”

Yuri: *(Falls to the ground)* “What?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Holding her aunt and continuing to cry)* “Yes, Auntie! The king flogged him and left him half-dead. All his assets and titles were confiscated, and his palace is locked too. The king accused him of treason, and he is under investigation!” *(Crying)*

Yuri: *(Puts her hand on her chest)* “That son of a concubine... I should have killed him when I had the chance. My brother was right all along! What about Weka?! Where is Weka?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Smiles in her heart, then suddenly switches to crying)* “Auntie, she is dead too!”

Yuri: *(Running out of breath)* “What? My Weka?! Dead?! How?!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Because of that seductress! The king sent Weka to the cold palace and sentenced her to death for our family name and honor.” *(Smiles in her heart)* “Weka committed suicide! It is only me, Auntie.” *(Crying)*

Yuri: “Take this token; it can control the imperial soldiers. Take this letter and send it to the border, to the commander. My son asked him to return to the capital. It is time.” Imperial Consort Rika: *(Looks at the letter and token)* “Time for what?!”

Yuri: “To return power to where it is supposed to be.” Imperial Consort Rika: “A commander returning to the capital without an imperial decree from the king is treason!” Yuri: “That's why everything must go smoothly and carefully. A big surprise—we will show them what the imperial family is made of!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “I will do as you said.” *(Walks out, smiles, and whispers in her heart)* “I will give Benson one more chance. If he chooses that slave girl, I will show no mercy.” *(Walks out of the quarters)* “Honestly, you are too powerless to be alive; you can stay here in this cold place and die. Once I get back to the king, kill that village girl, become queen, and give birth, the prime minister will go too. But I need the imperial family name for my son and to keep the king in check. Ahahahahahahah. See, Weka? In the end, it is me who wins and gets it all—the man you love so much, and the highest place. Me, yes, me. Only me, ahahaha.”

Imperial Grand Consort: *(After dinner at the Palace of Splendor quarters)* “Maid! Show where the king will rest tonight!” King Benson: *(Looks at the queen)* “Hmmm, I am going to rest.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Looks back at the king)* “Have a beautiful dream, my husband.”

King Benson: *(Waiting)* “Hmmm, is that all?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Looks at the Imperial Grand Consort)* “Did we forget anything else?” Imperial Grand Consort: “Not really. Did we, my son?!”

King Benson: “What if someone attacks me once I leave the quarters, or gets sick, or dies? Is that all you will say to me?!”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Such a thing will not happen. My palace is the safest place to be! Everyone here is my people!”

King Benson: *(Looking displeased)* “Anything can happen here.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Stands up and kisses her husband)* “I love you! Sincerely! Let's live a long life together, and you will be safe. Okay?!”

King Benson: *(Holding her and kissing her deeply)* “Yes. I love you too sincerely, my wife!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Smiles)* “Are you happy?!”

King Benson: “I will be happier if you spend tonight with me. I will pleasure you.”

Queen Rosanna: “Remember what the imperial doctor said. I need rest. See? You always take all the time you get to hit on me!”

King Benson: *(Giggles)* “Hahahaha! Because my love for you is too strong!” Imperial Grand Consort: *(Smiles)* “Maids! Show the queen where she should rest tonight. I am going to rest too!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Going to her inner chamber)* “Rest well, Mother!” Narrator: Outside the palace, at the prime minister's mansion, all the ministers were gathering... Prime Minister's Wife: *(Beside his bed, crying)* “Oh, my God! Who did this to my lord?! My husband, who dared hurt you?!”

Prime Minister's Daughter: *(Crying)* “You got beaten so badly?! Doctor, how is he doing?!”

Doctor: “Replying to you, Princess, he has lost a lot of blood. His wounds are very severe. I will prescribe medicine, Your Highness!”

Prime Minister's Daughter: “Guards, take this useless thing and execute him! The rest of you—if none of you can heal my father, you will share the same fate!”

Doctors: *(Shaking in fear)* “Show mercy, Princess!” One

Doctor: *(Yelling while being dragged down to be executed)* “Show mercy! Show mercy, Princess! I have a wife and daughter! They only have me! Please show mercy!”

Guards: (*Directly execute him*) “Your own fault for angering the princess!”

Ministers: “We never imagined that a useless king would oppose the imperial family and beat the prime minister to the brink of death.”

Minister of Revenue: “Foolishness! I did discourage you from crowning him, but all of you insisted, saying since he is young and the child of a concubine, it would be easy to control him. Now look where we are today!”

Minister of Education: “I do not want to be a part of this anymore. I do not want to involve my family.”

Ministers: “Yes, yes... This is becoming too dangerous. The king is not under our control. That Rosanna is dangerous too. It is better to stay away from this matter; our families could get executed for this!”

Minister of Security: “None of us have clean hands. At the end of the day, if the prime minister falls, we all fall.”

Minister of Agriculture: “But if we confess to the king and give him proof of the evil things the prime minister did, maybe out of mercy he will forgive us or not kill our families.”

Minister of Treasury: “I was born in luxury, all my family was raised in luxury. Living a life without a title or as a commoner is worse than death.”

Princess: “You ungrateful idiots! After all the things my family has done for you, you dare think of betraying us?! Maybe I should beat you to death myself! Listen well: this mansion will never be my father's, who has been forging a secret weapon for a day like this, and a secret army too! We knew that sooner or later the power of our family would be a threat to the throne and one day the king would try to wipe us out. So we prepared in advance. We put him on that throne, and we will remove him from it. Once the Grand Imperial Queen gives us a sign, we will break into the palace and take over. I will personally deal with Rosanna.”

Minister of Resources: “Rebellion?! If it fails, we will all be executed without mercy.” Minister of Tailor: “What if it is a trap? Let's think carefully!”

Princess: “Are you scared?! Or do you only enjoy the money and influence this family offers you? You have to show your loyalty now. If you stay faithful in this hard time, once we take back the throne, I will reward you handsomely. But as a princess of this empire and daughter of the prime minister, I will not force my people to fight for my cause. If you want to fight with us in the palace, move beside me; and if you do not want to follow, stand in the middle of the room!”

Narrator: Half of the ministers stood up and went to the middle of the room. Ministers: “We have kids. We have families to take care of. Following the prime minister and living as a corrupt official was never a good idea. We will repent. Maybe we'll ask the king to forgive us. We do not want to be in this mess anymore.”

Princess: “Thirty ungrateful idiots! Guards, execute them all, and go to their mansions and kill their entire tribes! No trace, no proof left behind.”

Ministers: (*Executed immediately*) “Show mercy! Spare our families!”

Princess: “You twelve ministers who chose to stay, I will not treat you unfairly. But for safety reasons, none of you will be allowed to leave this mansion until the rebellion is over. Guards, take the rest of the ministers to prison!”

Ministers: “Princess, show mercy! We are loyal to the imperial family; we will never betray you, Princess. Show mercy!”

Princess: (*Whispering*) “It does not matter anyway; all of you will die, and your families will be wiped out. The new empire has to be clean, with no trace of the past. Hahahaha.” Prime Minister’s Wife: (*Smiling*) “They are going to pay!”

Narrator: Back in the palace, Imperial Consort Rika had a new plan.

Imperial Consort Rika: (*In her quarters, looking at the letter and the token and smiling*) “Benson! Benson. What can I do with you? Look how dirty my hands are, all because of you. What will you choose now?”

Maid: “My lady, there is news out of the Palace of Splendor: the Imperial Grand Consort called the doctor. I believe the queen is not feeling well, and the king will be alone. This is our chance to change the game!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Good job, a reward! Go tell the king that Rika discovered a secret of the imperial family and needs to see him now. Prepare some alcohol to add to it. Tonight, I must conceive the king's child, ahahahaha.”

Narrator: The maids prepared everything as Imperial Consort Rika asked, and the king was summoned to Rika’s quarters.

King Benson: (*In his inner chamber, alone in his room*) “Oh man! So now I am alone in my room. I do not want to sleep alone; I miss my queen. Maybe I can go visit her in her chambers!”

King’s Eunuch: “My King, the doctor said the queen needs to rest!”

King Benson: “Well, I will just talk to her. I mean, just look at her. I will not touch her or do anything. I will just lie beside her.”

King’s Eunuch: (*Gives the king a knowing look*) “We both know...”

Maids: “My King, Imperial Consort Rika sent us here to request your visit. She said she found out something about the imperial family!”

King Benson: (*Smiles and whispers*) “The fish has taken the bait.”

King’s Eunuch: “Will the king not visit the queen?”

King Benson: "I will listen to the doctor. Let us visit Rika and bring that special alcohol we prepared." Maid: *(Bows down)* "Welcome to the quarters, my King!"

King Benson: *(Entering the quarters)* "Rise. Where is Rika?!" Imperial Consort Rika: *(Covering herself with just a light, translucent fabric)* "Here! My King, you actually came!" King Benson: "Maybe I came at the wrong time. You don't look dressed properly." Imperial Consort Rika: "My apologies, My King, I was taking a shower. Please make yourself comfortable. I bought this expensive alcohol—your favorite. Let's drink and talk."

King Benson: "I did not come to drink, but to get the news you discovered. But since we share the same mind, I brought you a drink too. Give me a cup; let me pour you some." Imperial Consort Rika: *(Drinks)* "Let me pour you some too!" King Benson: *(Stares at her and drinks too)*

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Sweating)* "My body... I am so hot, it's so hot. I want you. What is happening to me? Ah! Hot!"

King Benson: *(Stands up)* "Guards!"

King's Personal Imperial Guards: "Yes, My King!"

King Benson: "As your reward for your service, I give her to you. Enjoy yourselves without limit!"

King's Personal Imperial Guards: "Let's go, Rika; I will take care of you tonight! Ahahha." King Benson: "That is for what you did to my mom and wife—take your own medicine, Rika. Omg, my body is so hot, I need to see my wife." *(Goes to see the queen)*

Queen Rosanna: *(Sleeping)* "Ah! Hmmmm!" Maid: "Your Majesty, the king is drunk! Wake up!"

Queen Rosanna: "How? What?" King Benson: *(Breaks into her room, kissing the queen and taking off her clothes)* "I need you now; I cannot control myself!"

Queen Rosanna: "Go call the imperial doctor now!" Maids: "Yes, Your Majesty!"

King Benson: *(Tears her clothes, carrying her to her bed and kissing his wife)* "Now! Now! Pay me! Serve me!"

Queen Rosanna: "What happened? How did you get like this? Calm down, let the imperial doctor check you first, okay?!"

Imperial Doctor: "Greetings, my Queen!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Holding the king down, sitting on top of him)* "Come fast, check the king!"

Imperial Doctor: *(Shocked)* "Ah!" Queen Rosanna: "Come fast, stop standing around!" Imperial Doctor: *(Checking)* "The king has been poisoned with a pleasure poison. This poison has no cure, but only hmmm..."

Queen Rosanna: “Only what?” Imperial Doctor: “Hmmm, only physical pleasure. You will have to make love to the king to clear the poison.” *(Runs out of the room)* Maids and Eunuchs: *(Run out of the room too)*

Queen Rosanna: “What? My dear husband, you certainly know how to worry about your wife.” *(She takes off her clothes, undresses him, and sits on top of him)* “Then let me serve you tonight. I will pleasure you!”

King Benson: “Fast, now!”

Narrator: Only screams came out of the room all night until morning. King Benson: *(Staring at his wife and whispering)* “Why is it morning?! I need more.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Looking at her husband)* “My body hurts. Are you awake? Are you feeling—”

King Benson: *(Giggles)* “I think I am still poisoned. I need you on top of me now.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Hides under her blanket, whispering to herself)* “I did not know you were so fearless in bed. Tell me, what do you want?! I need you to please me. Sit on top again?!”

Queen Rosanna: “My back hurts; it's your turn to be on top.”

King Benson: *(Smiles)* “I shall fulfill your demand, my Queen.”

Narrator: Imperial Consort Rika woke up in her bed wearing only the king's top robe, thinking that the man she spent the night with was the king. Imperial Consort Rika: “Finally, we did it. My son will be born soon. Ahahaha, Rosanna, you lost! I can't wait to see your face when you find out that the king and I had a passionate night, ahahahah. Maid, go call the imperial doctor. I need my pulse to be checked, ahahah.”

Maid: “Yes, Your Highness!” *(Whispers to herself)* “You fool, you will pay for all the evil you've done to my family.” Imperial Doctor: “Congratulations, Imperial Consort Rika, you are pregnant!”

Imperial Consort Rika: “Ahahahah, yes! Yes! A reward, everyone gets rewarded! Good job, good job, ahahaha. Finally, I am on top. You are finished, Rosanna! I have the army in my hand, and the heir. It is all mine. Maids, go request a meeting with the Imperial Grand Consort. Tell her I have good news to tell her, ahahahahha.” Maids: “Yes, Your Highness!” Narrator: A few days later, Imperial Consort Rika visited the Palace of Splendor.

Imperial Consort Rika: “Greetings, Mother.” Imperial Grand Consort: *(Sitting with Rosanna and drinking tea)* “What news did you want to share?” Imperial Consort Rika: “I am pregnant!” Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)*

Imperial Grand Consort: “And who is the father?!” Imperial Consort Rika: “Who else but the king himself? After all, I am a king's woman.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Still drinking tea)* “Some people never give up. That is impossible.” Imperial Consort Rika: “Days ago, the king and I shared a passionate night, and by God's mercy, I conceived.”

Imperial Grand Consort: “Bring the imperial doctor.” Maid: “Yes, Your Highness!” Imperial Doctor: “My Queen, you summoned me?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Check her right there and tell me if she is pregnant.” Imperial Doctor: *(Checks her pulse, replies to Their Majesties)* “She is indeed pregnant.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Stands up)* “What?! Impossible!”

Imperial Grand Consort: *(Holds the queen's hand)* “Calm down, there must be an explanation. You know this is Rika.”

Queen Rosanna: “Go call the king! Now!” Maids: “Yes, my Queen!”

King Benson: *(Running toward Rosanna)* “My wife, you called for me?”

Queen Rosanna: “Did you sleep with Rika?!” King Benson: *(Smiles)* “Calm down. Listen to me.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying)* “Do not tell me to calm down; she is pregnant! You broke your word; you promised!” *(Crying)*

Imperial Consort Rika: *(Smiles)* Queen Rosanna: *(Takes a sword from a guard and directly attacks Rika to end her right there)* “Then die!”

King Benson: *(Holds the sword with his bare hand and bleeds)* “Calm down! It is a misunderstanding.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying)* “You dare to defend her and protect her?!”

King Benson: *(Takes away the sword as he bleeds)* “Do not dirty your hands; that is my job.” *(Carries Rosanna on his shoulder)* “Guards, take Rika to her quarters! She is now Imperial Noble Consort Rika!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Smiles)* “Thank you, Your Majesty. I know you had feelings for me and our child.”

King Benson: “She is not allowed to go out of her quarters until her child is born! From today on, my mother is the Grand Imperial Queen, and Yuri will be sent to the cold palace to never return.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Being taken away by the guards)* “What?! My King, you cannot do this to me! I am carrying your child, I am carrying the royal bloodline!” *(Crying)* King Benson: *(Laughing loudly while carrying Rosanna and walking away)* “Ahahaha, who told you that was my child?!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Shocked)* “What do you mean, My King? Clearly we slept together! We made love, clearly!”

King Benson: *(In the private chamber, gently puts Rosanna on her bed while bleeding)* “Calm down, it is a misunderstanding, okay? That is not my child, and I did not sleep with Rika!”

Queen Rosanna: “But she said two days ago you spent the night with her?!” King Benson: *(Smiles)* “My wife, is your memory foggy? Two days ago, I was poisoned, and you were on top of me, loving me hard. Remember? Or should I show you right now how that night was?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Blushing)* “But how is she pregnant?!”

King Benson: “I gave her to the very same guards who were accused of adultery with my mother! I used the same guards to make her an adulteress.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Stops crying)* “I see!” King Benson: *(Holding her while bleeding, wiping her tears away, and pulling her close)*

Queen Rosanna: *(Stands up, turns away, and holds her womb)* “Really?” *(Smiles)* “I will treat your wound.”

King Benson: *(Smiles)* “Ahahahah.” Queen Rosanna: *(Treating his wound)* “Sorry for hurting you and losing control.”

King Benson: *(Admiring her face and lips)* “That was hot. Whenever you lose control—in bed or with a sword... So how are you planning to pay me for the wound and for not trusting me?”

Queen Rosanna: “What does my King desire?!”

King Benson: “Since that night, I have not touched you for two days as the doctor asked. I am craving you. Sit on top again.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Looks at her womb, smiles, and looks at her husband)* “You are bleeding and still thinking of pleasure?!”

King Benson: “Ahahahah.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Pushes him onto the bed, lifts her clothes)* “My child needs to eat too.” King Benson: *(Pulls her close)* “Yess, ah! More. Yes, more.”

Queen Rosanna: “Gentle, okay?! Go easy on my stomach.” King Benson: “I will spend the night here.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Locked inside her palace)* “Benson! Benson! You cannot do this to me, I am carrying your child! Let me out! Let me out! Let me out!” *(Crying)* Personal Maid: “Your Highness, it is not good for you to yell and scream. You are putting the baby at risk. Remember, our entire future depends on this baby.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*Slaps the maid*) “Don't you think I know that?! All of this is because of that seductress! If she wasn't here, and if I had burned her along with her village, none of this would've happened. This is all that died Tiju's fault; she deserved to die along with that Weka. But I will not repeat their mistakes. I still have Yuri's letter and the token that controls the army. With this baby, I can get rid of Benson and Rosanna, then rule this empire all alone! Hahahaha. Once things stabilize, we will take over the palace.”

Prime Minister's Wife: (*At the prime minister's mansion*) “Every day his condition is getting worse, and all these doctors are not helping.”

Princess: “Mother, doesn't the palace have the best doctors?!” Prime Minister's Wife: “I don't think the king will allow it!”

Princess: “Why not? Our family has been loyal and serving the crown for generations. Sparing one imperial doctor is not a lot to ask!”

Prime Minister's Wife: “If the king cared at all, he would have sent a doctor back to the mansion with your dad. It has been days, and we have heard nothing from the king. Our property got confiscated and our titles revoked. The king is trying to corner us.” Princess: “That will never happen. I will personally go to the palace and request an imperial doctor from our aunt.”

Prime Minister's Wife: “There is a rumor going around that your aunt left the palace for prayer; that is why the king got the courage to attack our family.” Princess: “That makes no sense! Our aunt is the Grand Imperial Queen Yuri; she would never leave the palace and watch our family collapse!”

Prime Minister's Wife: “You might be right. Maybe something happened to her, or maybe the king locked her down too. It wouldn't be shocking, considering even the prime minister was brutally punished by him.”

Princess: “Mother, we can't sit here and watch our family die. I am not going to sit around waiting for my death. We have to do something! Guards, take all these useless doctors and execute them at once! Maids, prepare my robes; I am going to the palace to see my auntie!”

Doctors: “Show mercy, it is not our fault! The prime minister's health cannot recover! Life and death are in God's hands... We are just vessels to serve His purpose. We are merely human, Your Highness!”

Princess: (*Turns to them*) “As the princess of this empire, I order you to turn into God and save my father!”

Doctors: (*Look at each other*) “Your Highness! That...” Princess: (*Angry*) “Then you are completely useless! You don't even deserve those arms of yours. You are simply here to save my father, and if you can't fulfill that purpose, you are better off dead!” Doctors: “Your Highness, show mercy!”

Princess: “Since the matter of life and death depends on God, I will be God and decide on yours.” (*Takes a sword and walks toward the doctors*) “Then die!” Imperial Guards and Eunuch:

(Breaking into the mansion and announcing) “Queen Rosanna is here! Show respect to Queen Rosanna!”

Princess: *(Turns toward the gate)* “What?!”

Everyone: *(Bows down—except the princess and the prime minister's wife)* “Respect to Queen Rosanna, long life! Long life!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Entering the mansion with giggles)* “Rise!”

King’s Eunuch: *(Reading the decree)* “Everyone, bow down to hear the king’s decree!”

Everyone: *(Bows down)*

King’s Eunuch: “Tiju and Weka are dead, punished for all the evil they have done. They are hereby demoted to common citizens and will be buried outside of the imperial tombs.

Furthermore, for failing to properly educate the children of the imperial family, allowing them to create chaos in the harem, and harming the king, queen, and land, Grand Imperial Queen Yuri is also demoted to a common citizen. She will be exiled to the cold palace and never return. Finally, for disrespecting the king multiple times in the court and in public, the prime minister is demoted to a common citizen. All the prime minister's property will be confiscated, and this mansion will be placed under the queen's control. Have you received the decree?!” Princess: “I refuse the decree!”

King’s Eunuch: “Refusing the king's decree is equivalent to rebellion.”

Queen Rosanna: “Which is punishable by death unto the nine generations!” Princess: “This is the imperial family, the prime minister’s residence! Even the king feared the name of our royal family. How dare a slave woman tell us what to do?!”

Queen Rosanna: “And who is that slave girl?!” Imperial Guards: *(Draw their swords)* Prime Minister’s Soldiers: *(Draw their swords in defense)* Queen Rosanna: “Is this a rebellion?!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: *(Holds her daughter and forces her to bow down)* “We accept the king’s decree!” Princess: “Mother?!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: *(Looks at her daughter and whispers)* “Be quiet. You will get us killed.” *(To the queen)* “Your Majesty, forgive my daughter. She is young and spoiled. Please do not take offense!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles out loud)* “Why would I get offended by people without titles? All doctors are dismissed. Guards, escort them to their homes safely; they are under the protection of the crown.”

Princess: “They are treating my father! My father is in critical condition.” Queen Rosanna: “Doctor! How is the minister?!”

Doctors: *(Looking at their savior, replying to her)* “Your Majesty, he is half-dead. We need a miracle!” Queen Rosanna: “I guess the imperial guards beat him too hard!”

Princess: “You know how old he is! Beating him like that is the same as sentencing him to death!”

Queen Rosanna: “Sadly, he survived!”

Princess: “You dare! I am the princess of this empire. My dad is the prime minister, my aunt is the Grand Imperial Queen, and my uncle was the past king. Our imperial family tree is immovable!”

Queen Rosanna: “So what?! All titles are given by the king and can be stripped by the king. Whoever the king favors is the one who is honored.” (*Moves close to the princess*) “Whoever displeases the king is buried.”

Princess: “Without our imperial family, the king is the child of an adulterous concubine and will never be crowned! He should be bowing down to show respect to our imperial family.”

King’s Eunuch: “You dare?! Disrespecting the king is punishable by death, and insulting the new Grand Imperial Queen, the king's mother, is treason!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: “The king's mother has been promoted to Grand Imperial Queen?! Is the king intentionally targeting the imperial family?!”

Princess: “He would never dare!”

Queen Rosanna: “You dare look down on the king, my husband?! As the queen of the empire, Their Majesties' legal and only wife, and the mother of the empire—if I say beat, they beat! For disrespecting the crown, the princess is demoted to a common citizen and sentenced to be flogged forty-five times!”

Princess: “You dare!”

Queen Rosanna: “Watch me! Guards, seize her and flog her forty-five times.” Imperial Guards: (*Dragging the princess across the floor and flogging her forty-five times*) “Yes, my Queen!”

Princess: (*Standing up and shoving Rosanna*) “Go die!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Falls, starts bleeding*) “Ah... It hurts! Save me!” (*Holds her maid*) “Save my child...!”

King Benson: (*Witnessing Rosanna falling, yelling*) “*Mpenzi wangu!*” (*Runs and holds Rosanna*) “What is wrong?!” (*Yelling*) “What happened here?! Oh my God, you are bleeding... So much blood?! Doctors, check my wife immediately!” (*Carries her away*) Queen Rosanna: (*Barely awake as she is being carried by the king*) “*Mume wangu*, our child. Save my baby—” (*Crying and fainting*) “Our child...”

King Benson: (*In shock*) “You are pregnant?! Rosanna! Doctor, hurry! If anything happens to my wife and child, you will all die!” (*Placing Rosanna on the couch*) Doctors: “Put her down here; we will try to stop the bleeding first. Please, My King, go outside!”

King Benson: “No, I will stay beside her. If you can save my wife, you will be set for life.”

Doctor: “Do not worry, My King, it may look severe, but the queen and the baby will survive!”

King Benson: “Really?!”

Doctor: “Indeed, My King. God is on her side. Now the bleeding has stopped, and the pregnancy is stabilized. She just needs rest, and she will recover safely.”

King Benson: “Thank you, our Creator, God of Abraham! Wait... she is pregnant. I am going to be a father!”

Doctor: “Yes, My King! We believe it is going to be twins.”

King Benson: *(Standing up in pure excitement)* “Really?! Wow, hahahaha... Amen! I am going to be a father! Everyone gets a reward! Twins!”

Narrator: While Queen Rosanna is asleep, she has a prophetic dream. Queen Rosanna: *(Dreaming, waking up in an unknown place)* “Hello? Is anyone here? Who is here? Am I not supposed to be at the prime minister's mansion? Huh... Mother? That is my mother-in-law! Mother, I am here!” *(With excitement, running to hug her, but she goes right through because she is invisible)* “Huh? What? What's going on? Wait... This is my village! This is the slave village. How did I get here? Wait... Nobody can see me?! What? Am I invisible? Wait, that is me! That is the young me—” *(Looks at her younger self and smiles)*

Young Rosanna: “Daddy! I want that sweet candy!”

Tarma: *(Rosanna's father)* “I already bought you a bag full of candies!”

Young Rosanna: *(Puffy face)* “But I want that one too!”

Here is the revised and polished version of your story with corrected grammar, improved flow, and enhanced readability, while keeping every bit of your original dialogue, characters, and plot points intact.

Queen Rosanna: *(Laughing out loud)* “Ahahahaha.”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Worried)* “What's wrong?!”

Queen Rosanna: “I just realized that you are very funny! Ahahah.” *(Starts crying again)*

King Benson: *(Worried)* “My wife, what's wrong?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying out loud)* “I just want a muffin!”

King Benson: “Stop crying, okay? I will get you a muffin! Maids, bring muffins!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Puffy face)* “No! I want the one Mother made at the temple!” *(Crying again)*

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Worried and smiling)* “Do not be sad, okay? Stop crying, you are now pregnant. I have muffins—banana muffins, your favorite—and I have a lot of pretty robes for you. Come to my quarters and have some dessert.”

King Benson: *(Puffy face)* “Mother, stop stealing my wife... I also want a turn.” *(Hugging his wife)* “Mother, I want to do the saving next time!”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Smiling and hugging them)* “Then be faster!”

King Benson: *(Pouting with a puffy face)*

Narrator: After Queen Rosanna wakes up, they all move outside. The princess is kneeling on the ground alongside the prime minister's wife and all the prime minister's maids.

King Benson: *(Taking a seat, his voice dangerously low)* “Hmmm, you know harming the imperial heir carries a sentence of death, correct?”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Sitting down as well)* “Hurting the imperial queen is a sentence of death, too!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: *(Bowing down)* “Show mercy! We had no idea that the queen was pregnant!”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Furious)* “And you think it would be fine to push my daughter if she weren't pregnant?!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: “I didn't mean it like that...”

King Benson: *(Interrupting angrily)* “Then what do you exactly mean? If I hadn't arrived on time, you would have murdered my wife! You dare to touch my queen!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: “Please show mercy, Your Imperial Highness! From childhood, she has been spoiled and favored. Her carelessness is entirely my fault. As parents, we completely failed to educate her! So please, Your Majesty, spare her!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “And you truly believe the crime of attempting to murder the imperial heir can be excused by a lack of education?!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: “Show mercy! My husband is already half-dead, our titles have been taken away, and our wealth has been confiscated by the king. I am left with nothing but my daughter. Please, Your Imperial Highness, show us mercy!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Walking in and taking a seat)* “I almost lost my child?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Looking gently at Rosanna)* “Take a seat, my dear. Do not stand up for too long; you are carrying our future.” *(Turning a harsh gaze back at the princess)* “Perhaps, if you apologized to the queen, she might forgive you!”

Princess: *(Looking up)* “I am pureblood, born from the main branch of the imperial family. Why should I kneel to a slave?!”

King’s Eunuch: *(Stepping forward and slapping the princess)* “You dare disrespect our queen?!”

Princess: *(Rubbing her cheek furiously)* “I come from a lineage of kings, queens, and Grand Imperial Queens! Why should I ever bow down to a slave?”

Queen Rosanna: *(Smiles coldly)* “I was planning to forgive you... but you are utterly unrepentant.”

King Benson: *(Voice echoing with absolute authority)* “Since you look down on slaves so deeply, then you shall become one. Here is the imperial decree: for the crime of harming the queen and the imperial heir, the prime minister's daughter is hereby demoted to a war slave. She will labor on the imperial country farm under the strict surveillance of the king's eunuch! From this moment on, your noble status is stripped away.”

Princess: “I refuse! Guards, seize them!”

Prime Minister’s Guards: *(Raising their weapons toward the king, queen, and Grand Imperial Queen)* “Waiting for your command, Your Highness!”

Prime Minister’s Wife: *(Standing up and wiping away her tears)* “I am done playing around. None of you will leave this mansion alive. Ahahaha!”

Princess: *(Giggling as the guards surround the king, queen, and Grand Imperial Queen)* “Since you decided to be ruthless, we will show no mercy to this mansion. We will take everything back, including the crown.”

King Benson: *(Smiles coldly)* “Is this a rebellion?!”

Princess: “This mansion will be your tomb. Ahahahaha!”

King Benson: "Did you truly think I would bring my mother and wife without security?! I knew long ago that you intended to rebel, but I didn't know when or how, so I decided to hasten your plans by cornering you. Imperial Guards, reveal yourselves!"

Imperial Guards: *(Bursting through the gates and surrounding the rebels)* "Your Majesty!"

Princess: "What?! How?!"

Prime Minister's Wife: *(In shock, whispering)* "It is over!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggling)* "And I was merely using myself as bait!"

King Benson: *(Pouting with a puffy face)* "I didn't want you to use yourself as bait; I didn't agree to that plan! If I knew you were pregnant and things would get this dangerous, I would never have allowed you to be in harm's way!"

Princess: *(Laughing out loud)* "Well, so what?! Because today, this entire empire will fall!"

King Benson: "You're still not giving up?!"

Prime Minister's Wife: "My husband already escaped the mansion, ahahaha! He is already meeting with the commander; together, they will be taking over the palace."

Queen Rosanna: *(In shock)* "What?"

Princess: "When King Benson decided to promote Rika to Imperial Noble Consort Rika and lock her in her palace until she gave birth, Rika managed to send her maid outside the palace. The maid delivered a letter to my father. My father immediately recalled the commander to the capital to attack and seize the throne. I never expected that Their Royal Highnesses would visit us today and leave the palace unguarded."

King Benson: *(Stands up abruptly)* "What?!"

Queen Rosanna: "We have to go back to the palace immediately!"

Imperial Grand Queen: "My daughter, you are pregnant! We cannot allow you to put yourself in danger again!"

King Benson: "My dear wife, you must stay here under the protection of the imperial guards and my mother. I will ride back to the palace to defend it. The palace cannot fall!"

Queen Rosanna: "Absolutely not! What if something happens to you... our children aren't even born yet! I will not let you go by yourself or face this danger alone. I refuse!"

King Benson: "I have faith in your God. He brought us together, and He blessed us with beautiful twins. This is just the beginning of our story; it will not end like this."

Queen Rosanna: "But!"

King Benson: *(Interrupting her gently)* "If you stay here, I will have peace of mind and be able to fight freely... I won't worry about your safety. Stay here and wait for me..." *(He kisses her deeply)* "I will make it safe for you and our children!" *(With a heavy heart, he gently knocks Rosanna unconscious, carries her carefully into the inner chamber, and lays her down safely. Turning to his mother)* "Mother, stay safe. These guards are my trusted men; I trained them myself. They will keep both of you secure. When she wakes up... do not let her leave this mansion under any circumstances, and do not let anyone inside except for me."

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Nodding as tears stream down her face)* "Make sure you come back to us safely."

King Benson: *(Smiling, trying to ease her worry)* "Definitely, we planned for this. We've got this... I will be back!" *(He takes one last look at his sleeping wife and smiles, then departs)* "Let's go, imperial guards. We will fight to defend our empire and return alive to our loved ones."

Imperial Guards: "Yes, Your Majesty!"

Narrator: The king leaves the prime minister's mansion and rushes back to the palace to plan his defense against the prime minister and the commander of the army. Five hours later, the prime minister and the commander surround the palace, break through the gates, and force their way inside. The palace grounds are plunged into chaos, filled with panicked maids and eunuchs running in every direction.

Prime Minister: *(Laughing wickedly as he enters the palace)* “Ahahaha! Now, I am going to take back everything that rightfully belongs to me!” *(He and his soldiers charge deeper into the palace grounds)*

Imperial Commander: *(Son of Yuri and father of the deceased Tiju, whispering to himself)* “My daughter, I will have vengeance for you today. Mother, I am here to save you.” *(Turning to his troops)* “Take all the residents of the palace and gather them at the center of the palace, outside the meeting courtroom!” *(He charges forward on his horse alongside his army)*

Army: “Yes, Commander!”

Narrator: They go into every quarter, only finding maids and eunuchs. They gather all the maids and eunuchs outside the king's throne room.

Army: *(Reporting to the prime minister)* “Prime Minister, we have searched all over the palace. We only found maids and eunuchs. After questioning them, we discovered that the queen and the Grand Imperial Queen are at the prime minister's mansion, and the king is in his throne room!”

Prime Minister: *(Laughing out loud)* “Ahahaha! I knew he wasn't fit to be king, leaving the palace completely unguarded. I will repay him for every single frog he gave me and turn him into a slave, ahahaha! Gather the entire army; let us march to the courtroom. We are taking over, ahahaha! Surround the courtroom, leave those useless maids and eunuchs behind, and let's go to the main quarters!”

Army: “Lead the way, Your Highness!”

Commander: *(Thinking to himself)* “Something does not look right! Something feels completely off!”

Prime Minister: “Commander, why are you standing there? Let's go attack the king!”

Commander: *(Riding his horse quickly toward the prime minister)* “What if it is a trap? What if the king has a trap for us in the courtroom?!”

Prime Minister: *(Blinded by pride)* “There is not a single soldier here! Even if it is a trap... we outnumber the king's soldiers heavily. We will succeed!”

Commander: “Hmm... I trust you. Soldiers, charge straight to the wall and straight to the courtroom at the center of the palace!”

Soldiers: “Yes, sir!”

Commander: *(Whispering in his heart)* “It is too strange for the palace to be unguarded... Maybe I am overthinking. This king is as foolish as the prime minister said.”

Maids: *(Whispering to one another, looking at the prime minister)* “Idiot!”

Eunuchs: *(Smiling quietly to themselves)*

Narrator: They arrive at the courtroom, but to their utter astonishment, they find the king sitting outside with his throne, gathering and sorting through his clothes.

Prime Minister: *(Laughing mockingly as he dismounts his horse)* “You foolish king! Today the Lord has delivered you into my hands.”

King Benson: *(Lifting his eyes calmly)* “Oh, it's you again! I am currently trying to choose which clothes or style I should wear today. In your opinion, which one looks best?!”

Prime Minister: “Today is your funeral! I will be taking over the palace... your reign is officially over!”

King Benson: (*Thoughtfully*) “Says who?!”

Imperial Commander: (*Riding up on his horse*) “Good to see you, brat. I am here to take revenge for my daughter whom you killed! As for your wife, I will turn her into a slave girl—or perhaps I will have some fun with her before I end her life!”

King Benson: (*Eyes flashing with absolute fury*) “Returning to the capital without an imperial decree is treason. You and your family will be executed for this!”

Commander: “And how exactly are you planning to do that?! You will die today. My soldiers have surrounded the palace and your courtroom. You have no escape; this is the end.”

King Benson: (*Closing his book firmly*) “I’m so tired of hearing this from everyone I meet. You are the one who is surrounded, not me!”

Prime Minister: (*Laughing hysterically*) “Delusional! There is not a single guard or soldier here. I guess you took them all to my mansion, ahahahaha.”

King Benson: “Who told you that guards can’t wear maid clothes or eunuch clothes?”

(*Immediately, all the nearby eunuchs and maids tear off their robes, revealing gleaming armor and hidden weapons underneath. Simultaneously, the entire army and the commander lower their blades—not against the king, but against the prime minister—revealing themselves to be the king’s spies.*)

King Benson: “I spent years sending my own loyal people to the border to infiltrate the military, systematically removing every soldier loyal to you in secret. Every single soldier you brought to the capital today answers only to me. All the maids and eunuchs are imperial guards trained by me. Ahahaha!”

Army: (*Turning their swords directly toward the prime minister and commander*) “You will pay for all the evil you have done!”

King Benson: “Every one of these soldiers is someone from whom you stole a loved one, a daughter, and a home. Today, they finally get their justice.”

Prime Minister: (*Panicking*) “Impossible! All these people work for the imperial family; they would never betray us. Impossible!”

Commander: “What are you doing?! I order you to attack the king! You’re supposed to fight the king!”

Army Leader: “You killed our women, destroyed our homes, and held our families hostage. Today, you face your judgment!”

Prime Minister: (*Losing his mind, stumbling backward*) “No! No! Why am I the king?! I am the king! No way! This can’t be happening!”

Army Leader: “Attack them immediately! Cut them into pieces until there is nothing left!”

(*Striking a blow*) “This is for my sister!” (*Striking again*) “This is for my wife!” (*Striking a final blow*) “And this is for the village!”

Prime Minister: (*With his last remaining breath, bleeding heavily*) “You son of a concubine, I will not let you off easily. The imperial family will never let you off. You dare scheme against me?!”

King Benson: (*Smiles calmly*) “Is that truly the last thing you’ll say before you die?!”

Commander: (*Giggling weakly as he bleeds out*) “I can’t believe I fell for such a cheap trick!” (*Coughing up blood*) “How long did you plan for this?!”

King Benson: (*His smile widening*) “The moment I escaped to the slave village... that was when I made up my mind. I resolved to become king and wipe you all out completely.”

Prime Minister: (*Gasping and bleeding*) “I told my sister to finish you off back then, but she didn’t listen to me. What did you do to my sister?!”

King Benson: “Oh, the ex-Grand Imperial Queen Yuri? I demoted her and exiled her to the cold palace!”

Prime Minister: “How can you be so ungrateful?! She took you in and made you king; she treated you with nothing but kindness!”

King Benson: (*Voice dropping to a cold, razor-sharp edge*) “What exactly do you mean by ‘kind’? She refused to send me to school, she let me kneel all night in the cold, she locked me in a dark storage room without food for days, and she allowed her sons to use me as a horse while her maids and sons whipped me. Is that what you call kindness?!”

Prime Minister: (*Gasping, horrified*) “So... your entire display of devotion toward her was an act?!”

King Benson: “I did what I had to do. I am going to be a father now, so I need to make my land safe for my wife and children.”

Prime Minister: “Are you planning to completely wipe out the imperial family?!”

King Benson: “No. But if anyone harms or schemes against my family—imperial or not—I show no mercy!”

Prime Minister: (*With a final sigh*) “It seems... I was the fool.” (*He draws his last breath and dies*)

Imperial Commander: “My daughter Tiju, I am sorry. I failed you. I always wanted to be a righteous commander like our ancestors, but I let myself get tangled up in power and wealth. Forgive me, my dear.” (*He collapses and dies*)

King Benson: (*Turning to his loyal soldiers*) “Gather the remains of their bodies and seal them in boxes. Have them moved to the prime minister's mansion—it's time to bring back my family.” (*He looks toward the horizon, whispering*) “My dear sister... just as I promised, have I taken vengeance for you? Every single person that ever hurt you is paying for what they did. Rest in peace.”

Narrator: The soldiers pick up the body parts and box them up. The maids and eunuchs clean the palace, washing away all the blood and repainting the entire palace walls. After the sun goes down, the king takes a shower and decides to return to the prime minister's mansion to retrieve his family.

Imperial Grand Queen: (*At the prime minister's mansion*) “Rosanna will wake up soon. I do not know how long it is going to take until he returns.”

Imperial Guards: “Your Highness, we checked the mansion. We found a chamber full of weapons, and we found prisoners—and this was after all of the other ministers were dead!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Looking at the imperial guards*) “What?! How did our ministers end up here?!”

Ministers: “The princess and the prime minister's wife were in prison! We were planning to report the rebellion, but they imprisoned us and killed half of the ministers to scare the rest of us off!”

Princess: (*Ex-princess*) “Liar! You clearly agreed to follow me to destroy the palace!”

Ministers: “We would never! We are loyal to the crown, Your Highness. Trust us, we work for the interests of the empire. The prime minister kidnapped our families and us to force us into rebellion.”

Minister of Revenue: “Yes, Your Highness! It is true; do not listen to that delusional girl!”

Princess: “If Your Majesty checks the mansion, you will see the records I kept safely, showing how these ministers collaborated to cause chaos! Everything is recorded and put away safely, just in case one day they try to expose us.”

Minister of Education: “You clearly told us to destroy all the proof and links! You told us there would be no proof left to trace us!”

Minister of Finance: “If Your Majesty spares me and my family, I will give you all the proof of the embezzlement the imperial family committed... all the proof we have will be yours, Your Highness!”

Ministers: “Yes, we will, Your Highness! And we will be loyal to the crown!”

Princess: “A dog biting the hand that feeds it?!”

Ministers: “You are the one who betrayed us first by locking us in prison, even when we agreed to go along with the rebellion! Either way, we had no future; we should choose the winner and survive!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Turns around and calls the prime minister's maid*) “Enough! Maid, your house will undergo a deep investigation, your mansions will be confiscated, and your property will be placed under the crown—including all the proof that will be found. Once my son gets here, we will decide what to do with you. Today, we must clean our empire's foundation!”

Maid: “Your Majesty, I am the king's person. I work as a spy in the prime minister's mansion.”

Princess: (*Being held down by imperial guards*) “What?! Tweiiji?! How?! I treated you so kindly! Why would you betray me?!”

Maid Tweiiji: (*Replying to the princess*) “How dare a slave question an imperial maid?! And to answer your question, my sister used to work in this mansion. My sister was eleven years old when she got hired as a doctor's assistant for this mansion; her contract was supposed to dissolve when she turned twenty. My sister won your favor when she was sixteen, working under you as a doctor. You knew her contract would dissolve when she turned twenty, but you killed her when she turned eighteen because you were scared she would expose your evil deeds! All our family received was her body cut into pieces and her face disfigured! I will never forgive you for what you did to my sister. Luckily, when King Benson was recruiting new loyal maids, he chose me. At ten years old, I decided to enter your mansion as a personal maid.”

Princess: (*Laughing*) “You did all that just for revenge?! Ahaha, I don't even know which one was your sister!”

Maid Tweiiji: (*Undoes her ponytail, letting her hair fall over her shoulders*) “Do you remember now?!”

Princess: (*Looks carefully*) “Tweiwei?! Are you still alive?!”

Maid Tweiiji: (*Covers the ex-princess's mouth*) “Shut up! You don't deserve to say my sister's name! You are not worthy!”

Princess: (*Shocked*) “How did you survive? I clearly saw your body in pieces! Impossible... you are a ghost!”

Maid Tweiiji: (*Crying*) “The one you killed was Tweiiji! You killed my younger twin! The king had to dirty his hands to bring me to this mansion; we had to make up a story and replace one of the hired maids.”

Princess: (*Confused*) “What? No way, you never told me that you had a twin sister! You only told me that you had a younger sister. I clearly saw you being beaten to death and cut apart! It's impossible!”

Maid Tweiiji: “It is true; I am the maid Tweiwei whom you hired. On my eighteenth birthday, my twin sister Tweiiji came to visit me to celebrate. I only had two years left until I gained back my freedom and finally left this place. She came to the mansion to celebrate my birthday; we were in my chamber when the head maid called me to the kitchen. I left to go help in the kitchen, and I explicitly told her to stay in my room and wait for me. But Tweiiji was always stubborn and

adventurous; after I left, she put her hair down and wore my maid uniform. While exploring the mansion, she caught you having an affair with the doctor. You called a eunuch to dishonor her body, and you whipped her, beat her to death, and cut her apart! When I finished helping the head maid, I returned to my room—she was gone, and I only found her clothes. I ran out to look for her, but when I got there, I only found her body in a box! I asked around, and the eunuch told me everything. So I decided to take my sister's identity—Tweiji—and leave with the box and my money. Our parents died when we were young; I am the oldest, and I worked tirelessly to give her a better future and help pay for her school. She was the future bride of the minister of treason's son. When I turned twenty, that would have been when she got married; I was saving for her dowry. I turned twenty this year—this year should have been her wedding, but she died in my place! I went back to the minister of treason's son pretending to be Tweiji. I told him Tweiji was dead and asked him to enlist me in the palace. That was when I met the king and got sent here to be a spy.”

Princess: (*Laughing like a crazy woman*) “The doctor was right, I should have destroyed the entire family. It is too late, and she is already dead!”

Maid Tweiji: “But you still have to kneel to my twin sister Tweiji and apologize—to all the maids you killed and all the people you wronged. Today, you are facing divine retribution!”

Princess: “I will never!”

Maid Tweiji: (*Slaps the princess*) “That is for my sister!”

Princess: (*Shocked*) “You dare?!”

Maid Tweiji: (*Slaps her again*) “Yes, I slap you over and over!”

Princess: (*Clinging to her past status*) “I am the princess! The daughter of the prime minister, and my hand was the past king's wife! You dare touch me?” (*She physically attacks Maid Tweiwei*) “You are going to pay!”

Imperial Guards: (*Hold her down*) “Bow down!”

Prime Minister's Wife: “Do not touch my daughter! Let her go! Let her go! Grand Imperial Queen, I will pay the price for all the wrongs of this mansion! Please let my daughter go! Please, I beg you! I will pay with my life! Please spare my daughter's life!”

Princess: “Mother, do not beg them. I am not scared! Let them come at me; I am not wrong! I am the princess of this empire! If I kill, I kill; if I punish, I punish, so what?! You should have watched her when the eunuch tore off her clothes and forced her, ahahaha! I stood there watching and laughing—it was so entertaining! The doctor had fun with her, too! Even if you kill me, what will that do, ahahaha? She is dead! Dead!”

Maid Tweiwei: “You are absolutely crazy! Absolutely crazy!”

Princess: “That is all you lowly people deserve! Kneeling and paying respect... So what? It is a dear blessing, ahahaha!”

Imperial Guard: “The imperial family exists to protect people, keep the weak strong, and keep the government in check—to help and support the king and queen. Noblesse oblige. But you used your power to abuse the weak and take advantage of the empire! You are not worthy of being a noble or a princess of this empire. Even the title of slave is too good for you, because slaves are human and you are not!”

Princess: “You dare look down on me, too?! I am telling you, I will never fall! This mansion will never fall!”

Prime Minister's Wife: (*Slaps her daughter*) “Enough! Don't you see our situation?!”

Princess: (*Shocked*) “Mother, even you?! You turn against me?! You are the one who taught me all this! Why are you treating me like this?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Entering and clapping her hands)* “Well, well! I never expected that I would wake up to such a show—every bit of it is beautiful!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “My daughter, you are awake!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Runs into the arms of her mother-in-law)* “Did the king go to the palace alone to deal with the rebels?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “I trust my son, but above all, I trust God. He will definitely return my son to me! Relax, you are now pregnant; everything is going to be good. We planned everything.”

Imperial Guard: “King Benson is here! Show respect to King Benson!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Runs and hugs her husband, crying)* “You are here! You are not wounded... Are you okay?!”

King Benson: *(Hugs his wife and smiles)* “Pantalones, I told you I would be fine. When you are safe, I am safe. Are you angry at me for knocking you out?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Puffy face, walking toward her mother-in-law and hugging her)* “Yes! Now I see you, and now I am angry at you! I do not like when you leave me behind; I want to stand hand in hand with you! It is not fair!”

King Benson: *(Following closely behind her)* “My baby, I didn't want you to follow me or sneak into the palace when I was facing the rebels. I just wanted you to be safe... Don't be upset with me, my love... I need your kisses... Kiss me now, okay?! You are pregnant; being angry is not good for the baby! Mother, I need my wife back...!”

Imperial Guard: *(Takes the box, opens it in front of them, and reveals the prime minister and the commander cut into pieces inside)* “Here is your husband!”

Prime Minister's Wife: *(Screaming out loud)* “Ah! Husband! Nooo! What did they do to you?! Nooo! I will kill them! Nooo!”

Imperial Guards: *(Whispering to themselves)* “Even people who hurt others have people they love. How can they hurt other people's loved ones and not expect their own loved ones to be hurt? In the end, no matter how powerful they are, they die like any human. Life is unforgiving.”

Princess: “No! Father! No! My father! Nooo! It is over! Nooo! It is impossible!” *(Starts screaming and going crazy, directly attacking King Benson)* “You die!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Moves fast to intercept the attack)* “My husband!”

King Benson: *(Turns around very fast, kicks the princess, and holds his wife)* “Queen of my heart! Are you okay?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Fainting)* “My King!”

King Benson: *(Furious, draws his sword and stabs the princess, then walks over to the prime minister's wife and stabs her as well, before carrying his wife back to the carriage)* “Guards, clean up this mess! Show no mercy to those who target my family! Execute those corrupt ministers along with everyone who works for the prime minister. Mother, let's go home.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Yes, My King. But my daughter is staying in my quarters.”

King Benson: *(Puffy face, getting into the carriage)* “No, Mom! You spent all day with my wife; now it is my turn.”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Inside the carriage)* “She is pregnant—she is carrying our twins! She will be safer with me, and I have a bigger room, too.”

King Benson: *(Whispering in his heart)* “I will just kidnap my wife.” *(Carrying his wife)* “I have the biggest quarters, and I will ask the servants to change the style to make it comfortable for my wife and the kids!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “No need! I already made everything for her, so you do not need to do unnecessary spending!”

King Benson: (*Puffy face*) “So, she told you that she is pregnant, and you didn’t bother to tell me?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “No, she did not! Prophet Kafura visited my quarters and told me. I was so happy and started preparing everything in advance.”

King Benson: “The prophet visited the palace?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “He visited me, not the palace!”

King Benson: (*Suddenly the carriage stops; they have arrived at the palace. King Benson holds his wife and runs straight out of the carriage*) “MINE!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Shocked and confused*) “What? Wait!” (*Giggles*) “So cute! I never imagined that he would be attached to anyone else or find anything that truly interests him. Rosanna is truly our blessing; I cannot wait for my grandchildren.”

Narrator: King Benson rushes into his quarters carrying his wife and gently lays her on his bed to rest. A few minutes later, Queen Rosanna begins to wake up.

King Benson: (*Sitting beside his wife, whispering*) “You better wake up soon, or I am going to start kissing you! Maids! Call the imperial doctor!”

Maids: “Yes, Your Highness!”

King’s Eunuch: “The imperial doctor is married!”

Imperial Doctor: (*Bowing down*) “My greetings, Your Highness!”

King Benson: “Rise, and check my wife and child! How are they doing?”

Imperial Doctor: (*Examining Rosanna*) “Hmmm, I see... the queen is pregnant with twins—a girl and a boy. However, I believe she suffered a double shock, which left the pregnancy unstable. I will prescribe a medicine blend to stabilize the babies, and I absolutely recommend bed rest for a couple of days. Let her drink the medicine three times a day: in the morning, in the evening, and right before she sleeps. I will personally return to check on the babies and mother, Your Majesty!”

King Benson: “You shall be rewarded! Give me the medicine and prescription; I will personally administer her medicine!”

Imperial Doctor: “Thank you, Your Majesty! I will go to my chambers now and gather the necessary herbs to send back to the palace!”

King Benson: “Also, send one of your nurses to attend to my wife, just in case there is an emergency!”

Imperial Doctor: “Yes, Your Highness!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Waking up, yelling*) “My King!”

King Benson: (*Holding his wife*) “I am fine! Calm down, I am fine!”

Queen Rosanna: (*With worried eyes*) “Are you okay? Are you hurt?”

King Benson: (*Calming his wife down*) “I am perfectly alright. You have to stop scaring me like this! Stop fainting, or all my hair is going to turn grey from worrying about you and our twins!”

Queen Rosanna: “We are having twins?”

King Benson: “Yes! A boy and a girl. By the way, why didn’t you tell me that you were pregnant? You know I would have never put you in danger!”

Queen Rosanna: “Yes, I know you would never! Do you remember the night you were drugged with a pleasure drug?”

King Benson: (*Giggles*) “Yes! I went to visit Imperial Noble Consort Rika; she drugged the wine. I brought her alcohol, which was also drugged—I drank her wine, and she drank mine, but

her wine showed early symptoms, so she got hot quickly before I could lose control of myself. I ran straight to your chambers, and we made passionate love all night to cure me of the effects of the drug.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shyly*) “Yes... After that night, I became pregnant. I wanted to tell you, but then Rika came and claimed she was carrying your child—though it wasn’t yours, because after she drank the wine, you gave her to your imperial guard! And then we had to fight the rebellion, so I did not want to worry you. I was planning to tell you once we finished cleaning our empire from corruption!”

King Benson: “It was so cute to see you angry—you almost killed Rika and ruined our plan! At the end of the day, her child is innocent. We will take care of Rika, and I will call the imperial guard to tell him he is going to be a father! I will make it up to you and our children; we are going to be a happy family.”

Queen Rosanna: “I know, you will be a great father. But you know Rika... Are you sure she is truly pregnant?! What if she is tricking us again? What if this is her scheme, and she still believes that you are the father of her child?”

King Benson: (*Holding his wife*) “Whatever she brings, we will face it together; I will not be careless anymore! If she tries to harm you again, she will meet my sword!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Looking at her husband with loving eyes*) “I do not want any bloodshed. I want to protect you, too! Let me protect you, too!”

King Benson: “You are protecting us just by keeping our family safe and staying alive. Please, just deliver our child safely to me!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Smiles and hugs her husband*) “So you have to be there to raise them!”

King Benson: (*Hugs her back*) “Definitely!”

Queen Rosanna: “By the way, where is Mother?”

King Benson: “She is at her quarters! The doctor said you have to rest, so you stay here with me!”

Queen Rosanna: “Do you know how long?!”

King Benson: “Forever!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Giggles*) “Ahahahahaha, you just want to keep me here!”

King Benson: (*Pouting*) “Now it's my turn; I am not sharing! Now that you are carrying my child, I have to watch you carefully!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Kisses him*) “You are so cute!”

King Benson: (*Pouting playfully*) “Is that all you see me as?!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Thoughtfully*) “You are very handsome, too!”

King Benson: (*Proud face*) “And!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Looks at her husband carefully, straightening his back, head, and shoulders*) “You are powerful, too!”

King Benson: “More!”

Queen Rosanna: “You are a man. A man I can rely on, cry on, and depend on. You are my man, my husband. My soulmate, my strength, the man that God chose for me, my handsome husband and my king and lord, the love of my life and the father of my children!”

King Benson: “Forever!”

Queen Rosanna: “Forever and a day!”

King Benson: “You are my life, the breath I breathe every day, the strength that pushes me forward, my purpose, my family, my past, future, and present. The queen of my heart and all that is mine, including my kingdom. The most beautiful woman I have ever seen in my life, and I am

completely blinded by your love! Forever and a day... I pray that God keeps us together and we grow older and grey... that we watch our kids grow up and get married, and we hold our grandchildren!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Interrupting)* "And God shall fulfill it! It seems like, my daughter, you finally found your happiness!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Trying to stand up)* "Prophet Kafura!"

King Benson: *(Gently forcing her back to sit down on her bed)* "Good to see you, Prophet!"

Prophet Kafura: "Good to see you, My King! It is good to see you happy!"

King Benson: "Please, sit down with us! Indeed, my queen has brought joy to my soul; I will soon be a father!"

Prophet Kafura: "Indeed! Our empire is truly blessed. The queen will have a safe delivery!"

King Benson: "Amen!"

Maid: *(Bowing down)* "Greetings, Your Majesty, and greetings, Prophet Kafura!"

Prophet Kafura: "My greetings to you, too!"

King Benson: "Why this disturbance?!"

Maid: "The imperial doctor brought medicine and a nurse, Your Highness!"

King Benson: *(Leaving)* "Forgive me, Prophet, I will be right back!"

Queen Rosanna: "Don't take too long!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Smiling)* "*Binti mfalme*, what do you think of this life now?!"

Queen Rosanna: "I feel like I am dreaming!"

King Benson: *(Returns with medicine)* "Never say that! I don't want this to be a dream. I dreamed for too long; I don't want to dream anymore!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* "Okay, my dear husband!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Smiling)* "Right, My King. I have waited to see the prosperity of our blessed empire; now it is finally a reality. On some occasions, our God uses dreams to communicate with His beloved people. Whom the Lord has put together, no man or being can separate. Yet, in every vision or reality, man has a role to play—even though, at the same time, God can do all things Himself without man. So, take good care of each other. This is just the beginning; there are still more battles to fight, more victories to gain. In all, our Lord, God, and Savior will always be with us. He is the Prince of Peace, the Lion of Judah, and the Son of David. The Holy Spirit of the living God, along with His presence, will be with us on this journey!"

King Benson: *(Giving medicine to Rosanna)* "Amen to this. Does your presence bring good news or bad news? You know my wife is pregnant; the doctor said she needs rest and no more shocks!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Smiling)* "Peace be with you, My King. It all depends on your perspective!

Sometimes, the news God brings is to help you prevent something evil from happening. God is God, and all He gives and brings can only be good, but it all depends on your perspective!"

King Benson: *(Grumpy, forcing Rosanna to drink medicine)* "Then you bring bad news when my wife is pregnant!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Closing her mouth tight)* "No! No!"

King Benson: *(Holding her close)* "My queen, drink your medicine; you need to take medicine for you and the babies. Come on, open up! Open up your mouth!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Refusing)* "But I hate medicine; it is bitter... Nooo!"

King Benson: "Come on! Come on, drink! Drink, my baby, drink! I will get you some sweets if you drink. Open up, open up, say ahh!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Laughing)* “I guess some things never change... You still act as you did when you were little, running away from medicine, ahahaha!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Pouting)* “Since you are a powerful prophet, why don't you heal me now and make my pregnancy stable?!”

King Benson: *(Staring at the prophet with a bowl of medicine)* “Right, you can!”

Prophet Kafura: “God is not a magician, and He already gave you healing through medicine—drink it already! I brought some sugar with me. A sugar mine was found in the village; now the slave village is able to make sugar and sweets. Before, it was the imperial family that monopolized the production of sugar, but now the slave village of Hikmid can produce sugar, and anyone can afford it or buy it from the slave village. The nobles are angry because such a privilege only belonged to the noble families of the capital. Now they are attacking families who are producing sugar and causing the village to regress. The people are being afflicted; they said Rosanna *binti mfalme* has forgotten her people and lives in luxury while her kindred are suffering. And here is the sugar: simply mix it with the medicine and give it to the queen!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Shocked)* “Why does such good news never reach the palace? We had no idea that a sugar mine or cave was found in the slave village, or that the slave village was being oppressed by nobles because of the sugar! I never forgot my people and where I come from; I am still fighting for my own survival and my children. The king and I just stopped the rebellion and are working on stabilizing the empire—we have been busy, and also the matter of rebuilding the slave village belongs to my mother-in-law, so my husband and I were not informed. But send them good news: Rosanna, Queen of Boparl, will personally hold justice for them and return all their belongings! We will personally visit the slave village to check on the matter.”

King Benson: “After you drink your medicine and the pregnancy is stabilized, and if you serve me well... maybe we can both go!” *(Giggles, mixes sugar into the medicine, and hands it to his wife)*

Queen Rosanna: *(Drinks it)* “Delicious! So much better!”

Prophet Kafura: *(Smiling)* “Then I will return to the people of God to tell them the news... I will be watching you, my little Rosanna.” *(He disappears)*

King Benson: *(Smiling)* “He certainly knows how to put on a show.” *(Stands up)* “I will go investigate the situation of the slave village. Stay here and rest!”

Queen Rosanna: “We just finished the rebellion, and it is almost night... Why don't you rest? Tomorrow we will investigate it?!”

King Benson: “Since Prophet Kafura came here himself, it means the matter is urgent... the enemy is already alert; they might try to cover their tracks and destroy the proof. So I must attack now. Also, if I don't bring my queen an answer to this matter, you will be stressed out, and you will not sleep. So I must go!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Looks at her husband)* “Can you worry about yourself, too?! You are the king of this empire; your life and safety are the most important! Stay the night with me so I can sleep with peace of mind. Tomorrow we shall do this together—I hate when you leave me behind to go fight alone. We are a couple and partners; we should do this together as a couple!”

King Benson: *(Smiling, lying down beside his wife and cuddling with her)* “I shall do as my queen demands! Let's rest tonight!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Closing her eyes in her husband's arms)* “Let's rest!”

Narrator: Early in the morning, the king meets with his mom to talk about the situation in the slave village and start their investigation. But a fire is building in the palace, led by Imperial Noble Consort Rika.

Maid: "Imperial Noble Consort Rika! Bad news! The king has found out about the sugar mine in the slave village, the rebellion was a failure, and Queen Rosanna is pregnant!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*In her quarters*) "What?! How is that possible?! I clearly did everything privately... When my uncle attacked the palace, the rulers were here; how did it fail?!"

Maid: "The rulers went to the prime minister's mansion. The prime minister's wife and daughter were both executed, and all our people were arrested, including all the ministers. The king got back to the palace in time to stop your uncle's rebellion. Both the commander and the prime minister who were leading the rebellion in the palace were executed!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*In shock, falling to the ground*) "So... the entire imperial main branch family was executed?"

Maid: "Yes, Your Highness... the king executed them. But Yuri, the ex-Grand Imperial Queen, is still in the palace, and now the imperial family is receiving the news about the main branch being wiped out, the rebellion, and the deposed Grand Queen!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "Does the king know about my involvement?! Is he aware that we were behind it?!"

Personal Maid: (*Slaps the maid*) "How dare you bring such bad news knowing Your Highness is pregnant!" (*To Rika*) "Your Highness, no! If the king knew, he would execute us immediately. Since he hasn't, it means we are good, and I am relieved that every person who knew about the letters and the military seal—anyone we used who was aware of our matters—is dead! Nobody can betray us!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*Standing up*) "Good! Good! How did that slave woman get pregnant? She always finds a way to stand in my way. We need to get rid of that baby. Anyway, I am from the imperial family, and my child is royal; if it is a boy, he will be crown prince!"

Maid: "The queen is having twins...!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*Slaps the maid*) "What?! How did you guys monitor her?! Why is everything so easy for her?! Go tell the imperial family that the Imperial Noble Consort is pregnant with a son! Also, ask them to put pressure on the king to crown him crown prince and to talk me out of this lockdown. And go spread rumors around the empire: the queen is a seductress who forces the king to kill all his ministers, including the main branch of the imperial family. Let me see how her God is going to protect her from this, ahahaha!"

Maid: (*Smiling*) "But, Your Highness, we do not know if the child you are carrying is a boy!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*Slaps her*) "That is none of your business! I have my own plan, ahahahaha! I spent my entire life planning for this! No God or demon can stop me, ahahahaha! You are dismissed! All of you, out of my chamber! If I can't have the king's first son, I can just make one!" (*Smiles*)

King Benson: (*At the Palace of Splendor*) "Mother, there is urgent news!"

Imperial Grand Queen: "What kind of news?!"

King Benson: "They found a sugar mine in the slave village!"

Imperial Grand Queen: "Amazing! You can put them under the protection of the crown and protect the resources from the imperial family. All of that can help us destabilize the imperial family and return power to the crown!"

King Benson: “You were not aware of the matter? You were in charge of rebuilding the slave village; how did this matter escape your supervision?”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(The king’s mother)* “I finished restoring the village a couple of months ago and placed a new administration to serve the slave village well. I put all my focus on working on the rebellion matter; I had no idea that the imperial family and nobles would do this behind my back!”

King Benson: “I did a few investigations, and I believe it is Rika again!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “What?! How?! How far does her influence reach?! How did she hear about the sugar mine?!”

King Benson: “I do not know! But whenever I investigate the situation, Rika looks clean and polished. Most of the people who work for her suddenly disappear, get sick, or get dismissed from the palace—she leaves no record! All the people who could testify suddenly vanish; I find it highly suspicious!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “That is true; it always looks like this whenever Rika tries to cover something up or launch an attack! Furthermore, the amount of money she spends far surpasses the monthly budget the palace offers her. I always wonder where she gets the extra money!”

King Benson: “And no money outside the palace is allowed in, but I checked her monetary statements, and her spending looks correct. Unless someone from outside smuggled the money in, there is no way she could get this extra money!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “And there is a surplus of gold and silver circulating the palace. I tried to investigate, but I realized it was counterfeit money!”

King Benson: *(Chokes)* “Who dares make counterfeit money in my territory and bring it into the palace?! That is unforgivable!”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Gives the gold and silver to her son)* “Here is the fake currency! Take a look and tell me what you think!”

King Benson: *(Checks carefully)* “Hmmm... Yes, indeed, this is fake gold and silver! How did something like this enter my palace?!” *(Squeezes the gold and silver)* “Rika, how dare you try to destabilize my empire!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “We do not have proof yet, but I believe if we figure out how the fake currency gets into the palace, we will solve the sugar mine problem.”

King Benson: “That can’t wait—my wife needs an answer. I will go with the imperial soldiers to check the situation and make it safe for my pregnant wife to visit!” *(Squeezes the counterfeit coin)*

Imperial Grand Queen: “Okay, you take care of the sugar mine, and I will investigate who is smuggling the fake currency into the palace!”

Maid: *(Interrupting)* “Your Highness, I have very bad news!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “How can things possibly go wrong again?!”

King Benson: “What is it?!”

Maid Guana: “There is a rumor spreading both inside and outside the palace! It’s about Queen Rosanna?! The imperial family just launched their attacks, and people are rebelling—including those in the queen’s own homeland!”

King Benson: “What are the people saying?! What do they want?!”

Maid Guana: “They are saying Queen Rosanna is a slave, and a slave cannot rule! They say she seduces evil spirits that are destroying our homeland, and that she forces the king to wipe out the main branch of the imperial family, including the prime minister and the commander. They believe she schemed against the ex-Grand Imperial Queen Yuri to have her sent to the cold

palace, and that out of jealousy, she forced the king to dismiss the harem and lock down Imperial Noble Consort Rika. Everyone knows that Rika is pregnant, and they are asking the king to release her from her confinement!”

King Benson: (*Takes a deep breath*) “Now the entire imperial family is ganging up against us!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “This is Rika's move; she finally made her move. My son, why don't you reveal that Rika's child's father is actually an imperial guard?!”

King Benson: “I am planning to, but we have to make sure we cut off all the loose ends first. This has to be our counter-move that will put Rika and the imperial family down permanently. Guana, does the queen know about the rumors?!”

Maid Guana: “Now that the queen is three months pregnant, her health and safety must be our primary goal. I made sure no rumors entered her private quarters or chambers; Queen Rosanna is not aware yet... but we are running out of time, and we don't know what type of move Rika will make next!”

King Benson: “Now that she is three months pregnant, staying in the same palace as Rika is not safe. But I do not know if it is safer outside, because we don't know who Rika is using!”

Queen Rosanna: (*With her pregnant belly showing, interrupting them*) “I will go! I will go with you to the slave village to fix the sugar crisis! We cannot leave the capital in crisis. How about we gather everyone and give a speech to explain everything and expose the truth!”

King Benson: “That will not do—you are heavily pregnant! I will not put you in danger!”

Queen Rosanna: “I know, my husband, but can you please trust me? This pregnancy is an advantage—who will not pity a pregnant woman?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “It is still far too dangerous! What if someone attacks you?!”

Queen Rosanna: “I believe my husband will protect me like he always has, and we will take a few trusted guards with us. But we cannot leave the palace empty, so Mother, you will have to stay here to keep an eye on Rika's moves!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “I hear you, but I do not feel safe letting you stop the rebellion and stand in the crowds, especially being so heavily pregnant. It makes me uneasy!”

King Benson: “Yes, I agree with my mother; I will never forgive myself if anything happens to you!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Pouting*) “Please trust me! My husband will be there; everything will be alright! Please, Mother, do not stop me!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Holds her daughter-in-law's hands*) “Your safety is my priority; I do not want you to put yourself or the babies in danger. I will be at peace if you take some of my people outside the palace to protect you!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Smiles warmly*) “Mother, you worry for nothing, but I shall do as you request. I will take your people outside to protect me during my speeches, okay?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Good, my good daughter! I pray that this trip outside the palace is safe!”

Queen Rosanna: “My dear mother, God will always answer your prayer. The prayer of a mother toward her children is the most powerful shield. I actually already knew about the rumors, too—it was so suspicious to see everyone acting so protective, as nobody from outside was allowed in my quarters and none of my servants wanted me to leave my quarters. I thought something must have been going on! Guana!”

Maid Guana: “Yes, Your Highness!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Holds Guana's hands*) “You know I hate when you hide things from me! Don't you trust me to solve everything together? We are a family, and I see you as my own sister!”

Personal Maid Guana: “Your Majesty! I am just worried about your safety and the babies; I don't want you to put yourself in unnecessary danger!”

Queen Rosanna: “I know that. Ever since the day I moved into the palace when I was eighteen, and after I met you, you have always been so protective! But I am going to be twenty-six soon; I am not a kid.”

Personal Maid Guana: “But to me, Your Highness, you are the only family I have left. Please, Your Highness, let me go outside the palace with you!”

Queen Rosanna: “But I need you here to watch over the palace and my private quarters!”

Personal Maid Guana: “Your Highness, I have a trusted eunuch and maid who can do that job just as well as I could. Please, Your Highness, allow me to go with you!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Guana is my person; I sent her to the palace when my son was a child to keep him safe when I was exiled to the temple by Yuri. After taking care of my son, she is now taking care of you. Let her accompany you outside the palace, and take some of my imperial guards, eunuchs, and maids. They are entirely loyal to my family, and they will know exactly how to act when an emergency occurs.”

Queen Rosanna: “Mother, if you trust them, I trust them. I will take them outside the palace together with my husband and my people!”

King Benson: *(Smiling)* “That got solved quickly! The imperial guards will send the news throughout the empire that the king and queen will be coming out of the palace. Let everyone who has a complaint bring it to them! Let everyone gather in the capital in three days!!”

Imperial Guard: “We shall do exactly as the Lord desires!”

Narrator: After three days, the king and queen leave the palace to meet with the citizens of the empire for the first time together. But Imperial Noble Consort Rika has other plans for them!

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Smirking during her lockdown in her quarters as her pregnancy becomes more noticeable)* “Everything is going as we planned. Did the king and queen leave the palace?!”

Maid: “Yes, Your Highness! I let some of our people mix in with the citizens. Today's show will be unforgettable—she will not return to the palace, ahahaha!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Walking inside her inner chamber)* “Ahahaha! That's what you get for challenging me! You are not worthy of it, ahahahaha!”

Crowds: *(Outside the palace walls, shouting complaints)* “Depose that slave woman! We don't want her! She is not worthy to be the ruler of this empire!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Standing beside her husband, holding his hand and touching her belly)* “You've got this!”

King Benson: *(Holding his wife's hand)* “You don't have to do this if you don't want to!”

Queen Rosanna: “I must do this!”

Crowds: *(Starting to throw vegetables at the queen)* “Go back to your village, slave woman! Woman of evil! Return to your homeland, you slave! You are not worthy! Depose her! Depose her!”

King Benson: *(Shielding his wife from the attacks)* “Guards, get every single person who hurt my pregnant wife executed!”

Queen Rosanna: “Stop!” *(Whispering to her husband)* “We cannot fight violence with violence.” *(Looking at the crowds)* “Then answer me: who is worthy?!”

Citizen 1: “All queens must come from pure blood!”

Citizen 2: “Yes, all the rulers of our blessed empire come from clean imperial royal blood! You slave women are unclean and evil; you are not worthy!”

King Benson: “You dare disrespect my woman—your queen—in front of me?!”

Citizen 1 & 2: (*In fear*) “It is not what we mean! We are just saying this woman is a seductress of evil spirits... ever since she entered the palace, people keep dying! A slave woman from a village has nothing to do with royal matters, knows nothing about the empire or royalty, has no backers, and doesn't come from an influential family! Her family has no merit or noble status!”

King Benson: “Then are you saying I am unworthy to be king?!”

Crowds: (*Whispering*) “No, no, that's not what we meant!”

King Benson: “My mother is from a merchant family; she had no relationship with the imperial family, and when my father was alive, she was a concubine. Since you said all the rulers of our blessed empire come from pure blood, are you calling me impure blood?!”

Citizen 1: “No, Your Highness... we are not talking about you! We are talking about her?!”

King Benson: “And who is 'her'?!”

Citizen 1: “That slave girl?!”

King Benson: “And who is that slave girl?!”

Citizen 1: “The queen! Beside you!”

King Benson: (*In anger*) “Then you should bow down and show your respect! Don't you know disrespecting the crown leads to the execution of your entire family?”

Crowds: (*Bowing down in fear*) “Have mercy, Your Highness! We were just saying a woman from a slave village is not worthy; the king has some royal blood in him, but the queen's lineage is impure!”

King Benson: “In my entire life, I have never met someone as sweet as my beautiful wife—kind, generous, compassionate, forgiving, understanding, and cute! When she was crowned queen, she immediately worked on decreasing tax collection by half, and she stopped the nobles from taking your women and children for forced house labor! She worked tirelessly to stop the nobles from taking away your land and crops, all while the imperial family worried about the luxuries they spent and how to cover the gap in their lavish daily expenses! She is fighting the nobles and rumors at the same time while being pregnant! But look: the very citizens she is defending and fighting for are defending their oppressors! You are the ones who are not worthy, not my queen, who is full of love and compassion! I should just give you up to those greedy nobles and imperial families; let's see how you and your family survive then!”

Crowds: “What?! We thought that the imperial family was the one that made all these changes and that the nobles were showing more compassion! We are so sorry, Your Highness!”

King Benson: (*Angry*) “Foolishness! Foolishness! When have you ever heard that nobles sacrificed their luxurious daily lives and expenses for your good in this empire?! Or when have you ever heard those corrupt dead ministers show compassion for your children, crops, and wives?!”

Citizen 2: “Your Majesty! We were wrong! We are truly sorry!”

King Benson: “I don't need your apology—the one you hurt is my beloved wife! The one you should apologize to is my queen. From a young age, nobles and imperial family members are raised in luxury and taught how to rule; they can't relate to your suffering or struggles. But my wife has the same pain and experiences as you. Nobody is fit to rule beside me if it is not her.”

Queen Rosanna: “When a noble tries to mock my lack of education and imperial knowledge or rituals... I spent my life learning how to survive the winters, how to dig a well of water, and how to hunt for food. They spent time learning which fork to use, which dance goes with which music, and what dress is in trend. But you spent your time working on your farms and crops while the nobles waited to take away your animals, crops, and women. Tell me: who is better

suited to guide an empire through a storm?! I know I am a village girl; my father is a fisherman, and my mother was a dancer. I have no powerful backers or influence. From an outside perspective, after the dismissal of the harem, the execution of all the ministers, the prime minister, and the commander, and the deposing of Yuri, I do look like a seductress. But did you forget that all the people who got punished are the same people who destroyed your family, stole your land, and abused you?! The same people sent letters of complaint to the king—now the king has done justice for you, and you call him an evil seed! For all the work my husband has done for this empire, you are not worthy of his sincere and true heart! He spent nights reviewing each complaint, planning how to solve it and how to make life easy for his people. Yet in every situation, you blindly tear him down with your complaints!”

Crowds: “Yes, it is true! It is true! We are very sorry; we got misled and took advantage of it!

Long live the King! Long life the Queen!”

Citizen 1: “Long life the Queen! Long life the King! We give you all our loyalty and all that we own! For our blessed empire!”

Citizen 2: “For our blessed empire!”

Crowds: “Long life the King! Long life the Queen! For our empire!” (*All the citizens of the empire repeat it over and over*)

Narrator: The king and queen walk hand in hand while the citizens of their empire cheer them on and sing their praises! “Long life to the King and Queen!” As the couple walks away, one of the people in the crowd stands up with a knife to attack the queen, but her personal maid Guana shields her and takes the knife straight to her chest. The imperial guards rush to the pregnant queen inside the carriage for her safety, while the king and the guards capture the attacker. The attacker commits suicide to ensure silence, but they carry the imperial family seal with them. The crowds are dismissed while still singing praises to the king and queen, and the couple and the injured maid Guana return to the palace to get immediate treatment for the injured Guana.

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: “How did the couple of the year receive my little gift?! Did those people crush her into dust?!”

Maid: “Imperial Noble Consort! The event was a disaster for us! The people left singing the praises of the king and queen; the empire accepted her, acknowledged her rulership, and pledged their loyalty to the King and Queen!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: “What?! Did Rosanna at least die?! Did they finish the job?! Did she get injured at least?! Anything?!”

Maid: “No, Your Highness!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: (*Slaps the maid*) “What?! What type of people are you sending to get the job done?!”

The End of Season 1: *Rosanna and the Evil King*

Season 2: *The Song of Rosanna and the Evil King: The Secret Identity*

Chapter 1: The Secret Identity

Prophet Kafura: (*Storyteller*) “The king and queen rush back to the palace. They take the injured maid Guana to their inner chambers and call the imperial doctor to treat her.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Crying*) “Hurry! Hurry! Follow me! Lay her on our bed! Maids, go call the imperial doctor! Fast!” (*Carrying the injured Guana*) “Stop crying, stop panicking! She is going to be okay!” (*Laying Guana on their bed*) “Guana, you cannot die! Keep your eyes open, okay?! You cannot leave me!” (*Crying*) “You raised me and took care of me; you are more than a maid to me, so please do not die, okay?!”

Maid Guana: *(Smiling while bleeding and coughing up blood)* “My King, it is not fitting for a king to cry. How many times did I tell you to stop crying in front of people?” *(Holds the king's face)* “Do not waste your precious tears on a lowly life like mine.” *(Coughing up blood)* “You better be gentle to my queen; she is so sensitive and emotional!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying)* “Just stop worrying about me already! I am going to be twenty-six and will be a mother of twins! I am a grown-up!” *(Crying)*

Maid Guana: *(Giggles)* “And you think grown-ups go around screaming that they are grown-ups? In my eyes, my queen, you will always be a child!”

Queen Rosanna: “That is not fair; you are driving me backward! Please do not die. You have to see my children; you have to watch them grow older and get married. You will be their teacher and babysitter—please do not leave me!”

Maid: “Your Highness, the imperial doctor is here!”

Imperial Doctor: “Gree—”

King Benson: *(Interrupting)* “Stop the greetings and treat my maid fast!”

Imperial Doctor: *(Standing up fast, removes Guana's robe, pulls out the knife, tries to stop the bleeding, and begins to clean the wound and bandage it)* “We are so lucky—the knife did not go deep! She was wearing her identity seal, and the person stabbed directly through it, which helped stop the knife from going in. Give her a couple of days; she will wake up. Right now she is in shock. Here, Your Majesty, is her identity seal; she will need a new one, as this one is completely broken!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Sitting on the floor)* “Thank you, Holy Spirit! I was the one who made her identity seal; I gave it to her as a birthday gift when she turned thirty-five.” *(Crying)* “I never imagined that would save her life! I am so relieved!” *(Hugging her husband while crying)*

King Benson: *(Crying and hugging his wife)* “I was so scared, oh my God! I am happy she will be fine, and you and our twins are safe. They will pay for this; I will not let a single one of them escape!” *(Crying)*

Imperial Doctor: “My job here is done. I will come again tonight to check how her wound is and give her medicine once she wakes up! The queen needs to rest, too! This medicine is for you, My King; it will help you sleep. The queen should continue taking her medicine, as well, especially after the events of today.”

King Benson: “Go prepare both medicines; do not forget to add sugar to them. I will stay here until my wife calms down!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: “Did they find out whose people the attackers were?”

Maid: “No, Your Highness, but those idiots had their identification seals on them.”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Slaps the maid)* “You idiot! How many times have I told you to be careful? This could lead them straight to us!”

Maid: *(Crying)* “The seal only said 'Imperial Family Members'; it did not specify their branch or name, Your Highness!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Standing up)* “That is good, as long as they cannot track us. Alright... hopefully, Guana dies!”

Maid: “Hhmmm... she survived, as well!”

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Slaps and starts kicking the maid)* “What?! What kind of joke is this?! Is life laughing at me?! I will not let this happen! It cannot be like this! Why is she so lucky?! Everything is over for her! Why?! Why is she having it so easy?! Guards, take this incompetent maid and beat her to death! Take a deep breath, Rika; it is okay!” *(Starts screaming and breaking furniture in her chamber)* “Die, Rosanna! Die! Die! Die! I hate you! I hate you!”

Why can't you die or disappear?! That stupid king is ruining my plan! I need to get rid of both of them, but they are so lucky and protected! Why?!"

Maid: *(Being beaten)* "Show mercy, Your Highness! I have served you since I was a child! Show mercy! Give me another chance to make things right for those I have wronged! Please, God, see this lowly slave and answer my request—I promise I will confess everything I did for that evil Rika! Save me!"

King Benson: *(Falling asleep cuddling with his wife, whispering and giggling)* "So happy you're safe... You better serve me well tonight. Show me all the moves I showed you! Yes, my queen, I like that! Give me more!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Already finished taking her medicine)* "I still haunt you even in your dreams, my little pervert!"

King Benson: *(Sleeping and mumbling)* "Wait! I need to see what you are wearing underneath! Kiss me more! You need to sit on top tonight!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Staring at her husband sleeping and whispering to him)* "You are still a little pervert, even in your dreams!" *(She covers her husband and walks around the palace in deep thought)* "I do not like how people close to me keep getting hurt! I feel like they are getting hurt because they are around me. Even though I am a queen, I do not know how to protect the ones I love. Oh God, I do not know how to deal with Rika and her influence!"

Maid: *(Bleeding)* "Help me, please! I do not want to die! Please!"

Queen Rosanna: "Do you hear that?!"

Maid: "Your Majesty! Hear what?!"

Queen Rosanna: "I think I am hearing someone asking for help in that direction!!"

Maid: "Your Majesty! That is Imperial Noble Consort Rika's quarters; it is not safe to go there!"

Rika's Personal Maid: *(Outside)* "Help me, please! I do not want to die! I need to see Queen Rosanna; I have things to report!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Running toward the sound)* "But life is more important, you know that Rika has been in a bad mood lately!" *(Arriving)* "You?! Are you not Rika's personal maid?! What happened to you?!"

Maid: "Please help me! I do not want to die! I have proof of everything Rika did. If you save me, I will give it to you!"

Queen Rosanna: "Guards! Take this injured maid to the doctor and have him treat her and heal her no matter the cost!"

Maid: "Your Majesty! Are you sure we can trust her?! She is Rika's maid—what if this is their plan?!"

Imperial Guards: *(Carrying the bleeding maid to the doctor's quarters)* "Yes, Your Majesty!"

Queen Rosanna: "If this was their trap, this maid wouldn't have been left half-dead. Nobody knew we were walking around the palace. Let's continue walking; I have never seen this part of the palace. Who lives there?!"

Maid: "That is the cold palace quarters; the one next to it is the isolation palace... it is only a little better than the cold palace!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Walking toward the isolation palace)* "Wait! Is that Yuri?! Is she not supposed to be in the cold palace?! Why is she in the isolation palace?!" *(Entering the quarters)*

Maid: "Your Highness, it is not safe for you to enter the isolation quarters, especially being pregnant! We don't know which crazy person lives here!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Getting closer to the stranger)* "Yuri?!"

Stranger: "Who are you?!"

Queen Rosanna: (*Looks carefully*) “Are you not Yuri?!”

Stranger: (*Grabbing Rosanna's hand*) “Did that wicked woman send you to finish me?!”

Maid: (*Pushing the strange woman away*) “Stay away from our lady the queen!”

Stranger: (*Yelling*) “Tumifisa! Tumifisa, are you still alive?! Oh my God, that is so good!”
(*Hugging Rosanna*)

Queen Rosanna: (*Pushing the stranger away*) “What are you doing?!”

Guard: “Hold the stranger down! You cannot touch the queen!”

Stranger: (*Yelling*) “Tumifisa! It's me, Yi! Yi, I am still alive, remember?! It is me, Yi!”

Queen Rosanna: “I am not Tumifisa; I am Rosanna, Queen of Bopar! You are confusing me with someone else!”

Lady Yi: (*Looking carefully*) “How is it possible? You look the same! I was the one who gave it to you!”

Queen Rosanna: “You dare deceive the crown? This bracelet was given to me by my mother!”

Lady Yi: (*Being held down by the imperial guards*) “Can I ask you: what is your mother's name?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Jirmak! My mother is the princess of the slave village Hikmid!”

Lady Yi: “The child survived! Ahahahah! We were able to save the child! Ahahah.”

Queen Rosanna: “Let's leave this quarter; this lady is crazy!”

Lady Yi: “Wait! I know your mom! Does your mom have a red birthmark behind her neck and thigh?!”

Queen Rosanna: “Yes! How do you know that?!”

Lady Yi: “Because I was the one who helped your mother escape the palace when she was a baby, away from my twin sister Yuri. Your grandmother Tumifisa was my best friend and the personal maid of my twin sister Yuri, and my name is Yi, the oldest twin. I was supposed to marry the last king, but out of jealousy, my twin sister injured my face, locked me down, and got married in my place!”

Queen Rosanna: “That makes no sense! How could your parents not tell the difference between you two?! And why should I believe such a silly story?”

Lady Yi: “How about you go ask my sister Yuri in the cold palace?! She will tell you!”

Queen Rosanna: “How do you know she is in the cold palace?!”

Lady Yi: “Because of the prophecy!”

Queen Rosanna: “What a prophecy?!”

Lady Yi: “It is a long story; you will have to sit down to hear it!”

Maid: “My lady, it is going to be night soon! You cannot trust the words of someone who has been locked in the isolation palace. Everyone who gets sent here always goes crazy!”

Queen Rosanna: “I don't trust you! Even though you know things about my mom... nothing you said can be proven! I am leaving!” (*Walking out of the isolation palace with her maids, eunuchs, and guards*)

Lady Yi: (*Smiling*) “You act exactly like Tumifisa! You are three months pregnant, and you are carrying twins—a boy and a girl!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shocked and terrified*) “What?! How do you know that?! Do you have spies in my quarters?! Are you threatening me?!”

Lady Yi: “Well, I saw it in a dream. I just didn't expect that it was you instead of Tumifisa! How cruel my sister is—she probably killed your grandma!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Walking out of those quarters fast in fear*) “Maid! Go investigate the imperial ledgers and documents! Go find out if anyone named Tumifisa existed, and investigate Yuri and her family, leaving nothing out! I am returning to my quarters to talk to my husband!”

Maids and Eunuchs: “Yes, Your Majesty!”

Prophet Kafura: (*Narrator*) As the queen walks toward her quarters, she meets the Grand Imperial Queen watering the flowers in the garden.

Queen Rosanna: (*Entering the garden*) “Greetings, Mother!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Turning toward Rosanna*) “Greetings, my daughter! Why are you walking alone at night?!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Smiling*) “I was surrounded by maids, but I sent them away.”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Now that you are pregnant, it is not safe for you to walk alone at night! Those palace personnel should be punished!”

Queen Rosanna: “Mother, it's ok! But I have a question: do you know if the ex-Grand Imperial Queen had a sister... or a twin sister?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Looking carefully at Rosanna*) “Hmmm... I remember when I was young, I married the past king and was pregnant with my son. I heard that the king was supposed to crown a woman of the imperial main branch called Yi, but something happened, and he married her sister Yuri instead!”

Queen Rosanna: “Hmmm... do you know what actually happened?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “It was this massive controversy. Anyone who talked about it or knew the situation was executed by Yuri! People used to say that even though they were identical twins, Yi—which means 'virtue'—was more beautiful, elegant, talented, and kind than her sister Yuri, whose name used to be RuYi, meaning 'not a perfect virtue'. She was ruthless, a schemer, and jealous of her sister because of her sister's talents. One of them was destined to marry the past king; something happened to Yi, and RuYi changed her name to Yuri to erase her sister.”

Queen Rosanna: “Do you know anything about Tumifisa?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “How do you know about these people?! This matter was supposed to be buried and forgotten!”

Queen Rosanna: “Mother, please tell me!! Please!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “All right, because you are cute... Tumifisa was Yuri's personal maid, but Yi's childhood best friend. She was supposed to enter the palace as Yi's personal maid, but after the disappearance of Yi, she had to enter the palace with Yuri. There was this old prophecy: *'The Lord will take the empire and give it to a slave'*... because of how ruthless Yuri was. The king never loved her, because he loved our children and me. She took out her anger on maids, concubines, and slaves. After the prophecy, she removed all the maids that served the king and replaced them with eunuchs. But one day, when the king was drunk, he forced himself on Tumifisa. Months before I got exiled to the cold palace, I heard that Tumifisa gave birth with the help of Yi, but both Yi and Tumifisa died—nobody knows where the child is or if the child even survived, though we all knew it was a girl. After that, Yuri schemed against me, and I got exiled to the temple. The king never visited Yuri until the day he passed away.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Speechless*) “Do you know the child's name?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Thinking carefully*) “The child's name was supposed to be... Jir... Jirm... I believe it was supposed to be... hmmm... Jirmak! Yes! The baby's name was Jirmak!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shocked, almost fainting*) “Does that mean... My husband and I are related?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “That is not true, because that night the king spent the night with me in my quarters! We wanted to keep it a secret because he was scheduled to spend that night with Queen Yuri. Tumifisa was taken advantage of by the past king's brother. To cover the scandal, the king was willing to adopt the child of Tumifisa as his first princess; he wanted to protect both the child and the mother. But Yuri found out and thought that it was the king's child.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Taking a deep breath)* “To protect me, his brother, and the royal family's reputation, the king had to cover for his brother. It is a crime for any man to touch any woman who lives in the palace—all women who live in the palace belong to the king, including the maids. So his brother forcing himself onto a maid is the same as declaring that he is king, which is seen as rebellion! The king loved his only brother; to protect him from the corrupt ministers who forced him to marry Yuri as queen, he took the blame. He just never expected that Yuri would harm a pregnant maid and an unborn child.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Taking off her bracelet)* “Do you know anything about this bracelet?!”

Imperial Grand Queen: *(Checking the bracelet carefully)* “What?!... This is an imperial treasure... The king and I picked this gift for Tumifisa's child, Jirmak. We were planning to give it to the baby after she was born, but we lost it in the chaos of trying to stop Yuri from killing the child and mother. How did you find it?!” *(Starts crying)*

Queen Rosanna: *(Takes back her bracelet and walks away)* “Mother, I will take my leave!”

Imperial Grand Queen: “Wait! Have a maid escort the queen back to her palace!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Whispering to herself)* “I never imagined my mother would be imperial, and that I have imperial blood. Does that mean I am also evil!?” *(Arrives at her quarters and lies beside her husband)*

Imperial Grand Queen: “Maybe if the king and I had told Yuri that the king spent that night with me, perhaps Tumifisa and Jirmak would have been alive!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Back in her palace, lying beside her husband)* “So we are both from the same family... Does that make us cousins?”

King Benson: *(Mumbling in his sleep and giggling)* “Yes, wifey, we can do it here... nobody is watching! Hahaha... now you are pregnant! It means my work is paying off!” Hahahaha...

Queen Rosanna: *(Staring at her sleeping husband)* “Wake up, pervert!”

King Benson: *(Opening his eyes and smiling)* “Yes, wifey, let's continue where we left off!”

(Puffy face) “Hey! Why do you have your clothes on?! I just took them off!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Staring at her husband)* “Hmmm...!”

King Benson: “I mean, in the dreams... when I was dreaming...” *(Trying to go back to sleep)* “I am going to dreamland.”

Queen Rosanna: *(Staring at her husband and smiling)* “Don't sleep, my pervert! We need to talk.”

King Benson: *(Sitting up)* “Anything my queen wants! Half of my kingdom is all yours—what bothers my wife?!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Smiles)* “Pervert!”

King Benson: *(Bursting out laughing)* “Ahahaha! You know you're funny without even trying!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Laughing together with her husband)* “Ahahaha, I am serious! Ahahaha!”

King Benson: “Okay! Tell me, I am all yours!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “Did you know that Yuri's name was RuYi and she had a twin sister called Yi?!”

King Benson: *(Thinking deeply)* “Yes, I remember... but mostly it was a rumor. Everyone who knew about it got executed by Yuri.”

Queen Rosanna: "I met Yi today!"

King Benson: (*Giggles*) "That's impossible! Because there was a rumor that her twin sister died—that's how she ended up marrying my father! But I believe, with how evil she is, she probably killed her twin sister!"

Queen Rosanna: "Did they find her body or a cemetery?!"

King Benson: "Not really, because the imperial family put pressure on my dad to marry Yuri as queen, and my dad didn't have time to investigate because he had to protect my mother and me. Yes, years after she got married, I heard that my father's brother slept with her personal maid and the maid got pregnant. My mother tried to protect the maid, but I heard that she died, and nobody knows where the baby is until today. My father wanted to adopt the baby as his first princess to protect his brother from the imperial family, but the ex-Queen Yuri was against it because she thought my father was the one who slept with the maid!"

Queen Rosanna: "What if I tell you that the baby survived?"

King Benson: "That will be amazing, because my uncle hated my dad because he thought that my father was the one who harmed the baby! My father's biggest regret was failing to protect his brother's only daughter!"

Queen Rosanna: "Yi is alive! She is locked in the isolation palace, and the baby survived, too!"

King Benson: "What?! You are serious?!"

Queen Rosanna: "Very serious... and I am the child of that baby!"

King Benson: "Stop joking!"

Queen Rosanna: "I am very serious! We are cousins! Maid! Go call the imperial doctor!"

Maid: "Yes!"

King Benson: "Eunuch! Go to the imperial uncle's palace and ask him to come see the king. It is an emergency! Fast! I will personally go to the isolation palace to see if Yi is still alive. My queen, you stay here; I will be right back!" (*Standing and going to the isolation palace*)

Queen Rosanna: (*Nods*)

Prophet Kafura: (*Narrator*) King Benson went to the isolation palace while his imperial uncle headed to the palace!

Imperial Eunuch: "Imperial uncle has entered the quarters!"

Imperial Uncle: (*Walking in, upset*) "That brat called me at this hour... so, where is the king?"

Queen Rosanna: (*Walking toward the sound*) "Who dares break into my palace?!"

Imperial Uncle: (*Stares at Queen Rosanna*) "Tumifisa?! Are you still alive?!" (*Starts crying, hugging Rosanna*)

Queen Rosanna: "Impudent! Guards?!"

Imperial Guards: "Protect the queen! Greetings, imperial uncle!"

Queen Rosanna: "Imperial uncle?!"

Imperial Uncle: "It is me, Tumifisa! Are you still pregnant?!"

Queen Rosanna: (*Looking away in embarrassment*) "I am not Tumifisa! I am... hmmm...

Rosanna, daughter of Jirmak! Jirmak, your daughter!"

Imperial Uncle: "Jirmak?! Daughter of Jirmak...?! Jirmak?!"

Queen Rosanna: "Yes! Tumifisa's child survived! I am the daughter of that baby... your granddaughter!"

Eunuch: "The imperial doctor is here!"

Imperial Doctor: "Greetings, Your Highness! Oohh! Hmmm... my greetings to you, imperial uncle!"

Imperial Uncle: "It is good to see you again; you are still as young as ever!"

Queen Rosanna: "Rise; my husband will be back shortly!"

Imperial Guards: "King Benson is back!!!"

Imperial Doctor: "Greetings, My King!"

Imperial Uncle: "Greetings to you, King Benson!"

King Benson: "Rise! I brought someone from the isolation palace!"

Imperial Uncle: *(Looking at the stranger from the isolation palace)* "Yi?! You are still alive!"

Lady Yi: *(Runs for a hug)* "Imperial family head?!"

King Benson: "To clarify, she is truly Yi, the twin sister of the ex-Grand Imperial Queen Yuri!"

Lady Yi: "She is a fake! I am the one who was supposed to marry your father, King Benson, but my twin sister threatened me, injured my face, accused me of being impure, and locked me in the palace on the wedding day! She did all this with the help of the prime minister!" *(Looking around)*

"Where is Tumifisa's child?!" *(Walking toward Rosanna)*

King Benson: *(Interrupting her walk)* "Please stay away from my pregnant wife until it is deemed safe for you to get close! Imperial doctor, can you do a blood test to see if we are related?!"

Imperial Doctor: "Yes, Your Majesty! But it will take a while to gather all the tools I need for the test!"

King Benson: "Tell him what you need, and my maids will help you organize everything according to your instructions!"

Imperial Doctor: "I need a bowl of water, Your Majesty."

King Benson: "Bring a bowl of water!"

Maid: *(Bringing water)* "Yes, Your Majesty!"

Imperial Doctor: "I will need a few drops of blood from the imperial uncle and Rosanna! I will have to use my needle to get blood from your fingers!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying)* "What?! I hate needles! Do you have other methods?!"

Imperial Doctor: "This is the only true and precise method, and it is direct!!" *(Takes blood from the imperial uncle and drops it into the water)* "Queen Rosanna, it is your turn!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Running, crying to her husband, and hiding in his arms)* "No needles, it hurts!"

King Benson: *(Comforting his wife)* "It's okay, my wife, you are safe... alright, let's just get this done, okay? Just look at me, not the needle or the doctor!"

Queen Rosanna: "But I am pregnant! I hate needles!" *(Suddenly she gets pricked by the needle, and a drop of blood enters the water and merges with the imperial uncle's blood, showing a direct relationship)*

Imperial Doctor: "Yes! The blood merged as one; you have a very strong relationship... you are related!"

King Benson: *(Shocked, then laughs)* "What?! So you are related to your imperial uncle?! We are cousins! Can you try to take my blood and the queen's blood to see if we are related?!"

Imperial Doctor: *(Pricking the queen again with the needle, and then the king)* "You are not related, but it looks like you might be from the same family, though not directly related! Same with Lady Yi."

King Benson: "Go! Bring Yuri from the cold palace!"

Imperial Guards: "Yes, Your Majesty!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying from the pricks of the needle)* "That was not nice!"

Imperial Uncle: "It's okay, my daughter. Come to Grandpa, come get a hug!!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Runs to her inner chamber)* "Nooo!"

King Benson: *(Giggles)* "Ahahaha, you just scared my wife!"

Imperial Uncle: (*Heartbroken*) “Not fair! I finally have a girl in my family, and she escapes me?!”

King Benson: “Give her time, and she will warm up to you!”

Imperial Uncle: “I just want to take her home, to a grandpa, and spoil her! Get some family bonding time!”

King Benson: “If you do that, you will be permanently banned from entering the palace! My wife, mine alone! I found her first! All of you, stop trying to steal my pregnant wife!”

Imperial Uncle: “Listening to my grandson-in-law, the p...!”

Imperial Guard: “Yuri is here!”

Lady Yi: (*Standing up proudly to face her evil twin*) “Long time no see!”

Yuri: (*The past king's queen*) “You're still alive? I thought that the isolation palace would finish the job!” (*Guards force her to kneel and hold her down*)

Imperial Doctor: (*Takes Yuri's and Yi's blood and tests it*) “Yes, they are directly related! They are identical twin sisters!”

Yuri: “So what?! She is old, and the last king is dead, ahahaha! I already enjoyed the power and the beauty, while you have been locked in the palace looking ugly!”

Lady Yi: (*Getting closer to her twin and whispering*) “And more worthless and unwanted—just like Prophet Kafura said!”

Yuri: (*Attacking her sister*) “I will kill you! You die! What makes you think you are better than me, huh?! We have the same face, the same body... What makes you better than me?! Why should I be a servant and you the queen?! Why should your destiny be greater than mine? What makes you better than me?! Nothing?! I will never accept it!! Never!!”

King Benson: “Send her back to the cold palace and cut off her tongue so she will never speak nonsense again!”

Yuri: “You dare?! I am the Grand Imperial Queen! The queen! The past king's legal wife! You dare... Imperial family head, save me! Please! Show mercy! You used to favor me! You supported me! Please!”

King Benson: (*Looking at his uncle*) “Do you want to save her?!”

Imperial Uncle: “No! Take that evil woman away and cut her tongue so she is never seen again!”

Imperial Guards: “Yes!”

Yuri: (*Being dragged away by the imperial guards*) “You cannot do this to me! I am the Grand Imperial Queen! Do not touch me! Do not touch me! Help me! Help! My daughter is the empress of the neighboring empire! She will deal with you. Let's see how you can save this empire, ahahaha!”

King Benson: (*Sitting down and holding his head*) “This is done! Finally, Yuri is down! How will the neighboring empire react when they find out that Yuri and Yi were fake twins, and that the daughter they married now is a fake princess?!”

Imperial Uncle: “The reason why they married Yuri's child was that she was the legal daughter of the king and Yuri; because she was the legitimate princess! If they find out the story of Yuri and Yi, we do not know how they will react or how the empress will be treated. After all, she is innocent. For the sake of our alliance and to save the imperial bloodline from embarrassment, this matter has to end here.”

King Benson: “Yes! This matter is very serious! But the one who has been wronged the most in this matter is Lady Yi!”

Lady Yi: “I just want freedom. I know that everyone in the empire thinks I am dead, so if I can get a new identity with a title and some land for me to stay until I pass away... I have been

locked in the isolation palace by my sister since I was sixteen, and now I am sixty-eight. I just want to rest.”

King Benson: “I know this situation looks unfair to you, Lady Yi, but I hear you; I will reward you greatly for all your suffering. For now, it is late; I will ask my maid to send you to one of the empty quarters to rest. Tomorrow my wife and I will decide what to do next!”

Lady Yi: *(As the maid escorts her to her new room)* “Yes, My King! Since the king and I never married, but he married my twin sister, I have no right to the throne.” *(She leaves the king's quarters)* “Maid! Take me to the cold palace; I want to be there to send my sister away!”

Maid: *(Stares at each other)* “Hmmm... yes, my lady!”

Imperial Uncle: *(Staring at the king)* “Tell me everything about my granddaughter?!”

King Benson: *(Smiling tiredly)* “Grandfather-in-law and imperial uncle... the sun has gone down, and the moon and stars are out... I am so tired, I need sleep.” *(Trying to sneak away)*

Imperial Uncle: *(Thinking deeply)* “Maybe I should move into the palace!! I need to take care of my granddaughter and the future twins!”

King Benson: *(Stops)* “No... no... no, that is not necessary! You can always come to visit her whenever you want... haha!” *(Awkward)* “Just leave and go back to your own house! You have a big palace, too... and here I have all trusted people to take care of my pregnant wife!!”

Imperial Uncle: *(Not listening)* “I am going to go home and pack my things and move into the imperial palace, ahahaha!” *(Grabs his grandson-in-law and carries the king outside the palace with him)*

King Benson: *(Yelling)* “Save me!... Help me!... Nooo!” *(Being carried away by his imperial uncle)*

Imperial Guards: *(In fear, whispering)* “Our king is our hero! Thank you for your sacrifice!

Return to the palace safely, Our Majesty!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Sleeping, deeply tired... dreaming about her mother singing)* “Mother!”

Lady Yi: *(In the cold palace)* “Hello, sister!”

Yuri: *(Tongue cut off, screaming and only making sounds, being held down by maids)*

“Hmmmmmm! Ahhhh! Ehhhh! Hmmmmmm!... Ahhhh!”

Lady Yi: *(Laughing out loud)* “Who would ever imagine our power—Yuri, the most feared and scariest person—would end up less than a dead dog?! My dear sister! How pitiful!”

Yuri: *(Tries to attack her twin sister, but is held down by a maid)* “Ahhhh! Hmmmmmm!... Ehhh... hammm!”

Lady Yi: *(Smiling)* “I know, right... Maybe you should have finished me when you had a chance! I will never forgive you for what you did to our family! Because of you... Mom died, and my lover died... and now I have to lose my only identity! I cannot carry our family name or honor our dead parents... You are so evil!”

Yuri: *(Laughing, trying to form words)* “T... the... d... deserved to... di... die! Ahahahaha... All... of... t... them! Ahahahaha... Y... yu... you... lost! Ahahaha! You have nothing... I... left! Ahahaha! I... am... Yuri... I will n... ver... never die!”

Lady Yi: *(Giggles)* “Just like you left me in the isolation palace to die, I will leave you here to die and rot, ahahaha... Let's see how proud you will be... ahahaha!”

Yuri: *(Yelling)* “Stupid! F... foo... fool... kill... m... me! I... d... don't want to live l... like this! Noooooo! Noo!”

Lady Yi: “Maid! Lock this cold palace. From now on... nobody is allowed in or out. This quarter is in lockdown until my sister dies! One question, Yuri: why didn't you kill me if you had all the chances to do so all these years?!”

Yuri: *(Stays quiet and turns away... a tear falling)*

Lady Yi: *(Walking away from the cold palace)* “Even though you are so evil, you are the only family member I have left. But I will never forgive you for destroying our family! Because of you, Mom died, Brother got killed, and our dad is disabled! My life is ruined... because of your desire for power! Stay here, stay quiet, and get old quietly. Be crazy or a fool... nobody will care about you! As for me, I am leaving this palace... to go see the world!” *(As the gates of the cold palace close)* “Goodbye, my dear twin sister...” *(A tear falling)* “Let's never meet again, or I will kill you!”

Yuri: *(Speaks in her heart)* “I don't regret anything; all who die deserve to die. Everything ended up coming down to you, Yi—you were the gentle one, the graceful one, the kind one, the loved one... everything was easy for you! You were the twin of the sun; meanwhile, I was the twin of the night. Everyone hated me; nobody gave me attention... I was the ugly twin, the unwanted twin, the evil twin... the unlucky twin... our parents put all their attention and investment on you. Meanwhile, they rejected and abandoned me! No matter how much I trained to catch up to you... you were always brighter, shinier than me... even when we wore the same clothes, the same face, the same walks. It is not fair! Why should you be the empress? Why should you be queen? You were too nice, too kind, too gentle... palace life was never for you! You need to be ruthless to survive in this palace... if you don't kill, you get killed! Even if you choose peace, others will still scheme against you! So what did you want me to do...?! You were the only one who treated me kindly and gently... even when I schemed against you or hurt you, why did you have to be the angel and the perfect daughter?! I hate you! I hate you and everyone! I hate you the most! But you were the only family I had left; I couldn't kill you... no matter how much I wanted to! You are so fake! Your knife cuts so deeply... because you kill with kindness! Your kindness is bitter!” *(Crying)* “But I have done so much evil, killed so many people—even if I die, my soul will never find peace! If I stay alive, I fear that the king will not let you go, or our family. After all, we rebelled, tried to assassinate the king and queen... we played with the crown and the bloodline. All of these crimes are too big... I must pay for them with my own life! I will not stay here in the cold palace and die like a rat! I am Yuri, the most powerful woman in the empire—the Grand Imperial Queen, the past king's legal wife! I will not let my enemy triumph over me or get the last laugh; I will laugh at them in hell and wait for their downfall.” *(She wears her wedding robe, the clothes in which she was crowned by the past king)* “Sadly, I wanted to live peacefully with you, but you... you only had eyes for that woman... You never held a place for me in your heart... but I will be the one who gets buried next to you, not that woman! She stole you in this life, but she will not steal my place beside you.” *(In her royal robe, she walks around the cold palace, sits down, and drinks poison. Yuri dies with a prideful smile and smirk)* “I am the only master of my life and time! Take care, my dear sister!” *(Smiles)*

Lady Yi: *(Waking up from a nightmare)* “RuYi?!!!!! Yuri!” *(Runs out of her quarters without shoes in her night robe toward the cold palace)* “RuYi!!!! RuYi!!! Do not do this, please!” *(As memories of their childhood play in her head)* “RuYi!” *(Opens the cold palace's gates... sees her sister wearing her royal imperial robe, sitting down in all her glory)* “RuYi?!”

Yuri: *(Smiling)* “How many times have I told you? My name is Yuri! The Grand Imperial Queen and legal wife of the past king!” *(Coughing out blood)*

Lady Yi: *(Running toward her sister as her twin sister falls into her arms, bleeding out of her mouth)* “RuYi! What did you do? You silly!”

Yuri: *(Out of breath)* “I am Yuri! Are you a dumb fool? Why are you crying, stupid!?” *(Bleeding from her mouth)*

Lady Yi: *(Crying)* “Call the imperial doctor! Fast! Fast!”

Yuri: *(Holding her sister's face)* “Not necessary! This poison has no cure! My dear sister... You are so sweet and soft; palace life was never for you! After all the evil I did, you still come here and cry? You are a stupid woman! I hate our parents because they only loved you and didn't care about you! Sending you into the palace with your personality was a death sentence. I prefer you hating me than seeing the only person who cares about me die! They all deserve to die! I should have wiped them all out!”

Lady Yi: “Why are you always like this? Why do you always think like this...? Our parents knew that with that mentality of yours, you would get the entire imperial family executed! You were too wild; the life of the palace is rules and regulations. You were never good with rules, regulations, or virtue! Now, half of the imperial family is executed because of you. They wanted to keep you home, safe... get you married outside the palace so you could live freely. From the moment we were born, my destiny was already decided; I grew up training for it!”

Yuri: “Really!? But I wanted power and influence! I didn't want a normal life! I hate the prophecy! Why was I the twin of the night?! Why did I choose evil?! I didn't choose this fate! Why should I pay for it?! All of them deserve to die! My sister... now I will be gone; take care of yourself! They will not blame you for anything... I will bury the entire imperial family with me; go live freely. And as for Imperial Noble Consort Rika... she is wiser than me. If she gives birth to a son, our imperial family can still rebuild... but you need to get rid of her before she becomes your obstacle! She is not easy to deal with!”

Lady Yi: *(Holding her bleeding twin sister)* “I don't care! Hang on, ok! The doctor will be here soon!”

Yuri: “Sister!”

Lady Yi: “Yes, Sister!”

Yuri: *(Forming words)* “Can you call my name again? I want to hear it before I go!”

Lady Yi: “You are not going anywhere! No, I am not saying that!”

Yuri: “That is my last wish! Please! You know I don't have much time left!”

Lady Yi: *(Crying deeply)* “RuYi!”

Yuri: *(Bleeding out and coughing)* “RuYi! I am RuYi! Ahahaha...” *(Looking at the night full of stars)* “I am finally free of all this... our parents always cared about the imperial family and its status and influence... I used to think they loved their family and reputation more than us! But now I understand why: it is because if our family stands, we also stand, and nobody will look down on us. We rule, and they are all slaves, ahahaha! I grew up in power and developed a love for our family like a mother for a child, but in the end, I led it to destruction, and now you have nobody to rely on. I only left you with the enemy; I burned all our ways out and all our allies.” *(Coughing hard)*

Lady Yi: “RuYi! Stop thinking of all these things; it doesn't matter. I don't care anymore about power, name, or influence. I just want my beloved sister back!”

RuYi: “Can we go back in?! Can we go back to how we used to be as children?! Before the power, the prophecy, and the schemes? You know, I changed my name to Yuri because I didn't want anyone to blame you for my sins! I hid you in the palace because every time I see you, who I truly am and my sins speak louder!” *(Closes her eyes and dies)* “Even God cannot remake an evil person like me!”

Lady Yi: *(Her twin passing away in her arms, bleeding)* “RuYi!!!!!! Wake up! I forgive you, ok?! Let's go out of the palace; we can start over—I will ask King Benson, they will forgive you!”

Why do you have to be so prideful?! You are my only family, RuYi!” (*Crying deeply and holding her dear twin closely until morning*)

Prophet Kafura: “The death of the past queen was felt throughout the entire empire. King Benson spent his night at his uncle's house telling him about his granddaughter Rosanna's story and packing gifts. The next morning, the Grand Imperial Queen—the king's birth mother—received the news of Yuri passing away from her old rival, as well as the news of Rosanna being the granddaughter of the past king's older brother: the child of Jirmak, Tumifisa's child.”

Queen Rosanna: (*Sunrise, the next day of the chaotic night, waking up in her bed*) “Good morning! Hus... wait! Where is my husband? Maid, where is the king?!”

Maids: (*Bowing down*) “Good morning, Your Majesty. The king left last night with the imperial uncle; he went to his palace!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shocked*) “...Hmm! My husband! Why?!”

Maid: “Since the imperial uncle is your grandfather, he is trying to move in to build a relationship!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Standing up*) “What!?!?”

Imperial Guard: (*Bowing down*) “Your Majesty!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Her stomach is bigger than before*) “What again?!”

Imperial Guard: “Forgive us for the disturbance. Yuri passed away last night!”

Queen Rosanna: “What?! How?!”

Imperial Guard: “And Lady Yi is requesting an audience with you!”

Queen Rosanna: “Son of man, have mercy!!” (*To her maid*) “Maid! Guana! Yes, Your Majesty! Turn toward her maid.” (*To Guana*) “Dress me up, and ask Lady Yi to meet me in the meeting chamber. What?! Guana! What are you doing out of your bed?! Go lay down, the doctor said you need rest until you heal!” (*Pushing her out of her inner chamber and forcing Guana to lie down on her bed*)

Guana: “The imperial doctor said I can do it now, Your Highness! Please, let me serve you!!”

Queen Rosanna: “No! Okay, just heal! After you saved my life and got stabbed because of me, I have been having nightmares. So please rest and heal properly; I will go get your breakfast and bring it to your quarters!”

Guana: “No, Your Majesty! That is your slave's job. Your concern about my life and your care for my safety is more than this maid can afford. Please, Your Majesty, do not overwork yourself, especially since you are so heavily pregnant!”

Queen Rosanna: “You have served me since I entered the palace. At least in gratitude, allow me to serve you, too—not as a master, but as a sister!” (*Standing up to go wash up and make breakfast*)

Imperial Grand Queen: (*The king's birth mother, having breakfast in her quarters*) “Eunuch! Go invite the queen to come have breakfast with me!”

Eunuch: (*Bowing down*) “The queen is having a bath right now, and then she is going to have a meeting with Lady Yi!”

Maid: (*Bowing down*) “Reporting to the Grand Imperial Queen, Yuri passed away last night!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Puts her teacup on the table and takes a deep breath*) “It is finally over. Knowing Yuri, she probably took her own life; she is a prideful woman, and sentencing her to the cold palace and cutting out her tongue is worse than death, because she is used to being respected and feared. Start preparing the funeral—at the end of the day, she is still from the imperial main branch family, and she is still known as the past king's legal wife!”

Personal Maid: "If she didn't plot against you, you should have been the one to be the past king's queen!"

Imperial Grand Queen: "Those grudges passed away together with the dead; there is no need to speak ill of the dead."

Personal Maid: "How do you want her funeral to be, Grand Imperial Queen?! Don't forget she is still an evil woman!"

Imperial Grand Queen: "I will talk to the king and see what he wants to do with Yuri's body!"

Prophet Kafura: *(Narrator)* Together with the maids, Queen Rosanna took a bath and dressed herself to go meet with Lady Yi.

Imperial Guards: "Queen Rosanna is here!"

Lady Yi: *(Bowing down in a night robe stained with her twin sister's blood)* "Greetings, Your Highness!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Sitting down on her throne in the meeting chamber)* "Lady Yi, good morning. What brings you here to my palace, and why is your robe soaked in blood?! Maid, go call the imperial doctor right now!!"

Lady Yi: *(Interrupting)* "No need, Your Majesty! This blood is my sister RuYi's."

Imperial Nurse: *(Entering the chamber, bowing down)* "Good morning, Your Majesty!"

Queen Rosanna: "Check Lady Yi!"

Imperial Nurse: *(Checking Lady Yi)* "Your Majesty, she is perfectly fine, but her pulse shows that she is tired and that she spent the night crying."

Queen Rosanna: "Thank you, you are dismissed! Take Lady Yi, bathe her, and change her robe!"

Maid: "Yes, Your Highness!"

Lady Yi: *(Interrupting)* "If I have found favor in your sight and if the queen has compassion for my past experiences, please accept my request and issue a decree on my sister's behalf!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Intrigued)* "I do show mercy and compassion; after all, I serve a compassionate, forgiving, and understanding God. Please tell me what your request is; in all the power that was granted to me, I shall fulfill it!"

Lady Yi: "My sister has passed away!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Standing up)* "What?! Yuri has died?! How?! When?! Did you..." *(Stares at her robe)* "...attack her?!"

Imperial Nurse: "We checked her body, and it showed that she drank poison!"

Lady Yi: "I had a nightmare last night and decided to go check on my sister. She poisoned herself and died in my arms!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Sitting down)* "Knowing her personality, it is not shocking! What was your request?!"

Lady Yi: "Even though she has done so much evil, can she be buried with all the royal full titles, rituals, and merits as a Grand Imperial Queen and the past king's legal wife!?"

Queen Rosanna: *(Standing up)* "That will never happen! That title belongs to my mother-in-law! Only she can be buried beside the last king!"

Lady Yi: "Please! Your Highness, give me this decree and send her in peace; she is the only family member I have left!"

Imperial Grand Queen: *(King Benson's birth mother)* "And where do you put me?! Your imperial family is used to getting whatever they want! I was not able to marry the last king because your family schemed, but being buried by his side and spending our next life together—I will never compromise on that!" *(Walking across the chamber)*

Lady Yi: “Only the king's legal wife has the right to be buried inside the same tomb as the king, and RuYi was actually the past king's legal wife and queen!”

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Giggles*) “I guess it is time. Hear the past king’s will and decree!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Shocked and bowing down immediately*)

Maids, Eunuchs, and Imperial Guards: (*Bowing down*)

Imperial Grand Queen: (*Reading*) “Here is the word of the past king. This is my last will; hear it and follow it. This decree is an official letter of dissolved marriage between Yuri and me. In my life, I never met someone as vicious as Yuri, but to maintain the balance of the empire and keep the imperial family in check, I had to support her presence and turn a blind eye to her evil deeds. But since I am passing away, I am leaving this decree to protect my beloved wife and Prince Ian. Ian is officially taking over all my royal duties and will be crowned king of this empire; his name shall be known as King Benson, and his mother as the Grand Imperial Queen, the past king's legal wife. Their status should be restored in full, and all that was taken away by the imperial family from them should be returned with interest. The Grand Imperial Queen—King Benson's mother—should be buried beside me once she passes away, to meet again in our next life. As for Yuri, her title is abolished, and all her merits will be taken away, including all the gifts she received from the past king and the people, including all her royal imperial garments. She should be cast out immediately by the past king and thrown to the dogs. That is all!”

Lady Yi: (*Standing up*) “That is impossible! How is that the past king’s decree?! He never talked about leaving any decree! It must be a fake?! You are forcing the will of the heavens?!”

Personal Maid: (*Standing up and slapping Lady Yi*) “You dare?!”

Lady Yi: “You can't do this! You can't fake an imperial decree! If it was the past king's will, why wait until now? Why did you never mention it from the beginning?!” (*Screaming*)

Maid: (*Slapping her*) “You dare disrespect and question an imperial decree!”

Lady Yi: “The past king would never go against the imperial family!”

King Benson: (*Entering the palace*) “Thank God I am not my father! The past king is the past king; I am me, and I am the king!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Looking at her husband*) “You are here!”

King’s Uncle: (*Excited*) “You are here, my granddaughter! Come here! I brought so many things for you!”

Queen Rosanna: (*Hiding behind her mother-in-law*) “No!”

King’s Uncle: (*Heartbroken*) “Come give your grandpa a hug!”

King Benson: (*With tired, sleepless eyes*) “Stop bothering my wife! Lady Yi, your sister will never get the Grand Imperial Queen title; from the beginning, that title should have belonged to my mother... and as the king, I am returning what belongs to whom.

Lady Yi: “But my sister has served the empire for generations! For all the work she has done, she deserves a reward!”

King Benson: “Your sister has destroyed the empire, killed thousands of people, and destroyed multiple families for selfish reasons! She corrupted the empire and corrupted the ministers... your imperial family ruled in blood and sheep!”

Lady Yi: “Is the empire not successful... the empire still succeeds and goes forward and develops!”

King Benson: “Are you discrediting the lives your sister took?!”

Lady Yi: “They are servants; they should serve the empire!”

King Benson: “You dare look down on my people?! In the beginning, I felt sorry for you and what happened to you; now I realize that keeping you around is a death insurance policy!”

Lady Yi: “I do not care about what happens to me; spending years in that isolation palace turned me into a corpse anyway. The dead are dead... Your Majesty, please, let my sister be buried with the honor of a Grand Imperial Queen!”

King Benson: “The past king wrote a letter of divorce to your sister Yuri a long time ago. He feared that after he passed away, your family would turn his beloved empire into chaos and a playground. He asked my mother to hide this secret decree until the right time and to eliminate your family because you are all too powerful.”

Lady Yi: “Then why didn't you do it?! Why wait until today?!”

King Benson: “The safety of my women and the stability of my empire are my top priorities!”

Lady Yi: “So you used Yuri to get rid of the imperial family?!”

King Benson: *(Smiles)*

Lady Yi: “What about Imperial Noble Consort Rika?! Will you get rid of her, too?! She is carrying your blood! Your child!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Giggles)* “Who said that was the king’s child?! In this life and the next one, forever I will be the only one who will carry my king’s children!”

Lady Yi: “Wait! You would harm your own child just to get rid of the imperial family?!”

King Benson: “If you plan to use Rika’s child to gain power, it is useless—that child is not mine!”

Lady Yi: “Everyone in the palace knows that Rika is carrying the king's child!”

King’s Uncle: “The child Rika is carrying belongs to one of the guards who live in the palace!

King Benson never slept with Rika. Even though I don't like having him as my grandson-in-law, I'll admit he is pretty smart!”

Lady Yi: *(Falls to the ground)*

King Benson: *(Holding his wife)* “Lady Yi, you better give up all the crazy ideas in your head; this king is not easy to bully!” *(Looks at his wife and whispers)* “Your grandfather is crazy... he kept me away all night to pack things and tell him stories about you! I did not sleep at all!”

King’s Uncle: “As the head of the imperial family, Lady Yi is a member of the imperial family; her matters should only be dealt with by the imperial family! Do you object, My King?!”

King Benson: *(Tired)* “Please do as you see fit! Maid, go pack Lady Yi's things and send them to the imperial uncle's palace, and help Lady Yi move into my uncle's palace.”

Lady Yi: “So it is really over. I refuse to live in disgrace; there is nothing left for me here... My sister, I will be accompanying you. Let's keep each other company.” *(She runs and hits her head against the wall and dies immediately)*

Maid: “Lady Yi has passed away!”

Queen Rosanna: *(Falls onto her couch)*

King Benson: “Be careful, you are carrying our twins! Maids, take my wife to our inner chambers to rest, and call the imperial doctor to check on her. Lady Yi and Yuri will be buried outside of the imperial tombs, and Yuri's property will be confiscated and put into the imperial treasury!”

Narrator: Yuri is buried without a title, and Lady Yi is buried without a title outside of the imperial tombs. Meanwhile, Imperial Noble Consort Rika in her palace is panicking after finding out that the child she was carrying was a guard’s child.

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Whispering to herself in her isolation palace)* “I already had a miscarriage; the child I was carrying was a servant's child. All my plans are ruined, and the imperial family is already being wiped out! All my supporters are gone... the king will be

coming for me next. Well, if I cannot have him... nobody can. But before I die, Rosanna has to go first!" *(She runs out of her palace, disguises herself as a maid, and escapes)*

Imperial Uncle: *(Talking to the king)* "We should go to the slave village to look for my daughter!"

King Benson: "Yes! I already sent people to look for her to see if she is alive. I found out that Prophet Kafura saved her after the guards' attack, and she is living at the temple with him!"

Imperial Uncle: "Did you tell Queen Rosanna?"

King Benson: "Not yet; I wanted to surprise her... bring her mother to the palace and surprise her! She is heavily pregnant and cannot travel in a carriage to a different city; it will be safer to ask Prophet Kafura to come with Jirmak!"

Imperial Uncle: "You mean Princess Jirmak? It will be nice to have her here before the due date of the pregnancy arrives."

Narrator: Imperial Noble Consort Rika sneaks out of her palace and sneaks into the king's quarters with a knife!

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Hiding as a maid in the king's inner chamber close to Rosanna, looking for an opportunity)* "I need to wait for the right time to attack that seductress!"

Narrator: The king writes a letter to Prophet Kafura to bring Rosanna's mother to the capital for the birth of the twins; Rosanna is eight months pregnant.

Queen Rosanna: "My husband, when are we going to the slave village? I need to go see if my mother and father are still alive."

King Benson: "You are due soon; it is not safe for you to travel. Once the twins are born and it is safe to visit the slave village, we will go together!"

Mystery Voice: "Rosa! Rosanna!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Who is calling me?)* "Mother!!!!!!!!?"

Jirmak: *(Running to hug her daughter, followed by the imperial uncle and Prophet Kafura)* "Rosanna! *Binti mfalme?*!!!!!!!!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Running to hug her mother as her pregnant belly shows proudly)* "Mother!!!"

Jirmak: *(Hugging her daughter and starting to cry)* "I never imagined the Lord would ever return you to me and that I would ever see you again! You are alive, and you are now a queen!!!!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Tears falling on her face as she giggles)* "Yes! Ahahaha! Yes, it is a very long story, but yes!"

Jirmak: "And you are pregnant—I heard that you are carrying twins?!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Crying)* "Yes! A boy and a girl! Where is my daddy? Why is he not with you?!" *(Crying)*

Jirmak: "Let's go inside first; sit down, and we will talk about it! Okay, you are pregnant, and you will be due soon—you have to be careful!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Hiding)* "Why can she have a happy ending, and not me?! Why do things get better for her and worse for me?! I will never allow it... that seductress must pay for everything she has done to me! If she never entered the palace, I would have everything I want... It is all her fault; she must pay for all of this!" *(She runs and holds Rosanna hostage with a knife to her neck)* "Rosanna, you will pay today for what you did to me! You ruined all my plans! Everything that I planned for myself, you must pay for!"

King Benson: "Please put your knife down! Do not harm my wife, I beg you! Please, Rika! Please!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "For her, you put your pride down and beg?!"

King Benson: "She is my life! If she dies, I will die!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Yelling like crazy)* "I hate it! I hate it! That's why she must die! That's why she must go! I lost you because of her! What does she have that I don't?! I am more noble and qualified than her!"

King Benson: "Whatever you say and do, I agree—just put your knife down and let go of my wife, okay?! RiRi?!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "RiRi?! You stopped calling me by this name when I moved into the palace! So you do remember me?!"

Jirmak: "Please let go of my daughter! Take me instead! I just met her; I can't lose her again!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "No! No! No! Shut up! Shut up!! Shut up!!! For everything to go back to normal, she must go... For everything to belong to me, she must!"

Imperial Uncle: "I give you my word! If you let her go and cause no harm to her and the twins, no harm will come to you! You will be set for life!"

King Benson: *(Moving close to Rika)* "RiRi?! Remember? Just look at me... calm down! Let's talk about it calmly!" *(He moves close to Rika, pushes Rosanna toward his uncle, draws a sword, and stabs Rika directly)*

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: *(Bleeding)* "So... I was nothing in your eyes!" *(Tearing up)*

King Benson: *(Looking Rika straight in her eyes)* "You were nobody. You killed my sister, sent my mother to the temple, killed millions of palace workers, used the imperial family to cause me and my queen Rosanna harm, and now you die trying to kill my beloved woman! This is your end... sleep well, Rika!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "So you knew everything from the start?!"

King Benson: "I had my suspicions; I never expected that you were the source from the start!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "I did everything perfectly and succeeded in everything... why not this one?!"

Prophet Kafura: "Because your time is up! You are unrepentant and wicked, and your heart and mind are evil, fueled by greed and a hunger for power!"

Imperial Noble Consort Rika: "So... I lost because of God, hahaha..." *(Falls to the ground and dies)*

Prophet Kafura: *(Narrator)* Suddenly, Queen Rosanna's water breaks, and the twins are on their way out!

Queen Rosanna: *(Yelling)* "The babies are coming! My water broke!"

King Benson: *(Carrying his wife)* "Call the doctor! Call the doctor right now!!!"

Imperial Doctor: *(Running in)* "Bring her to bed, My Queen! You have to push hard. You have two lives inside you! Push harder!"

Queen Rosanna: "Ahhhh! It is hard! AHHHHHH!"

King Benson: "My love, take one big breath and push hard! I got you! Push, my baby! You are strong! Focus!!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Takes a deep breath and pushes with all her might...)*

Imperial Doctor: "I see the head of the baby! You've got this, one more push and it is over!"

Queen Rosanna: *(Pushes hard; the screams of the twins fill the chamber as King Benson weeps tears of joy, holding his children)* "We did it! I did it! Let me hold my babies!" *(She holds them; they have their father's face and Rosanna's nose)*

Princess Jirmak: "I am a grandma now... they are so beautiful! You did well, my daughter!"

Grand Imperial Queen Versta: *(Rosanna's mother-in-law)* "Finally, they are here! Good job, my daughter!"

The Fall of the Rebels and the Ultimate Victory

- **The Trap is Sprung:** King Benson, Queen Rosanna, and the Grand Imperial Grand Consort meticulously corner the corrupt Prime Minister and Commander by using the palace as bait. The rebel forces attack, believing the palace is unguarded, only to discover that the "maids" and "eunuchs" are actually the King's loyal undercover imperial guards and spies.
- **Justice is Served:** The Prime Minister and Commander are defeated and executed, bringing long-awaited vengeance for the fallen and restoring absolute order to the crown.
- **The End of Imperial Tyranny:** Yuri (the ex-Grand Imperial Queen) dies by her own hand in the cold palace after drinking poison, while her twin sister, Lady Yi, ultimately passes away after the full truth of the past royal corruption is laid bare.
- **Rika's Demise:** Imperial Noble Consort Rika's schemes completely unravel when it is revealed that her supposed "royal child" was actually fathered by a palace guard. In a final, desperate attempt at revenge, she sneaks into the King's quarters with a knife to assassinate Rosanna. King Benson outmaneuvers her, rescues his wife, and ends her reign of terror once and for all.

A New Era of Peace and Family

- **The Return of Jirmak:** King Benson arranges for Rosanna's mother, Princess Jirmak, to be brought safely to the capital with the help of Prophet Kafura, finally reuniting Rosanna with her beloved family.
- **The Birth of the Twins:** Immediately following Rika's defeat, Rosanna goes into labor. With King Benson, her mother, and the Grand Imperial Grand Consort by her side, she safely gives birth to healthy twins—a baby boy and a baby girl who share their father's face and Rosanna's nose.
- **Happily Ever After:** The empire is cleansed of corruption, the people pledge their enduring loyalty to the King and Queen, and Rosanna and King Benson step into their season of rest and victory, surrounded by family, love, and a bright future.

The End of Season two of The Song of Rosanna and the Evil King